POST-APOCALYPTIC FRONTIER GOTHIC



TESTAMENT OF DUST

The 2d12 System · Version 2

MASTER RULEBOOK

Roads through a broken world. Blood behind every bargain.

SKROXIOUSDM

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Testament of Dust

The 2d12 System · Version 2 · Master Rulebook

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Testament of Dust is an original setting for the 2d12 System.
Roads through a broken world. Blood behind every bargain.
The 2d12 System draws inspiration from Fate, the Cypher System, :Otherscape, Mouse Guard, Blades in the Dark and the 2d20 System; all trademarks belong to their owners.

Playtest draft — not yet playtested. Set in EB Garamond and Cinzel.

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CHAPTER I

Introduction

The old world is buried beneath the present, but it has not fallen silent. This chapter explains what this book contains, how its rules are named.

Fences of wood and garlic. Laser rifles beside wooden stakes. Somewhere beyond the ridge, an estate light comes on.

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About This Book

This master rulebook collects every current document for *Testament of Dust* and the 2d12 System into one volume. The generic engine comes first; the Frontier setting material builds on it.

Ch.	Chapter	Contents
I	Introduction	Terminology, renamed stats, notation
II	Core Rules	The 2d12 roll, character creation, Tychē Points, Effects, Resistance and recovery, clocks, Truths, Momentum and Woe, the conflict system, playbooks, advancement
III	Optional Modules	Module A Cyphers & Artifacts · Module B The Grind & Travel · Module C Truth-Driven Sandbox
IV	Generic Descriptors	Descriptor rules and 24 setting-neutral Descriptors, six per pool
V	Generic Playbooks	Playbook and equipment rules; Bellator, Furcifer, Savant, Interlocutor, Explorator, Adept
VI	Generic Focuses	Focus rules and 24 setting-neutral Focuses
VII	Frontier Rules	The Frontier setting: Campaign Truths, skills, day and night, vampires, the Bled, afflicted blood, killing methods, old-world works, contracts, conflicts, travel, Woe spends
VIII	Frontier Descriptors	20 Descriptors with Frontier hooks
IX	Frontier Playbooks	Sellsword, Stalker, Frontier Doctor, Broker, Rider, Occultist, Mutant, Cyborg Hunter, Warden
X	Frontier Focuses	20 setting Focuses, including the dhampir Focus
App.	Quick Reference	The roll, Difficulty, outcomes, bonus dice, recovery and the Night at a glance

When a rule here mentions another chapter, it uses that chapter's name and section number. For example, **Core Rules §4.1** means Chapter II, section 4.1. A bare reference such as **§6** points to a section in the same chapter.

Terminology and Renamed Stats

The source documents used the working names on the left. This book uses the house names on the right everywhere: in rules text, tables, abilities, gear and playbook names.

Working name	House name	What it is
Threat	**Woe**	The GM's pool: complications, escalation, vampire Woe spends
Momentum	**Momentum**	The party's shared pool of surplus Power (unchanged)
Fate / Fate Points	**Tychē / Tychē Points**	Each PC's narrative currency: invoke tags, accept compels; set by Refresh
Vitality	**Sōma**	Pool: strength, endurance, toughness. Resists wounds, poison, exhaustion, cold
Alacrity	**Akmē**	Pool: speed, precision, stealth, reflexes. Resists traps, falls, being caught
Mind	**Psychē**	Pool: intellect, perception, memory, cunning. Resists confusion, illusion, deception
Spirit	**Pneuma**	Pool: will, presence, faith, the supernatural. Resists fear, despair, possession, corruption

Working name	House name	Generic core playbook
Bruiser	**Bellator**	Front-line muscle; anchor Fight or Brawl
Operator	**Furcifer**	Infiltrator, scout, thief; anchor Stealth
Sage	**Savant**	Scholar, detective, scientist; anchor Lore or Investigate
Face	**Interlocutor**	Diplomat, con artist, leader; anchor Persuade
Wayfarer	**Explorator**	Ranger, pilot, explorer; anchor Survival
Adept	**Adept**	Mage, psychic, hacker; anchor Arcana or Tech (unchanged)

- **Pool shorthand.** Playbook stat blocks list base pools as **Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne** (Sōma / Akmē / Psychē / Pneuma).
- **Scars** take the name of the pool most tied to the condition that caused them: a **Pneuma Scar**, a **Psychē Scar** (Core Rules §6.3).
- **Names left as they are.** In-world names that use the everyday words keep them, because they describe the fiction rather than a stat: the **Spirit Duel** conflict type, the abilities **Spirit Sight**, **Shared Spirit**, **Steady Mind** and **Archive Mind**, and the Focus **Sends the Mind**

Abroad. Credits to the source games (Fate, Fate Core, 2d20) also keep their original names.

NOTATION

- ★ **Major.** An ability that costs **1 Refresh** when you take it, at creation or through advancement.
- ◆ **Capstone.** Unlocked after **12 Advances** if you have at least 4 abilities from that playbook. It costs no Refresh, and each character can have one.
- ◈ **Weird.** A Focus that assumes the supernatural, old-world works or afflicted blood. On the Frontier every ◈ Focus is allowed, but the marker shows which ones draw the attention of vampire households, Occultists and frightened villagers.
- **Tags** are written in *italics*, such as *marks on my throat*. **Statuses** add a tier, such as *wounded-2*.
- **Difficulty** is written by name and target, such as **Standard 15** or **Hard 18**.

A NOTE ON TONE

The Frontier is gothic horror on a post-apocalyptic frontier: lone riders, dusty towns, shuttered estates, laser rifles beside wooden stakes, blood ledgers and disputed wills, and vampires who are few, long-lived and indispensable. Players can be dhampirs, but not full vampires (Frontier Rules §1).

CHAPTER II

Core Rules

One roll, many outputs. A pair of twelve-sided dice decides whether you succeed, how much Power you earn and whether fate twists. Around that roll: pools that double as stress, tags and Truths, Tychē Points, Momentum and Woe, and scripted conflicts.

Roll 2d12 + Skill + Modifiers vs. Difficulty.

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1. Design Pillars

1. **Every currency has one job.** Four resources, each answering a different question:

Resource	Owner	Job	Borrowed from
Pools (Sōma / Akmē / Psychē / Pneuma)	Each PC	Physical, mental and spiritual cost — Effort and Resistance	Cypher + Blades stress
Tychē Points	Each PC	Narrative authority — invoke tags, accept compels	Fate
Momentum	The party (shared)	Tactical surplus from strong rolls	2d20
Woe	The GM	Mirror of Momentum — complications and escalation	2d20

2. **One roll, many outputs.** A single 2d12 roll tells you whether you succeed, how well (Power), and whether something twists (doubles).
3. **Fiction is mechanical.** Tags (on characters and items) and Truths (on scenes and the world) are the only modifiers. No hidden situational math.
4. **Characters are driven, not just capable.** Beliefs, Goals, and Instincts are the primary engine for earning Tychē Points and XP.

2. Core Resolution

2.1 The Roll

Roll 2d12 + Skill + Modifiers vs. Difficulty.

- **Skill:** +0 to +4 (from the skill pyramid; untrained = +0).
- **Tags:** +1 per relevant **power tag**, **maximum +2 per roll**. −1 per relevant **weakness tag** (no cap).
- **Statuses:** ± the tier of the highest relevant harmful status and the highest relevant helpful status.
- **Truths:** shift Difficulty by steps (§8), not the roll.

Why 2d12 summed: it produces a bell curve (2–24, average 13) — predictable for skilled characters, swingy at the extremes, and big enough that +1 modifiers matter without dominating.

2.2 Difficulty Ladder

Difficulty	Target	Example
Routine	—	No roll; it happens
Easy	12	Climb a knotted rope
Standard	15	Pick a decent lock
Hard	18	Track someone over bare rock
Formidable	21	Talk down a warlord in front of his troops
Heroic	24	Things legends are made of

2.3 Odds Reference

Chance to hit the number needed on the dice (after subtracting your bonuses):

Need on dice	2d12	3d12 keep 2	4d12 keep 2
7+	90%	98%	99%
9+	81%	94%	98%
11+	69%	88%	95%
13+	54%	78%	89%
15+	38%	65%	80%
17+	25%	48%	66%
19+	15%	32%	48%
21+	7%	17%	28%

Example: Skill +3 and one tag (+1) vs. Standard 15 → need 11+ → **69%**, or **88%** with one bonus die.

2.4 Bonus Dice and Effort

You can add d12s to the roll and **keep the best two**. Maximum **+2 bonus dice** (4d12 keep 2) from any combination of:

Source	Cost
Effort (Cypher)	3 points from the relevant pool, minus that pool's Edge (min 0)
Momentum (2d20)	1 for the first die, 2 for the second
Woe (2d20)	Give the GM 1 Woe per die
Help	An ally spends 1 point from a pool and risks sharing the consequences

Effort (revised). Each use of Effort costs 3 − Edge from the relevant pool. You may use Effort a number of times per roll equal to your **Effort Level** (1 at start; 2 and 3 are unlocked by advancement). Each use buys one of:

- **+1 bonus die** — declared before rolling.
- **+1 Power** — declared **after** a Success or Success at a Cost (Cypher's "effort on damage"). It cannot turn a failure into a success.

Example: Effort Level 2 lets you buy one bonus die before the roll, then spend again for +1 Power if you succeed.

2.5 Outcomes

Result	Outcome
Beat the target by 3+ per step	Success with extra Power
Meet the target	**Success** — 1 Power
Miss by 1–3	**Success at a Cost** — 1 Power, but the GM adds a consequence or gains 1 Woe (player's choice of which)
Miss by 4+	**Failure** — the GM makes a move; GM gains 1 Woe

Power = 1 for meeting the target, +1 for every full 3 points over it. Power is spent on **Effects** (§5). Any Power you don't spend becomes **Momentum** (party pool, max 6).

2.6 Doubles (Twists)

If your two **kept** dice show the same number:

- **On a success:** Critical — +1 Power and add a narrative flourish.
- **On a failure or cost:** Complication — the GM gains 2 Woe or introduces a complication right away.
- **Double 12s:** always a success with +2 Power. **Double 1s:** always a complication, even on a success.

Base chance of doubles on 2d12 is about 8% (1 in 12).

3. Character Creation

3.1 The Sentence

> ***"I am a [Descriptor] [Playbook] who [Focus]."***
>
> *"I am a **Reckless Furcifer** who **Never Leaves Anyone Behind**."*

Part	Grammar	What it gives you
Descriptor	Adjective	+2 pool points to one pool, 1 power tag, 1 weakness tag, 1 suggested Instinct
Playbook	Noun	Starting pools and Edge, special abilities, XP trigger, load-out, an anchor skill
Focus	Verb phrase	A tag theme (2 power tags + 1 weakness), a Tier 1 Focus ability, and a link to another PC

3.2 Pools and Edge

Four pools, each roughly 6–14:

- **Starting values:** the playbook sets the base (totals 36), plus 4 points to distribute and +2 from the Descriptor (42 total).
- **Edge:** the playbook gives **3 points of Edge**, maximum 2 in any one pool at creation. Edge reduces the cost of Effort and Resistance from that pool.
- Pools are spent on **Effort** (§2.4) and **Resistance** (§6). They are your stress tracks.

Pool	Covers	Resists
Sōma	Strength, endurance, toughness	Wounds, poison, exhaustion, cold
Akmē	Speed, precision, stealth, reflexes	Traps, falls, being caught or grabbed
Psychē	Intellect, perception, memory, cunning	Confusion, illusion, deception, madness from knowledge
Pneuma	Will, presence, faith, emotional core, the supernatural	Fear, despair, possession, corruption, social pressure

3.3 Skill Pyramid

Ten rated skills from a list of 20:

Rating	Count
+4 Great	1
+3 Good	2
+2 Fair	3
+1 Average	4

The playbook's anchor skill must sit at +3 or +4. The pyramid rule (each tier must have at least as many skills as the tier above it) still applies when you advance.

Generic skill list by default pool:

Sōma	Akmē	Psychē	Pneuma
Athletics	Shoot	Notice	Will
Brawl	Stealth	Investigate	Persuade
Fight	Drive/Pilot	Lore	Intimidate
Endure	Craft	Tech	Empathy
Survival		Medicine	Arcana*
		Deceive	

*Arcana is renamed per setting: Mysticism, Faith, Psionics, Weirdness, or removed entirely in mundane games.

The default pool pays for Effort and Resistance. The GM can allow another pool when the fiction supports it (Intimidate with Sōma = looming; with Pneuma = cold menace).

3.4 Tags

Characters carry 6–8 **character tags** from Descriptor, Focus, and Playbook:

- **Power tags** (e.g. *ex-navy marksman*, *silver tongue*, *grandfather's revolver*): +1 each when relevant, **max +2 per roll**.
- **Weakness tags** (e.g. *owes the wrong people*, *bad knee*): −1 when relevant, or compel for a Tychē Point (§4).
- **Burning a tag:** mark a power tag as burned to gain an automatic +1 Power on a success. It stays unusable until you recover it (a downtime action or a milestone). Burning ignores the +2 cap.

With a +2 cap, a third relevant tag is best used for burning or as Tychē Point invoke material.

3.5 Beliefs, Instincts, Goals

- **Belief** — a moral stance or conviction. "The law protects the powerful; I protect everyone else."
- **Instinct** — an if/then reflex. "Always check the exits when entering a room." Acting on an Instinct lets you take that action without spending time.
- **Goal** — a concrete objective for this session or mission. "Get Mara out of the precinct before dawn."

Goals are rewritten each session; Beliefs and Instincts can change at milestones.

3.6 Starting Resources

- **Tychē Points:** start each session with Tychē Points equal to your **Refresh** (base 3; see §4.1).
- **Load-out:** chosen during play from the playbook's gear list (Blades-style light/normal/heavy load), not bought in advance.

4. Tychē Points

Spend 1 Tychē Point to:

- **Invoke** — reroll all dice, or add +2 after rolling. This works with any tag or Truth you can justify, even one belonging to the scene or an enemy. Invokes are not limited by the tag cap.
- **Declare** — establish a minor fact about the scene. The GM may require it to tie to one of your tags.
- **Resist harder** — reduce one Resistance cost to 0 (§6).

Earn Tychē Points by:

- **Compels** — the GM or another player offers a complication based on a weakness tag, Scar, Belief, or Instinct. Accept → +1 Tychē Point. Refuse → pay 1 Tychē Point.
- **Playing your Belief against your interests** (Mouse Guard): once per session, take +1 Tychē Point when your Belief causes trouble for you.

4.1 Refresh

- **Base Refresh is 3.** At the start of each session, your Tychē Points reset to your Refresh (if you have more, keep them).
- At creation you get **1 playbook ability and your Tier 1 Focus ability for free**.
- You may take **up to 2 additional playbook abilities at creation, at 1 Refresh each**.
- Abilities marked ★ **(Major)** cost **1 Refresh** whenever you take them, including through advancement.
- An **attuned artifact** (Module A) costs 1 Refresh while you keep it.
- **Minimum Refresh is 1.** You can never trade away your last Tychē Point.
- The advancement option "+1 Refresh" (§12) lets you buy Refresh back.

Design intent: power comes at the cost of narrative flexibility. A low-Refresh character is mechanically strong but has to accept compels to stay fuelled.

5. Effects

Effect	Cost	What it does
Attack	1 Power per tier	Inflict a **Status** (e.g. *wounded-2*, *rattled-1*, *on fire-3*). In a conflict, an Attack removes Disposition instead (§10.6)
Weaken	1	Reduce one of the target's statuses by 1 tier, or **Burn** one of its tags for the scene
Create	2	Create a **Truth** that lasts for the scene (*smoke cover*, *crowd on our side*). One extra Power makes it last until resolved
Enhance	1 per tier	Give an ally a helpful status (*inspired-2*)
Restore	1 per tier	Reduce a harmful status on yourself or an ally. Lasting injuries have limits (§6.6)
Discover	1	Ask the GM one question; you get a true, useful answer
Advance	1 per segment	Tick a **progress clock** (§7)
Disrupt	2	Cancel or delay an enemy's prepared action, or take 1 point off the GM's Woe
Extra Feat	1	Achieve a second, related goal with the same action

Each point of Power buys an Effect. Players choose Effects that fit what their character did in the fiction.

Any unspent Power → **Momentum**.

5.1 Statuses

- Statuses have **tiers 1–6**.
- **Stacking:** a new status of the same kind raises the existing tier by the new tier minus 1 (minimum +1), so small hits accumulate slowly.
- **Tier 6:** the target is **Taken Out** of whatever that status represents (dead, unconscious, captured, convinced, routed), within the status's scope. A harmful status reaching tier 6 also gives one **Scar** (§6.3). Death needs a lethal cause and established stakes.
- Statuses modify rolls by ± **their tier** (use only the highest relevant harmful status and the highest relevant helpful status).
- **Same kind.** Harm is the same kind when it worsens the same injury, affliction or condition. Renaming it doesn't stop it stacking: another cut worsens *wounded*, renewed menace worsens *terrified*, but a fresh burn needn't stack with a concussion. The GM says whether new harm stacks **before** you decide to Resist or accept an injury (§10.9).
- **Order.** Resistance and armour reduce incoming harm before it stacks. Harm reduced to tier 0 isn't recorded and doesn't stack. A status can't go above tier 6; extra tiers have no effect unless a rule says so.
- **What it hinders.** A status's name decides which rolls it affects: *slashed thigh-3* hinders running and climbing, not reading a ledger. A status can also decide what is possible: no roll lets you use a hand you no longer have.
- **Life-threatening harm.** A physical status that reaches tier 6 can make you **Dying** when lethal stakes are in play (§6.7).

6. Resistance, Harm and Recovery

When a consequence lands on you (a status, lost gear, a bad position), you may **Resist**:

1. Choose the pool that fits (see §3.2: Sōma for harm, Akmē to dodge, Psychē against deception and confusion, Pneuma against fear and the supernatural).
2. Roll **2d12** and look at the **highest die**.
3. Pay the cost in pool points, **minus that pool's Edge**:

Highest die	Cost	Chance
12	0 (and clear one tier-1 status)	16%
9–11	1	40%
5–8	2	33%

Highest die	Cost	Chance
1–4	3	11%

4. **Effect:** reduce the incoming status by **2 tiers** (to 0 if that brings it below 1), or turn a severe consequence into a lesser one.

Imposed harm, in order. When an effect imposes a harmful status:

1. The GM names the status, its source and its incoming tier, and says whether it stacks with a status you already have (§5.1).
2. If you Resist, add any armour that applies (Playbook Rules §2.3) and pay the cost. A cost you can't fully pay makes you run dry (§6.1).
3. Record what is left with normal stacking. A status reduced to tier 0 isn't recorded.

Once per application. Resist each application of harm once. You can't make a second attempt against the same harm.

What Resistance can't touch. Resistance changes an imposed consequence. It doesn't reverse the action's success, restore lost Disposition or revoke an agreed outcome. Unless an ability says otherwise, you can't Resist:

- ordinary Disposition loss in a conflict (§10.6);
- an injury you accepted to cancel Disposition loss (§10.9);
- a cost you accepted in a concession (§10.11), or any other cost you accepted as payment for a benefit;
- a running-dry status (§6.2).

Protected payments. An effect that prevents incoming harm, cancels a consequence or clears a status as a side benefit (such as the 12 result above) can't remove an injury you accepted as payment, whichever action or Resistance produced it. Treatment, healing time and effects that explicitly heal an existing injury affect it normally (§6.6).

6.1 Running Dry

Trigger. You **run dry** when a positive cost brings a pool to 0 or is more than the points left in it. Finish the action or Resistance that caused the cost, then take a harmful **running-dry status** for that pool (§6.2). Running dry does not, on its own, take you out, give you a Scar or refill the pool.

Overrun. Work out the final cost after Edge, Tychē and every other permitted reduction, then compare it with the points left in the pool:

- **Overrun** = final cost − points left (minimum 0).
- **Incoming status tier** = 1 + overrun (recorded at tier 6 at most).

Spend the points you have. A pool can't go below 0, and the unpaid excess does not move to another pool.

Points left	Final cost	Overrun	Incoming status
3	2	0	None (1 point left)
3	3	0	Tier 1
1	2	1	Tier 2
1	3	2	Tier 3
0	3	3	Tier 4
0	5	5	Tier 6

Overrun beyond tier 6 has no extra effect unless a rule or an established stake says so.

Which costs can overrun. Only **Resistance** and costs **imposed** on you. Effort, Help and ability activation costs must be paid in full unless the ability says it can overrun. You may spend your exact last points on purpose: the pool runs dry and you take a tier-1 status. A cost you accept as payment for a benefit is not an imposed cost.

Pay as you go. Pay each cost at the point its rule says, and resolve any running dry straight away. If that status takes you out, finish only the action or Resistance whose cost caused it: you can't add more Effort, buy more Power or activate more abilities for that action. The action still resolves. If it is one of two independent actions in a volley, both resolve before victory is checked.

Separate costs stay separate. Each cost listed separately is its own payment. You can't split one cost into smaller payments, or combine separate costs, to change overrun or stacking. When one effect takes several points from the same pool at once, total them as one imposed cost unless the effect says otherwise. Costs from different pools are resolved separately.

Resisting on empty. You can Resist with a low or empty pool unless your condition prevents it (§6.4), and the Resistance still takes effect. Resolve protection, the Resistance and the original consequence first, then apply the running-dry status. The new status doesn't penalise that Resistance roll or undo its result.

Zero costs. A final cost of 0 never makes you run dry, even if the pool is already empty. Being at 0 isn't an event in itself: you don't take a new status because time passes, a new turn begins, or you take an action that costs nothing. A later positive Resistance cost or imposed cost can make you run dry again.

Empty pools. An empty pool has no penalty of its own. It doesn't remove Disposition or take you out; its running-dry status does that work. You can keep acting with other resources or with actions that cost nothing. The pool stays at 0 until rest restores it (§6.5). There is no automatic refill.

NPCs. Ordinary NPCs don't have pools and never run dry. Spending Woe on an NPC creates no status, and Woe can't be

overrun: if the GM can't pay an ability's Woe cost, the NPC can't use that ability. An NPC built with full PC pools runs dry normally.

RUNNING DRY IN ORDER

1. Pay each cost when its rule says.
2. If the cost empties or overruns the pool, work out the overrun.
3. Impose that pool's running-dry status at tier 1 + overrun.
4. Stack it with the same status if you already have it (§5.1).
5. At tier 6, apply the status's scope, then record one Scar (§6.3).
6. Recover the pool and the status separately (§6.5).

6.2 Running-Dry Statuses

The status must fit both the pool and the action that drained it:

Pool	Example running-dry statuses
Sōma	*physically exhausted*, *muscular strain*
Akmē	*unsteady*, *reflexes overloaded*
Psychē	*mentally exhausted*, *cognitive overload*
Pneuma	*resolve fractured*, *spiritually drained*

Set it up once. When you first record the status, set its name, its scope and its recovery category (§6.5). The name decides which rolls it hinders.

One status per pool. The first time a pool runs dry, that status becomes the pool's depletion status for the rest of the continuous ordeal. Write the pool beside it. Running dry in that pool again worsens the same status, unless a genuinely different cause calls for a different consequence. A new name or description is not a different cause. Each running-dry event worsens only one status.

Example. You have *mentally exhausted-2* and overrun Psychē by 2. The incoming status is tier 3, which stacks for +2, so you now have *mentally exhausted-4*.

It is a cost. Armour, Resistance and effects that cancel incoming consequences can't prevent or reduce a running-dry status. Once recorded, it can be treated, Restored or healed like any existing status, within the limits of the effect used. A clearing benefit from the same Resistance or action can't clear the status that paid for it.

6.3 Tier 6 and Scars

When a harmful status reaches **tier 6**, whether in one hit or through stacking:

1. Resolve its tier-6 outcome (§5.1).
2. Apply removal within the status's scope (below).
3. Record **one Scar**, subject to the limits below.

Scope. If the status leaves you unable to pursue your side's intent in the current conflict, you are **Taken Out**. Your side's shared Disposition doesn't change (§10.7). If none of a side's participants can continue pursuing its objective, that side loses at once. If the status only stops one activity (*bound* stops you moving, not talking), apply that restriction and stay in the conflict. Set the scope of a non-damage status when it is inflicted, and don't widen it at tier 6. Either way, the status still gives its Scar.

Not lethal by default. A running-dry status at tier 6 is not deadly on its own. Death needs a lethal cause and established stakes. Tier 6 doesn't, by itself, cost you a limb, lower a maximum pool or impose any other permanent loss; those need an established consequence, a specific effect or an agreement.

The Scar. The status records your current condition; the Scar records the lasting mark of reaching the breaking point. The player and GM agree on a Scar that fits what happened. A Scar can't introduce an unrelated injury, dictate an unrelated belief, or extend the opposition's victory beyond the stakes. Label it with the pool most tied to the condition (a *Pneuma Scar*):

Tier-6 status	Possible Scar
physically exhausted	*my old injury gives out under strain*
reflexes overloaded	*hesitates when everything moves at once*
cognitive overload	*gaps in the memory of that night*
terrified	*can't forget what was behind the door*
resolve fractured	*doubts the oath that once sustained me*
bound or *captured*	*can't bear being restrained*

Scar limits.

- **One per episode.** A status gives a Scar the first time it reaches tier 6. More harm while it stays at tier 6, or lowering it and raising it again in the same episode, gives no further Scar.
- **One per event.** A single action or hazard can give a character at most one Scar, even if it takes several statuses to tier 6. Only an ability that says so can give more than one.
- **Scar Recorded.** Mark every status that reached tier 6 in a Scar-giving event as *Scar Recorded* for the rest of the continuous ordeal, even if the status is later cleared. Remove the mark only when the status is fully cleared **and** the scene or ordeal is over. The mark is bookkeeping only, not a status or a penalty.
- Don't split one condition into several differently named statuses to gain or avoid Scars.

Scar effects. A Scar is a lasting weakness tag, not a status. Apply it when it's relevant, and it can be compelled for Tychē Points. Rest, treatment, Restore and pool recovery don't remove a Scar; changing one takes an Advance, a milestone or an explicit ability. If a Scar and a harmful status describe

the same impairment on the same roll, apply only the larger penalty. Your **fourth Scar** retires the character from ordinary adventuring. Finish the immediate scene, then decide with the player how the character leaves. Retirement doesn't mean death.

6.4 Being Taken Out

Three ways out. You are **Taken Out** of a conflict when a harmful status reaches tier 6 within its scope (§6.3), when an effect says so, when you voluntarily withdraw, or when an established circumstance prevents you from pursuing your side's objective (§10.7). Ordinary Disposition loss never takes an individual out. Once you are out, you can't start another action, spend Effort or activate an ability unless its rules let you act while Taken Out.

Disposition stays with the side. Being Taken Out doesn't directly change your side's shared Disposition. Your side loses your skills, abilities and help, and if none of its participants can continue pursuing its objective, it loses at once (§10.7, §10.10).

Out isn't down. Being Taken Out doesn't, on its own, make you unconscious, injured or dying. Describe it to fit the fiction: pinned down, disarmed, driven back, cut off, or too frightened to go on. Injury needs a status, death needs established lethal stakes (§6.7), and permanent harm needs an established consequence (§6.8).

Resisting while out. Being Taken Out doesn't automatically stop you Resisting, but the Resistance must be something you can still do. You can brace against pain while pinned down, but you can't dodge while fully *bound*, or use an act of will while unconscious. When a status first takes you out, finish any Resistance already under way. Resistance can't reverse a defeat, undo an accepted concession, or prevent a cost you accepted as payment. Once a conflict is settled, you can only Resist the consequences that were left open to it; you can't use Resistance to reopen the intent or delay settlement.

Getting back in. To rejoin a conflict that is still going, and that your side hasn't lost, you need both of these:

1. the condition that stopped you must be removed; and
2. an ability or rule must explicitly let a Taken Out character return.

Returning doesn't restore any of your side's Disposition unless the ability says so.

An ordinary Defend can't bring back a Taken Out ally unless its rules say it can. If you recover after the conflict is over, you act normally in the scenes that follow, subject to your remaining statuses.

6.5 Rest and Recovery

There's no separate "short rest" / "full rest" split. Instead, resting escalates through the day — the longer you take, the more you recover:

Rest # (per day)	Time required	Recovery die
1st	A few seconds; 1 action if taken mid-encounter	1d6
2nd	10 minutes	1d8
3rd	1 hour	1d10
4th	10 hours (usually overnight)	Restore all four pools to full

- Roll the listed die and **divide the result among Sōma, Akmē, Psychē, and Pneuma however you like** — it doesn't have to go to whichever pool was drained most recently.
- **Edge does not affect this roll.** Edge only reduces Effort and Resistance cost (§2.4, §6); recovery stays flat so it can't stack with Edge's other benefits.
- After the 4th rest, the cycle resets — your next rest that day (or the start of a new day) is a 1d6 again.
- Each PC rests and rolls independently. If two of five party members stop for 10 minutes to recover, the other three don't have to stop or roll.
- **Running dry has no automatic refill.** A pool at 0 comes back through these rests in the normal way. Its running-dry status recovers separately, as described below.

Recovering running-dry statuses. Restoring a pool doesn't clear its running-dry status, and clearing the status doesn't refill the pool. When you first record the status, choose its category:

- **Depletion** (exhaustion, strain, temporary overload): the default, unless the source makes it an injury or affliction. It recovers through rest, as described below.
- **Injury** (real physical damage): recovers through treatment, Restore and healing time, like any wound.
- **Affliction** (supernatural or ongoing cause): recovers only as its source allows.

Resting off depletion *(playtest value)***.** When you take one of the 1st–3rd rests, you can put the recovery roll toward the pool, toward its depletion status, or split it between them. Every **2 points** removes **1 tier** of the depletion status. Each point counts once. The 4th rest (full restore) also clears any depletion status whose cause has ended. It doesn't clear Scars, injuries or afflictions. Reassurance or first aid can make recovery possible, but can't keep stripping depletion tiers with Restore. Abilities that explicitly restore exhaustion or harmful statuses work as written.

No shortcut. Running dry never gives a special recovery roll, an automatic refill, or a way around the rest cycle. You can't overrun a pool on purpose to replace a bad recovery roll or to jump to a fresh rest stage.

Each layer recovers on its own. Disposition, pools and statuses each recover only through their own procedure:

- **Disposition** is set fresh when a genuinely new conflict begins (§10.2). Fresh Disposition doesn't refill pools or clear statuses, and a brief pause in the same struggle isn't a new conflict.
- **Pools** recover through the rests above. A full pool doesn't heal an injury, and an injury doesn't stop pool recovery unless its rule says so.
- **Statuses** recover by their kind: a temporary state ends when its cause or duration ends; injuries need treatment and time (§6.6); afflictions follow their source.

Winning a conflict, ending a scene or setting fresh Disposition is **not a general reset**.

Advance option — Hardened *(6 XP, one-time)*

Your recovery die steps up one size at every stage, permanently: 1d6→1d8, 1d8→1d10, 1d10→1d12. The 4th rest of the day remains a full restore. This is a flat, single bump — it does not scale further and doesn't interact with Edge, Effort Level, or pool growth from other Advances.

6.6 Treatment and Healing

Appropriate care. Treatment must address the cause of the harm:

Harm	Typical care
Wounds, blood loss, poison	Medicine and suitable supplies
Fear, grief, shock	Empathy, reassurance and safety
Confusion, cognitive disruption	Diagnosis, rest or specialist care
Damaged machines or implants	Science or Craft, tools and access
Curses, possession, corruption	A fitting supernatural method or the source's stated cure

A skill doesn't supply the tools, knowledge or fictional permission on its own.

Routine care. In safe conditions, when failure would add nothing, care needs no roll. It gives permission to treat, stabilises where nothing is uncertain, and meets the conditions for natural recovery. It **generates no Power**. If ordinary treatment could remove one tier of a lasting injury and success is routine, remove that tier and mark the injury *treated* there's no surplus Power or Momentum. Roll only when an uncertain result matters, never just to farm Momentum.

Emergency care stops an injury getting worse: stopping bleeding, splinting a limb, pulling someone away from a harmful influence, isolating a damaged power cell. It doesn't normally reduce the tier. When the outcome is uncertain, roll the treatment skill vs. **Standard 15**, adjusted by Truths. On a success, the deterioration stops or treatment can begin. On a Success at a Cost, the same, with the normal cost. On a failure, the condition is still untreated; the GM announces any further consequence before another attempt.

Restore on lasting injuries. Restore costs 1 Power per tier (§5). It can clear a **temporary** condition outright when the action removes its cause: putting out burning clothes reduces *on fire*, calming an ally reduces fear. **Lasting injuries** are slower:

- Ordinary treatment reduces a given lasting injury by **at most 1 tier**. Mark it *treated*.
- Further ordinary treatment can't reduce it again until a healing interval (below) actually removes a tier from it. Interrupting rest, changing healers, renaming the injury or starting a new scene doesn't clear the mark, and new harm to the same injury doesn't refresh it. A separate injury has its own mark.
- Spare Power buys other fitting Effects or becomes Momentum as normal.
- Abilities, cyphers and items that explicitly heal a stated number of tiers (such as *healing gel*) follow their own text. Abilities that only change the cost of Restore don't lift the 1-tier limit.

Care in a conflict. Treating someone under opposition uses your action. Emergency care can be a Defend only where the conflict type or an ability allows its skill (such as *Battlefield Surgeon*). Restoring Disposition keeps your side in the contest; it doesn't heal an injury unless the action also buys a healing effect.

Healing intervals *(playtest values)***.** Once a lasting injury has had appropriate care and its cause has stopped, safe rest removes one tier per interval. Use the injury's current tier:

Current tier	Safe recovery to remove 1 tier
1	One full night
2	One full day
3	Three full days
4	One full week
5	Appropriate treatment, then one full week
6, not lethal	Remove the incapacitating cause and set a recovery method
6, life-threatening	Stabilise, then definitive care before natural recovery begins (§6.7)

These are game-time intervals, not medical estimates. A full night is the normal overnight rest; a full day is 24 hours in recovery conditions; a full week is seven such days. Intervals can overlap pool rests. Recovery needs shelter, food and care that suit the injury. Light activity is fine; strenuous activity that aggravates the injury stops recovery.

Timing.

- When an injury's tier changes, its next interval uses the new tier.
- If treatment or healing lowers the tier, keep the qualifying time already spent. If that time already meets the new interval, remove one tier and start the next interval at zero. One change can complete only one interval.
- If fresh harm raises the tier, discard progress and start a new interval at the higher tier. Separate injuries don't reset each other.
- A brief interruption pauses recovery; it doesn't erase it. A bad roll on an unrelated action doesn't worsen an injury; that needs a relevant danger or a stated consequence.

Afflictions (poison, disease, possession, curses, ongoing exposure) don't follow the interval table. When the affliction is identified, its source sets what worsens it, what suppresses it, what allows recovery, and whether treatment cures it or only eases the symptoms. *Bled*, *Sun-Sick* and the Thirst keep their own rules (Frontier Rules §6, §7), and vampires keep their blood-based recovery (Frontier Rules §5.2).

6.7 Dying and Stabilisation

Becoming Dying. After Resistance and stacking, life-threatening physical harm that reaches tier 6 makes a living character **Dying**, if lethal stakes allow that outcome (§10.2). It also gives a Scar as normal (§6.3). The character is incapacitated and can't take ordinary actions. Start a **3-segment Dying clock**. There is no extra *dying* penalty; the injury already records the harm. Mental defeat, capture, exhaustion and ordinary fear never start a Dying clock, and a running-dry status is never lethal on its own.

Cadence. When Dying begins, set how the clock advances: at the end of each exchange after the one in which Dying began, during a scripted conflict; or after a stated fictional interval, outside one. The clock advances **because the interval passes**, not because someone attempts treatment. Several characters can act in the same interval without advancing it further. Moving into or out of a scripted conflict carries the existing deadline over; it doesn't advance the clock or grant extra time.

Further harm. Each further unmitigated physical harm that could worsen the mortal injury marks one extra segment, even though the injury stays at tier 6. One action or hazard can mark at most one extra segment. When the third segment is marked, the character dies.

Stabilising. An adjacent character with suitable means rolls Medicine vs. **Hard 18**, adjusted by Truths. An ability or a fitting supernatural method can offer another way.

- **Success:** the patient is stable and the clock stops.
- **Success at a Cost:** stable, with the normal cost.
- **Failure:** still Dying. The attempt uses the action, but doesn't advance the clock.

Stabilising doesn't erase marked segments, reduce the injury, refill pools or return the patient to the conflict. A stable patient can be moved with care. If a new event makes them Dying again, the clock resumes from its recorded segments.

Definitive care. Emergency care can stabilise a tier-6 life-threatening injury but can't lower its tier. Lowering it below tier 6 takes **definitive care**: a suitable procedure, facility or specialist, or an ability or item that explicitly heals the injury (such as *Miracle Worker*, *Not on My Table* or *healing gel*). The GM states what that requires when the injury is assessed and doesn't add requirements once they are met. When definitive care brings the injury below tier 6 and removes its immediate lethal cause, clear the Dying clock.

Immediate death. Use it only when the established outcome leaves no plausible time for rescue, or a specific killing method calls for it (such as a killing strike, Frontier Rules §5.2). Announce that danger before the roll, and allow Resistance, escape or interruption. Once such an outcome is fully resolved, don't add a Dying clock to undo it; equally, don't skip the clock for an ordinary mortal wound just because the description is graphic.

Bled. Blood loss keeps its own tiers 4–6 and its own stabilising rules (Frontier Rules §6). Don't run a Dying clock for *Bled* as well.

6.8 Permanent Harm

Where it comes from. An injury doesn't become permanent just because its tier is high. Permanent harm needs an established permanent-injury stake, a specific effect or creature rule, a voluntary bargain, or a Scar-giving event. Tier 6 always gives a Scar (§6.3), but never by itself severs a limb, destroys an organ, lowers a maximum pool or causes any other permanent mechanical loss.

The wound heals; the loss stays. A permanent change can outlast the injury that caused it. When *severed hand-4* has healed, the hand is still gone: the status measured the acute wound. Record the lasting change as a tag or a character fact, not as a status that never heals.

Adapting. Training, help, prostheses, old-world works or supernatural intervention can change how permanent harm affects play. A replacement doesn't automatically remove a related Scar, and a Scar doesn't make a replacement useless. Don't reduce maximum pools, Edge, skills or Refresh unless the effect or an agreed Advance says so.

7. Progress Clocks

- **Sizes:** 4 (simple), 6 (complex), 8 (daunting), 12 (epic).
- **Player clocks** tick with the **Advance** effect (1 Power = 1 segment).
- **Danger clocks** tick when the GM spends Woe (1 Woe = 1 segment) or on failures.
- **Racing clocks:** two clocks run together (e.g. *Crack the vault 8* vs. *Guards arrive 6*).
- **Linked clocks:** filling one opens or unlocks another.
- **Downtime projects** use 8- or 12-segment clocks.

8. Truths

Truths are tags that describe the scene, location, faction, or campaign.

- **Scene Truths:** *Pitch Dark*, *Knee-Deep Water*, *Hostile Crowd*. Each relevant Truth raises or lowers Difficulty by one step (±3), makes an action impossible or possible, or can be invoked with a Tychē Point.
- **Campaign Truths:** 3–5 world statements agreed at session zero (*Magic is real but feared*, *The Corporation owns the police*).
- **Creating Truths:** players use the **Create** effect or spend **2 Momentum**; the GM spends **2 Woe**.
- **Removing Truths:** use the Weaken or Create effect as a counter ("I kill the lights" removes *Brightly Lit*), at GM discretion.

See **Module C** for using Truths to drive a sandbox campaign.

9. Momentum and Woe

9.1 Momentum (shared by the party, max 6)

Gain: unspent Power from rolls. **Decay:** lose 1 Momentum at the end of each scene.

Spend	Cost
Add a bonus die	1 (first) / 2 (second)
+1 Power on a success	2
Ask the GM a question (Discover)	1
Create a Truth	2
Seize the initiative / change your scripted action in a conflict	2
Reduce Woe by 1	2

9.2 Woe (the GM's pool)

Starting Woe: 2 per PC at the start of a session. **GM gains Woe from:** players buying dice with Woe, Success at a Cost (if chosen), failures (+1), complications from doubles (+2), refused compels, and dangerous scene Truths (+1 per scene).

GM spend	Cost
Complication or minor twist	1
Tick a danger clock	1 per segment
NPC bonus die	1 per die
Activate an NPC/monster special ability	1–3
Create a Truth	2
Reinforcements	1 per minion, 3 for a significant NPC
Interrupt in a conflict (change an NPC's scripted action)	3

10. Conflict System

Every big contest uses full scripting. Small obstacles are handled with a single roll; anything that meets the conflict test below becomes a scripted conflict.

10.1 When It's a Conflict

Use a conflict when **any two** of these are true:

- Both sides have a clear **intent** that excludes the other's.
- The opposition is a **named NPC, a group, or a significant force** (not a single guard or a locked door).
- The outcome would **change the story** (a relationship, a location, a faction, someone's life).
- A single roll would feel **anticlimactic** to the table.

10.2 Setup

1. **Declare intent and stakes:** each side states what it wants if it wins. Establish what losing lets the other side do, whether death, permanent injury or capture is at stake, and what surrender or withdrawal could look like.
2. **Choose the conflict type** (§10.4), which sets the skill for each action.
3. **Disposition:** the leader of each side rolls **2d12 + the type's Disposition skill + the highest Edge in that skill's pool**, divide the result by three (round down). Next,adds +1 per helper, add every flat bonus or penalty to starting Disposition (from abilities, vampire rank, conditions and similar effects). That is the side's **Disposition** (usually 8–11), one shared total for the whole side (§10.7).
4. **Superiority:** reduce the opposing side's starting Disposition by your Superiority (§10.3).
5. **Track** Disposition as a number or a clock.

Intent sets the scope. Beating a side whose intent is to hold a doorway doesn't, by itself, let you kill them all, take everything they carry or achieve some unrelated goal.

Lethal stakes. A lethal outcome must be established before the roll or exchange that can produce it. Stakes can change mid-conflict when circumstances do, but never retroactively: the GM explains the new danger and lets those affected respond before it is resolved. Lethal stakes make death possible; they don't make every hit deadly.

New conflict or the same one? Set fresh Disposition only for a genuinely new conflict: a materially different intent or changed circumstances. Moving through a doorway, switching from a Fight to a Chase, or changing tactics in the same unresolved struggle continues the same conflict; carry over Disposition, used injury trades (§10.9) and Taken Out characters.

10.3 Superiority

Preparation can weaken an opponent's position before a conflict begins. Gain 1 Superiority for each of the following, to a maximum of 3:

- **Know Thy Foe:** Obtain information that reveals an exploitable weakness, motive, fear, or vulnerability.
- **Know Thy Battlefield:** Secure an advantageous position or understand circumstances that materially favour your approach.

- **Know Thy Players:** Put a plan, alliance, resource, or other preparation into place that materially improves your position.

Each category grants Superiority only once. Preparation must apply to the opposing side and the declared stakes of the conflict.

After calculating starting Disposition and applying all other modifiers, reduce the opposing side's starting Disposition by your Superiority, to a minimum of 1. This adjusted value is its starting Disposition for all purposes, including recovery and compromise.

Superiority is not tracked or spent after the conflict begins.

Abilities retain their normal benefits when their results also qualify for Superiority. Evaluate the concrete information, position, or preparation—not the ability's name. Rephrasing one advantage does not create additional categories; additional categories require distinct material advantages. Determine Superiority only at conflict setup.

10.4 Conflict Types

Type	Disposition	Attack	Defend	Feint	Maneuver
Fight	Fight or Brawl	Fight / Brawl / Shoot	Athletics / Endure	Deceive	Notice / Stealth
Chase	Athletics or Drive/Pilot	Athletics / Drive	Athletics / Drive	Stealth	Notice / Survival
Argument	Persuade	Persuade	Will	Deceive	Empathy
Negotiation	Persuade	Persuade	Empathy	Deceive	Investigate
Infiltration	Stealth	Stealth / Tech	Deceive	Craft	Investigate
Battle (armies)	Lore (tactics)	Fight	Endure	Deceive	Lore
Spirit Duel	Arcana	Arcana	Will	Deceive	Lore
Hack / Netwar	Tech	Tech	Tech	Deceive	Investigate
Survive the Wild	Survival	Survival	Endure	—	Notice

Settings can add types; each type needs one skill per action and a Disposition skill. A dash (—) means that action isn't available in that type.

10.5 Scripting and Volleys

Each **exchange** is three **volleys**. Each side secretly **scripts** three actions in order, then they are revealed one volley at a time.

- **Rotation:** every team member must act once in an exchange before anyone acts twice (Mouse Guard rule).
- **Changing your script:** spend 2 Momentum (players) or 3 Woe (GM) to swap one unrevealed action.
- **Independent:** roll against Standard 15 (adjusted by Truths and the opposition's tags).
- **Versus:** both sides roll; the higher total wins, and the margin over the loser's total decides Power (meet = 1, +1 per full 3).

	Attack	Defend	Feint	Maneuve
Attack	Both roll independently	Versus	Attack independent; Feint does nothing	Versus
Defend	Versus	Both roll independently	Feint independent; Defend does nothing	Versus

	Attack	Defend	Feint	Maneuve
Feint	Attack independent; Feint does nothing	Feint independent; Defend does nothing	Versus	Versus
Maneuver	Versus	Versus	Versus	Both roll independently

10.6 Actions and Effects

Action	Default effect of Power
Attack	Each Power removes 1 Disposition from the opposing side
Defend	Each Power restores 1 of your side's Disposition (up to the starting value)
Feint	Each Power removes 1 Disposition from the opposing side; the Feint ignores Defend
Maneuver	Spend Power on: **Impede** (1: opponent −3 on next roll), **Gain Position** (1: +1 bonus die on next roll), **Disarm** (3: remove an action type or burn a key tag for the rest of the conflict), or **Create a Truth** (2)

Effort (including Effort for +1 Power), Momentum, Woe, Tychē Points, tags, and Truths all work normally.

Three layers, three jobs.

Layer	What it measures
Disposition	Whether your side can keep pursuing this conflict's intent. One shared total per side (§10.7). Reduced by Attacks and Feints; restored by Defend
Pools	Your capacity for Effort, abilities and Resistance. Spent by you; restored by rest (§6.5)
Statuses	What has actually happened to you. Inflicted by direct harm, injury trades, hazards and compromise; recovered by treatment and time (§6.6)

Losing one doesn't reduce the others. Apply more than one only when a rule says so.

Conflict attacks. An ordinary successful Attack or Feint removes Disposition, and nothing else: no pool points, no status. Describe the loss to fit the fiction (driven back, an opening lost, cut off, a glancing blow); the description doesn't create an injury. Armour and Resistance don't reduce Disposition loss unless an ability says so.

Direct harm. Outside a conflict, harmful effects inflict statuses (§5, §6). Inside one, an ability or hazard can inflict a status only if it says so; resolve that status separately from any Disposition loss. Don't add harm to an ordinary Attack just because the weapon is dangerous or the narration is violent.

A side at 0 Disposition loses the conflict (§10.7), but its members aren't necessarily harmed (§6.4).

10.7 Shared Disposition

Each side has one Disposition total. Determine it normally, but do not divide it among participants.

Successful Attacks and Feints reduce the opposing side's Disposition. Successful Defend actions restore your side's Disposition, up to its starting total. Ordinary Disposition loss does not inflict statuses, drain Pools, or individually remove participants.

A character stops participating when a status, explicit effect, voluntary withdrawal, or established circumstance prevents them from pursuing the side's objective. Their removal does not directly change shared Disposition.

A side loses when its Disposition reaches zero or none of its participants can continue pursuing its objective. Complete independently resolving actions before checking victory. Resolve mutual defeat and compromise normally.

Injury trades protect shared Disposition, with no more than one participant accepting an injury against each Attack or Feint.

10.8 Conflict Gear

Gear in conflicts is written as an **action tag** that only applies to the listed action(s). It counts toward the +2 tag cap.

Example gear	Tag
Sword, knife	+1 Attack
Shield, cover	+1 Defend
Spear, polearm, rifle with scope	+1 Maneuver
Smoke grenade, false papers	+1 Feint
Damning evidence (Argument)	+1 Attack
Signed treaty draft (Negotiation)	+1 Maneuver

10.9 Accepting Injury

The trade. Injury trades protect your side's shared Disposition (§10.7). Once per character per conflict, when a successful Attack or Feint would reduce your side's Disposition, you may accept a lasting injury to cancel some of that loss. No more than one participant may accept an injury against each Attack or Feint. Declare it before the loss is applied, even if the loss would reduce your side to 0:

Injury you accept	Disposition loss cancelled
Tier 2	1
Tier 3	2
Tier 4	3

Name the injury, say how taking it keeps you in the fight, and record it at once. It must follow from the action: a blade gives *slashed forearm*, not *embarrassed* an occult assault might give *fractured concentration*. The injury stacks normally (§5.1) and must add a real cost: a new relevant status, or a worse one.

You can't:

- pay with an injury you already have, or with a status that has no relevant effect or is wholly covered by an equal or worse status;
- rename, split or file the injury somewhere irrelevant to dodge its cost;
- accept an injury that would take a status to tier 6;
- use the trade after you are Taken Out, or against voluntary costs or loss from Maneuvers, hazards or special effects (unless their rules allow it);
- cancel a status, an execution or any outcome that isn't ordinary Disposition loss, or cancel more loss than the Attack or Feint inflicted;
- invent a bodily injury to pay for a purely logistical setback.

The trade cancels incoming loss. It doesn't restore Disposition already lost or raise your starting Disposition.

It's a payment. Armour, Resistance, cancellation effects and side benefits can't reduce or prevent an accepted injury (§6). It heals through treatment and time like any other injury.

One trade per Attack or Feint. Only one participant's injury can cancel loss from a single Attack or Feint, and each point of loss can be cancelled only once.

Refresh. The trade refreshes only when a genuinely new conflict begins (§10.2).

10.10 Taken Out, Volleys and Mutual Defeat

Finish the action first. Complete all the costs, choices and effects of the action being resolved before applying removal it causes. After that, the removed character can't act (§6.4).

Independent actions. When two actions resolve independently in the same volley, both resolve even if one takes someone out. Neither cancels the other. Check victory after both.

Side defeat. When a side's Disposition reaches 0, or none of its participants can continue pursuing its objective, that side loses (§10.7). The winner achieves its intent, subject to compromise (§10.12). Don't make the losing side play out the same contest again; a new conflict needs a materially different intent or changed circumstances.

Mutual defeat. If both sides reach 0 in the same volley, neither wins outright. Resolve the compatible parts of both intents and a shared setback within the stakes. No compromise is calculated.

10.11 Conceding

Offer it before the roll. Before the next roll, a side may offer a concession instead of fighting on. State what the other side gains, what the conceding side keeps, what injuries, losses or obligations it accepts, and how the conflict ends. It must give the other side a meaningful success and fit the fiction: a mindless predator doesn't take surrender, so against one the offer may need an escape route or a sacrifice. If the sides don't agree, the conflict goes on. You can't offer a concession after the deciding roll.

Settle it. An accepted concession ends the conflict. Apply its terms with no roll to see whether they happen, and don't also apply compromise unless the terms include it. Costs accepted in a concession can't be Resisted or prevented afterwards; injuries in the terms heal normally. Conceding gives no automatic Tychē Point.

10.12 Compromise

When one side hits 0 Disposition, the conflict ends. The winner gets their intent but **pays a compromise** based on how much Disposition they have left:

Winner's Disposition Left	Compromise
Full or nearly full	None or trivial
More than half	Minor — loser gets a small concession; winner takes a tier-2 status
Less than half	Significant — loser gets part of its intent; winner takes tier-3 statuses or loses gear
1–2 points	Major — near pyrrhic victory; tier-4 statuses, a lost ally, or a new danger clock

Settling the outcome.

1. Determine the winner and the compromise.
2. State what the winner achieves and what the loser keeps or gains.
3. State every cost in full: who receives each injury and at what tier, and any non-injury costs. If there are alternative costs, state them now.
4. Credit existing injuries (below).
5. Resolve Resistance against what remains.

The listed tier doesn't apply to every member of the winning side; the costs say who pays.

Existing injuries count once. An injury taken during this conflict, including one accepted through the trade, pays for one injury cost assigned to that character if its current tier equals or exceeds the required tier. Each injury pays for one cost only. Injuries can't be pooled, split, moved between characters or credited against a non-injury cost. An injury already treated below the required tier no longer pays. Don't add injury costs because an existing injury pays for one.

Resisting compromise. Players may **Resist** imposed compromise statuses as usual (§6), except costs they agreed to. Resistance can reduce or remove the injury, but it doesn't revoke the loser's gain or any other stated cost. Don't add a replacement cost because Resistance removed an injury.

10.13 NPCs and Harm

- **No injury trade.** Ordinary NPCs and minion groups can't use the injury trade. A named rival built as a full PC can; any other NPC needs a trait that grants it.
- **Resisting.** Ordinary NPCs don't have pools (§6.1). An NPC reduces harm only through its listed armour, traits or abilities. Even then, it gets at most one reduction per imposed status application, and that reduction can't touch Disposition loss or an accepted payment.
- **Defeat.** An NPC side at 0 Disposition is defeated in this contest. Capture, escape, injury or death follow the stakes and the outcome. Use a Dying clock for an NPC only when rescuing them matters to play, and never use that shortcut to make a rescue impossible after offering it as a goal.
- **Special creatures.** Specific rules win: vampires keep *Hard to Kill*, killing strikes and blood-based recovery (Frontier Rules §5.2); machines and cyborgs shut down and are repaired rather than dying. An immunity stops an

unsuitable status, but not Disposition loss in a contest the creature can lose.

10.14 Order of Resolution

1. Establish intent, stakes and exits (§10.2); set starting Disposition and apply Superiority (§10.3); script the volley.
2. Pay pre-roll costs (Effort for dice, Help); resolve any running dry (§6.1).
3. Roll and determine the result and Power.
4. Make post-roll choices (Effort for Power) and pay them; resolve any running dry.
5. Separate Disposition loss from statuses imposed by a rule.
6. Offer eligible injury trades (§10.9).
7. Apply the remaining Disposition loss.
8. Resist imposed statuses (§6); pay; resolve running dry from Resistance.
9. Stack what remains; resolve tier 6: scope, Scar, Dying (§6.3, §6.7).
10. Resolve any independent action in the same volley.
11. Check removal, victory and mutual defeat. Before the next roll, either side may offer a concession.
12. Settle compromise (§10.12).
13. Afterwards, recover each layer by its own procedure (§6.5, §6.6).

Which rule wins.

1. Explicit amendments and replacements in this damage cycle.
2. Current creature-specific rules and explicitly revised abilities.
3. The general procedures of this damage cycle.
4. Earlier general rules.

A rule overrides another only on the subject it addresses. An ability that heals a status doesn't also restore Disposition, refresh an injury trade or erase a Scar.

10.15 Keeping It Fast

- Disposition of 4–7 should resolve in one or two exchanges.
- NPC sides script on index cards; minions act as a single group with one script.
- Table guideline: about 15–20 minutes per conflict.

II. Playbooks

Each playbook is a one-page sheet with:

- **Base pools and Edge**
- **Anchor skill** (must be +3 or +4)
- **Special abilities:** 1 free at start (6–8 options); more cost Refresh at creation or come from advancement. Major abilities are marked ★.
- **XP trigger:** one playbook-specific behaviour that earns XP
- **Load-out list:** playbook items plus generic items, Blades-style light/normal/heavy load
- **Relationship prompts:** 1 ally and 1 rival

Settings rename and reskin playbooks (Adept becomes "Hedge Witch" in fantasy, "Netrunner" in cyberpunk) but keep the structure.

II.1 Generic Core Playbooks

Playbook	Anchor	Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	XP trigger	Concept
Bellator	Fight or Brawl	12/10/6/8	Address a challenge with force or threats	Front-line muscle
Furcifer	Stealth	8/12/8/8	Address a challenge with stealth or precision	Infiltrator, scout, thief
Savant	Lore or Investigate	7/8/13/8	Address a challenge with knowledge or insight	Scholar, detective, scientist
Interlocutor	Persuade	7/9/9/11	Address a challenge with charm, lies, or bargaining	Diplomat, con artist, leader
Explorator	Survival	11/11/7/7	Address a challenge with endurance or the land	Ranger, pilot, explorer
Adept	Arcana or Tech	7/8/9/12	Address a challenge with your powers or gadgets	Mage, psychic, hacker

12. Advancement

12.1 Earning XP (end of session)

1 XP per "yes" unless noted:

- Did you hit your **playbook XP trigger**? (1, or 2 if it happened in a desperate scene)
- Did you **accomplish your Goal**? (+2)
- Did your **Belief** drive a meaningful decision?
- Did your **Instinct** get you into trouble or save the day?
- Did you face consequences from a **weakness tag or Scar**?

MVP vote: the table votes on one standout moment each session; that player gets +1 Tychē Point at the next session (above Refresh).

12.2 Spending XP (every 6 XP = 1 Advance)

- +1 to a skill (following the pyramid rule)
- +3 to one pool, or +1 Edge (max 3 Edge per pool)
- A new playbook special ability (★ abilities also cost 1 Refresh)
- A new power tag, or rewrite a weakness tag into a power tag
- **+1 Refresh** (buys back Refresh spent on abilities or artifacts; max base 3 + 1 per 3 Advances)
- A Focus ability from the next tier (requires 3 Advances per tier)
- **+1 Effort Level** (to Level 2 after 3 Advances; Level 3 after 9 Advances)

13. Example of Play

Kade, a *Reckless Furcifer who Never Leaves Anyone Behind* (Akmē Edge 1, Effort Level 2), is creeping through a warehouse to free a captured friend. Scene Truths: *Dim Lighting*, *Patrolling Guards*.

- **Roll:** Stealth +3, power tag *quiet boots* +1, power tag *knows this district* +1 (tags capped at +2). The GM sets Hard 18 but *Dim Lighting* lowers it to Standard 15. Kade needs 10+ on the dice.
- **Effort, part 1:** Kade spends 3 − 1 Edge = 2 Akmē for a bonus die → 3d12 keep 2.
- **Result:** dice show 9, 9, 4 → keep 9 + 9 = 18, +5 = 23. That's 8 over → **3 Power**, plus **doubles on a success → +1 = 4 Power**.
- **Effort, part 2:** Kade spends another 2 Akmē for **+1 Power → 5 Power**.
- **Spend:** Advance the *Reach the Cell* clock by 3 (3 Power), Discover (1 Power): "Where is the key?" — "On the sergeant's belt." 1 Power left → **+1 Momentum**.
- **Later:** the sergeant's dread patron, a bound spirit, lashes out with *terror-3*. Kade Resists with **Pneuma** (Edge 0): highest die 7 → cost 2 Pneuma. The status drops to *terror-1*.
- **Compel:** the GM compels *Reckless*: "You can't wait for backup; you go in now." Kade accepts and gains +1 Tychē Point.

14. Design Notes — What Was Kept, Changed, Cut

Source	Kept	Changed	Cut
Fate	Skill pyramid, Tychē Points, invoke/compel, Refresh as cost of power	Aspects are replaced by tags and Truths	Fudge dice, stress boxes
Cypher	Pools, Edge, the sentence, Effort on rolls and on Power, cyphers and artifacts (Module A)	Four pools instead of three; Effort buys bonus dice instead of lowering difficulty	d20 task levels, GM intrusions (replaced by compels and Woe)
:Otherscape	Power/weakness tags, statuses with tiers, effects, burning tags	Power comes from roll margin; tag cap +2	Themebooks, Improve/Abandon tracks
Mouse Guard	Full conflict scripting, Disposition, compromise, BIG, weapons as action bonuses, the Grind (Module B)	Disposition from 2d12; actions spend Power	Nature, Persona
Blades	Playbooks, resistance, stress-as-currency, clocks, load-out	Stress tracks are the four pools	Action dice pools, Position/Effect grid, crew sheets
2d20	Momentum, Woe, Truths, sandbox Truth tools (Module C)	Momentum from unspent Power; Truths shift Difficulty	d20 roll-under, complication range

14.1 Known Risks

- **Currency load:** pools + Tychē + Momentum + Woe is the upper limit for medium crunch. Keep spend menus short on the sheet.
- **Modifier range (revised):** max is skill +4, tags +2, helpful status up to +6, Tychē invoke +2. Statuses are now the largest swing. Playtest a ±3 status cap.
- **Effort for Power** may make high-Edge characters very efficient. Watch Edge-3 pools where Effort is free; consider a minimum cost of 1.
- **Four pools** means more pool points to track. The sheet should put all four in one row with Edge beside each.
- **Conflict length:** with scripting used for every big contest, the conflict test (§10.1) is what stops overuse.
- **Running dry (revised R3):** running dry now imposes a status at tier 1 + overrun instead of an automatic Taken Out, and a Scar comes from tier 6 instead of from an empty pool. Playtest the 2-recovery-points-per-tier rate for depletion statuses, the one-Scar-per-event limit, and how often Resisting at an empty pool reaches tier 4 or higher.
- **Damage cycle (unified):** watch whether the once-per-conflict injury trade (tier 2/3/4 cancels 1/2/3 loss) is a hard choice or always taken, and whether it drags conflicts out. Also test the compromise tiers (now 2/3/4), the healing intervals, the 3-segment Dying clock, and whether the 1-tier treatment limit makes Restore-cost abilities (*Field Medic*, *Field Surgeon*) feel too weak against lasting injuries.

- **Shared Disposition:** each side now has one Disposition track (§10.7), so ordinary loss no longer removes individuals. Simulated mirrored fights ran about 23.5% shorter than with personal Disposition, but the old rolled 7–12 track still ran long against a one-to-two-exchange target. Setup is now halved again (§10.2): in simulation this averaged about 6 (range 3–9) and about 6 volleys, close to a fixed track of 6. Flat starting bonuses and penalties from abilities and vampire rank are applied before the second halving, so they keep roughly their old weight. Compare this with a fixed track of 5 in play. Also watch whether a lone remaining participant acting repeatedly feels heroic or too forgiving, and whether larger parties get too many injury trades.
- **Superiority:** up to 3 Superiority against a starting track of about 6 can halve the opposition before the first volley. Watch whether preparation becomes routine, how often both sides claim it, and whether it double-counts preparation abilities such as *Ambusher* and *The Reveal*.

CHAPTER III

Optional Modules

Three drop-in modules for longer campaigns: one-use cyphers and dangerous artifacts, the grinding cost of travel and hardship, and a sandbox where the world itself is written in Truths.

Use any, all, or none. On the Frontier, all three are recommended.

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Module A — Cyphers & Artifacts (Cypher)

Cyphers are frequent, disposable power-ups that encourage players to use them rather than hoard them. Artifacts are rare, reusable items that may run out.

A.1 Cyphers

Sample cypher table (d12):

d12	Cypher	Tier	Effects
1	Healing salve / med-gel	2	Restore
2	Smoke charge	2	Create (*smoke cover*)
3	Flashbang / thunderstone	3	Attack (dazed), Weaken
4	Truth serum / mind-read charm	2	Discover ×2
5	Adrenal shot	3	Enhance (surging), restore 3 Sōma
6	Lockbreaker	3	Advance (any lock or security clock)
7	Ward token	3	Negate one incoming status of tier 3 or less
8	Phase key	4	Create Truth (*passage through the wall*) for one scene
9	Courage draught	2	Restore (fear), restore 2 Pneuma
10	Seeker	2	Discover (location of one person or object)
11	Firebomb	4	Attack (on fire), Create (*burning*)
12	Wild card	d6	Player names a reasonable Effect; GM sets the form

- **What they are:** one-use items or effects — potions, grenades, scrolls, nanite injectors, blessed relics, strange tech. Each has a **tier (1–6)**.
- **Using one:** an action, usually with **no roll**. The cypher generates **Power equal to its tier**, spent only on the Effects listed on the cypher. Some create a Truth or a story tag instead.
- **Cypher Limit:** each PC can carry **2** cyphers (some playbooks or Focuses grant 3).
- **Over the limit:** at the end of each scene, the GM gains 1 Woe per extra cypher and may trigger a **Volatile** result (roll d12: 1–4 one cypher fires randomly; 5–8 one cypher is ruined; 9–12 nothing happens yet).
- **Subtle cyphers** (setting option): instead of physical objects, cyphers are luck, insights, or favours ("a contact owes you", "a flash of insight"). They work the same way and fit low-magic or modern games.
- **GM pacing:** give out 1–2 cyphers per PC per session. They should feel like loot that gets spent.

Cypher format:

> ***Flashbang*** *(Tier 3)* — Effects: *Attack (dazed), Weaken.* Form: *palm-sized canister.* ***Draught of Iron Skin*** *(Tier 2)* — Effects: *Enhance (armoured), Restore. Lasts one scene.*

A.2 Artifacts

- **What they are:** reusable items of real power — a flaming sword, a psychic amplifier, a starship's AI core.
- **Tags:** an artifact has 1–2 power tags (counting toward the +2 cap) and usually a special ability.
- **Depletion:** each artifact has a depletion rating, e.g. **1 in d12**. After each use, roll d12; on that number or lower, it is **depleted** (broken, drained, or needs a downtime clock to restore).
- **Attunement:** powerful artifacts (marked ★) must be attuned and **cost 1 Refresh** while attuned (§4.1). A PC can attune to a maximum of 2 artifacts.
- **Artifact quirks:** each artifact has a weakness tag that can be compelled for Tychē Points (*thirsts for blood*, *talks too much*, *draws the Hunters*).

Artifact format:

> ★ ***Ember-Brand*** *(longsword)* — Tags: *blade of living flame, +1 Attack (conflict gear).* Ability: *spend 1 Power to add* burning *to any status you inflict.* Depletion: *1 in d12 (goes cold until bathed in a forge).* Quirk: cannot be hidden.

Module B — The Grind & Travel (Mouse Guard)

The Grind turns time, distance, and hardship into slow, steady pressure. It pairs with Mouse Guard's GM's Turn / Players' Turn structure.

B.1 Session Structure

Phase	What happens
GM's Turn	The mission. The GM presents obstacles; every roll counts as a **turn** on the Grind clock.
Players' Turn	Downtime after the mission. Players spend **Checks** to take actions: recover, research, craft, pursue Goals.

B.2 The Grind Clock

- During the GM's Turn, the GM keeps a **Grind clock** visible to the table.
- **Each roll** (including conflict actions as a group = 1 tick per exchange) ticks it by 1.
- **Size by hostility:** 4 (harsh: desert, deep winter, the underworld), 6 (normal wilderness or dangerous city), 8 (gentle or well-supplied).
- **When it fills:** every PC gains the next **Grind condition** they don't have yet, then the clock resets. The GM may also spend 2 Woe to tick it.

B.3 Grind Conditions (taken in order)

Order	Condition	Effect	Cleared by
1	**Hungry & Thirsty**	Short rests restore nothing	A meal, a Survival roll (Restore)
2	**Weary**	Effort costs +1	A full night's rest
3	**Exposed** (cold, heat, wet)	−1 Sōma Edge	Shelter and a recovery roll
4	**Shaken**	−1 Pneuma Edge; Fear statuses +1 tier	A Will or Empathy recovery roll, or a Belief moment
5	**Sick**	−1 to all rolls; can't recover pools	Medicine roll (Hard) + rest
6	**Broken**	Taken Out of the mission; gain a Scar	Players' Turn only

Grind conditions are statuses for Restore, but **they don't stack** — each is a separate condition.

B.4 Checks (Players' Turn)

- **Earn Checks** during the GM's Turn by **applying one of your weakness tags or Scars to your own roll** (−1). You earn 1 Check, or 2 if the penalty makes the roll fail.
- **Everyone gets 1 free Check** in the Players' Turn.
- **Spend 1 Check** for one Players' Turn action: a recovery roll against a Grind condition or status, a downtime clock roll, a research or crafting roll, restoring a burned tag, attuning an artifact, or a scene that pursues your Goal.
- **Sharing:** you can give a Check to another PC whose scene you take part in.

This makes weaknesses a deliberate resource: hurt yourself now to earn recovery and downtime later.

B.5 Travel

A journey is a **Journey clock** (6 for a short trip, 8 for a hard trip, 12 for an expedition). Each **leg** (a day or a stage), the party assigns **roles**; each role makes one roll:

Role	Skill	On success, spend Power on
Guide	Survival or Drive/Pilot	**Make Time** — Advance the Journey clock
Scout	Notice or Stealth	**Spot Trouble** — Discover, or cancel one encounter the GM has prepared
Quartermaster	Survival or Craft	**Forage / Ration** — clear Hungry for the party, or +1 Supplies
Lookout	Notice or Will	**Keep Watch** — the party isn't surprised; Restore Shaken

- **Supplies:** the party has **Supplies** as a status (start at 3–6). Lose 1 per leg. At 0, everyone becomes Hungry & Thirsty automatically and the Grind clock size drops by 2.
- **Terrain and weather** are Truths that set Difficulty (*Muskeg*, *Whiteout*, *Rapids*, *Washed-out Road*).
- **Encounters:** the GM spends Woe (1 for a minor encounter, 3 for a major one), or uses the Scout's failed roll.
- **Portages and hard stretches:** a special leg (Endure or Athletics roll for every PC); failure ticks the Grind clock twice.

Module C — Truth-Driven Sandbox (2d20)

Truths become the backbone of an open-world campaign: regions, sites, and factions are defined by Truths that players can discover, exploit, and change.

C.1 Truth Layers

Layer	Example	Lifespan
Campaign	*The old empire's roads still hold its magic*	Changes only through major arcs
Region	*Lawless borderland*, *Endless rain*	Changes through faction clocks
Site	*Flooded lower levels*, *Ghosts guard the vault*	Changes when PCs act on them
Scene	*Pitch Dark*, *Hostile Crowd*	One scene

C.2 Site Sheets

Each location gets a short sheet:

- **3 Truths** (at least one hidden)
- **A Woe seed:** 1–3 Woe the GM adds when the party arrives
- **A danger clock** (what happens if the party lingers)
- **A secret** (something worth discovering)
- **Rumours** (see C.4)

C.3 Truth Generator Tables (d12)

Roll once per column or pick.

d12	Terrain / Feature	Atmosphere	Hazard	Secret
1	Ruined fortification	Eerie silence	Unstable ground	Hidden passage
2	Dense forest	Constant rain	Disease	A traitor among allies
3	Flooded lowland	Oppressive heat	Predators	Buried treasure
4	Market town	Festival crowds	Watchful authorities	A forgotten god sleeps here
5	Mountain pass	Biting wind	Rockfall	Smuggling route
6	Abandoned facility	Flickering lights	Toxic air	Experiment gone wrong
7	River crossing	Thick fog	Rapids	Drowned village below
8	Sacred grove	Watched by unseen eyes	Spirit anger	A pact with the old powers
9	Frontier camp	Desperation	Bandits	Someone is not who they claim
10	Underground ways	Echoes	Collapse	Lost civilisation
11	Noble estate	Hollow luxury	Political danger	Blackmail ledger
12	Wasteland	Unnatural stillness	Exposure	Gateway to elsewhere

C.4 Rumours

A **rumour** is an unconfirmed Truth. When players confirm it (Discover, investigation, or arriving), the GM rolls d12:

d12	Result
1–4	**False** — and someone benefits from spreading it
5–8	**Twisted** — partly true, with a dangerous difference
9–12	**True** — becomes a Truth

C.5 Faction Turns

Between sessions (or each in-world week), the GM takes a **World Turn**:

1. Each active faction rolls **2d12 + its rating (+1 to +4)** vs. Standard 15 for its current project.
2. Power ticks the faction's **project clock** (6 or 8 segments).
3. When a clock fills, the faction **creates, removes, or changes a Region or Campaign Truth** (e.g. *The Guild controls the river* replaces *The river is free*).
4. PCs who hear about it can respond; PC actions can tick faction clocks forward or back using Advance.

C.6 Player Influence on Truths

- **Discover** effects and Momentum spends reveal hidden Truths.
- **Create** effects and 2 Momentum create Scene Truths; bigger changes need a progress clock (8 segments for a Site Truth, 12 for a Region Truth).
- Major arcs can rewrite Campaign Truths. These are the "legacy" moments of the campaign.

CHAPTER IV

Generic Descriptors

Twenty-four setting-neutral adjectives open the sentence: "I am a [Descriptor]..." Six belong to each pool. Each one gives +2 to that pool, a power tag, a weakness tag and a suggested Instinct. The Frontier Descriptors in Chapter VIII are written for the Frontier.

The adjective of the character sentence.

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3. Descriptors 29

1. Descriptor Rules

Each Descriptor gives (Core Rules §3.1):

Element	Detail
Pool bonus	+2 to one pool
Power tag	1
Weakness tag	1 (can be compelled for Tychē Points)
Suggested Instinct	Use it or write your own

Each entry also has a **hook**: one question to answer at character creation. The answer often becomes your first Belief or a relationship.

Every Descriptor works in any genre. Choose one from this chapter or, in a *Testament of Dust* game, from the Frontier Descriptors.

2. Quick Reference

#	Descriptor	Pool	Power tag	Weakness tag
1	Burly	Sōma	*built like a door*	*too big to hide*
2	Charismatic	Pneuma	*the room turns to me*	*needs to be liked*
3	Compassionate	Pneuma	*a kind word opens doors*	*can't turn away suffering*
4	Cunning	Psychē	*three moves ahead*	*trusts no one's plan but mine*
5	Curious	Psychē	*has to know why*	*pokes at what's best left alone*
6	Furtive	Akmē	*keeps to the edges*	*uneasy in the open*
7	Hardy	Sōma	*shrugs off the cold*	*ignores my own injuries*
8	Haunted	Pneuma	*has seen the dark*	*the past won't stay buried*
9	Light-Fingered	Akmē	*quick hands*	*can't resist a pocket*
10	Loyal	Pneuma	*stands by my own*	*blind to my friends' faults*
11	Methodical	Psychē	*measures twice*	*slow under pressure*
12	Nimble	Akmē	*light on my feet*	*too quick to trust my footing*
13	Observant	Psychē	*misses nothing*	*distracted by detail*
14	Reckless	Sōma	*charges in first*	*never looks before leaping*
15	Relentless	Sōma	*never stops coming*	*doesn't know when to quit*
16	Resolute	Pneuma	*iron will*	*rigid when plans change*
17	Restless	Akmē	*can't sit still*	*poor at waiting*
18	Scholarly	Psychē	*well read*	*lives in books, not boots*
19	Serene	Pneuma	*calm in the storm*	*slow to anger, slower to act*
20	Sly	Akmē	*always an angle*	*nobody takes my word*
21	Steady	Akmē	*hands like stone*	*slow to start*
22	Stubborn	Sōma	*will not be moved*	*can't admit I'm wrong*
23	Suspicious	Psychē	*notices what's off*	*sees enemies everywhere*
24	Weathered	Sōma	*seen worse than this*	*old wounds ache*

3. Descriptors

1. Burly

> *You fill doorways. People step aside before you ask.*

- **Pool:** +2 Sōma
- **Power tag:** *built like a door*
- **Weakness tag:** *too big to hide*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If something is heavy, I pick it up myself."

- **Hook:** What did you carry, haul or break before this life began?

2. Charismatic

> *When you speak, people stop and listen, whether they want to or not.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *the room turns to me*
- **Weakness tag:** *needs to be liked*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If a crowd gathers, I take the stage."
- **Hook:** Who once followed you, and where did you lead them?

3. Compassionate

> *You have never walked past someone in pain. You have paid for that more than once.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *a kind word opens doors*
- **Weakness tag:** *can't turn away suffering*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If someone is hurting, I stop to help."
- **Hook:** Whose suffering did you fail to ease, and does it still weigh on you?

4. Cunning

> *You see the board, the pieces and the hand moving them.*

- **Pool:** +2 Psychē
- **Power tag:** *three moves ahead*
- **Weakness tag:** *trusts no one's plan but mine*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If someone offers a deal, I look for the catch."
- **Hook:** Whose plan did you once see through, and what did it cost them?

5. Curious

> *A locked door is a question. You've never been good at leaving questions alone.*

- **Pool:** +2 Psychē
- **Power tag:** *has to know why*
- **Weakness tag:** *pokes at what's best left alone*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If something is hidden, I look inside."
- **Hook:** What secret did you uncover that you wish you hadn't?

6. Furtive

> *You keep to walls and corners. Being noticed has never gone well for you.*

- **Pool:** +2 Akmē
- **Power tag:** *keeps to the edges*
- **Weakness tag:** *uneasy in the open*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If I enter a room, I check the shadows first."
- **Hook:** Who are you keeping out of sight of, and why?

7. Hardy

> *Cold, hunger and pain are old companions. You've learned to walk on with them.*

- **Pool:** +2 Sōma
- **Power tag:** *shrugs off the cold*
- **Weakness tag:** *ignores my own injuries*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If I'm hurt, I keep going until the job is done."
- **Hook:** What hardship did you survive that killed others?

8. Haunted

> *Something from your past follows you. Some nights you can almost hear it.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *has seen the dark*
- **Weakness tag:** *the past won't stay buried*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If I'm alone at night, I keep a light on."
- **Hook:** What did you see that you can never forget?

9. Light-Fingered

> *Things find their way into your hands. You rarely remember deciding to take them.*

- **Pool:** +2 Akmē
- **Power tag:** *quick hands*
- **Weakness tag:** *can't resist a pocket*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If something valuable is left unattended, I take it."
- **Hook:** What is the one thing you stole that you can never give back?

10. Loyal

> *You chose your people. Nothing will make you abandon them.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *stands by my own*
- **Weakness tag:** *blind to my friends' faults*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If someone I trust is threatened, I step between them and it."
- **Hook:** Who did you swear to stand by, and have they earned it?

11. Methodical

> *Haste makes mistakes. You check everything twice and trust your notes.*

- **Pool:** +2 Psychē
- **Power tag:** *measures twice*
- **Weakness tag:** *slow under pressure*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If I'm unsure, I make a list."
- **Hook:** What disaster taught you never to skip a step?

12. Nimble

> *You move like water, over walls and through gaps others never see.*

- **Pool:** +2 Akmē
- **Power tag:** *light on my feet*
- **Weakness tag:** *too quick to trust my footing*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If the ground gives way, I move before I think."
- **Hook:** What did you learn to escape from, and who taught you?

13. Observant

> *You notice the scuffed boot, the nervous glance, the window left open.*

- **Pool:** +2 Psychē
- **Power tag:** *misses nothing*
- **Weakness tag:** *distracted by detail*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If I enter a place, I count the exits and the people."
- **Hook:** What small detail once saved your life?

14. Reckless

> *Thinking is for later. Right now, something needs doing.*

- **Pool:** +2 Sōma
- **Power tag:** *charges in first*
- **Weakness tag:** *never looks before leaping*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If there's danger ahead, I go at it head-on."
- **Hook:** Who got hurt the last time you charged in?

15. Relentless

> *You don't stop. Not when you're tired, not when you're hurt, not when it's hopeless.*

- **Pool:** +2 Sōma
- **Power tag:** *never stops coming*
- **Weakness tag:** *doesn't know when to quit*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If I start a chase, I finish it."
- **Hook:** What did you chase and never catch?

16. Resolute

> *Your word is iron. Once you decide, the world bends or breaks against you.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *iron will*
- **Weakness tag:** *rigid when plans change*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If I give my word, I keep it."
- **Hook:** What promise are you still keeping, and to whom?

17. Restless

> *Stillness itches. You need to move, act, see what is over the next hill.*

- **Pool:** +2 Akmē
- **Power tag:** *can't sit still*
- **Weakness tag:** *poor at waiting*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If things go quiet, I go looking for trouble."
- **Hook:** What place could never hold you, and who did you leave there?

18. Scholarly

> *You have read more than most people will ever hear spoken.*

- **Pool:** +2 Psychē
- **Power tag:** *well read*
- **Weakness tag:** *lives in books, not boots*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If a problem is new, I look for precedent."
- **Hook:** Which book or teacher shaped you, and what did it leave unanswered?

19. Serene

> *Storms rage around you. Inside, you are still water.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *calm in the storm*
- **Weakness tag:** *slow to anger, slower to act*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If panic spreads, I stay still and speak softly."
- **Hook:** What taught you peace, and what would shatter it?

20. Sly

> *There is always another way in, another word to say, another deal to make.*

- **Pool:** +2 Akmē
- **Power tag:** *always an angle*
- **Weakness tag:** *nobody takes my word*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If there's a shortcut, I find it."
- **Hook:** Who did you outwit, and are they still looking for you?

21. Steady

> *Your hands don't shake. When everyone else panics, you are the one who aims.*

- **Pool:** +2 Akmē
- **Power tag:** *hands like stone*
- **Weakness tag:** *slow to start*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If the moment is tense, I breathe and take my time."
- **Hook:** When did your steadiness matter most, and who was counting on you?

22. Stubborn

> *You've been told no all your life. You've ignored it all your life.*

- **Pool:** +2 Sōma
- **Power tag:** *will not be moved*
- **Weakness tag:** *can't admit I'm wrong*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If someone tells me to stop, I dig in."
- **Hook:** What did everyone say was impossible that you did anyway?

23. Suspicious

> *Everyone wants something. You just haven't worked out what yet.*

- **Pool:** +2 Psychē
- **Power tag:** *notices what's off*
- **Weakness tag:** *sees enemies everywhere*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If a stranger is too friendly, I watch their hands."
- **Hook:** Who betrayed you, and how did you not see it coming?

24. Weathered

> *Wind, sun and years have worn you down to something hard and lasting.*

- **Pool:** +2 Sōma
- **Power tag:** *seen worse than this*
- **Weakness tag:** *old wounds ache*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "If conditions turn harsh, I take the worst of it first."
- **Hook:** Where did you earn your scars, and who was with you?

CHAPTER V

Generic Playbooks

The six genre-neutral playbooks: Bellator, Furcifer, Savant, Interlocutor, Explorator and Adept. Each has eight special abilities, a capstone and starting equipment for three genres. The Frontier playbooks in Chapter IX reskin these six.

The noun of the character sentence.

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I. Playbook Rules

1.1 What a Playbook Gives You

Element	Detail
Base pools	Sōma / Akmē / Psychē / Pneuma, totalling 36. Add 4 points of your choice and +2 from your Descriptor
Edge	3 points: the fixed Edge listed, plus 1 point from the listed choices
Anchor skill	Must be rated +3 or +4 in your pyramid
Suggested skills	A recommended pyramid; change it freely
Playbook tags	Choose **2** power tags from the playbook's list
XP trigger	One playbook behaviour that earns XP (Core Rules §12.1)
Special abilities	1 free at creation; up to 2 more at creation for 1 Refresh each
Starting equipment	Signature items (choose 1 of 2), playbook kit, and always-carried items
BIG examples	Sample Beliefs, Goals, and Instincts
Relationships	1 ally and 1 rival from the playbook's list

1.2 Ability Notation

- ★ **Major** — costs **1 Refresh** whenever you take it (creation or advancement).
- ◆ **Capstone** — unlocked after **12 Advances** if you have **at least 4 abilities from this playbook**. Costs no Refresh. One capstone per character.
- **Veteran abilities:** after 6 Advances, you may take an ability from another playbook as an Advance. It costs 1 Refresh in addition to any ★ cost.

1.3 Rules References Used in Abilities

Term	Meaning (proposal section)
Power	Successes generated by a roll; spent on Effects (§2.5, §5)
Effort	Spend 3 − Edge from a pool for a bonus die (before rolling) or +1 Power (after a success) (§2.4)
Resist	Roll 2d12, pay pool points by highest die − Edge, reduce a status by 2 tiers (§6)
Status	Tiered condition 1–6; tier 6 = Taken Out (§5.1)
Truth	Scene, site, region, or campaign tag that shifts Difficulty by ±3 (§8)
Disposition	Conflict "hit points" (§10)
Injury trade	Once per conflict, accept a tier-2/3/4 injury to cancel 1/2/3 Disposition loss (§10.9)
Dying	Life-threatening tier-6 physical harm: 3-segment clock; Medicine vs. Hard 18 stabilises (§6.7)
Checks / Grind	Players' Turn currency and the hardship clock (Module B)

2. Equipment Rules

2.1 Load (Blades in the Dark)

Before a mission, choose your **load**. During play, declare items from your playbook kit as you need them and mark their load.

Load	Capacity	Effect
Light	3	You blend in; nothing obvious marks you as armed or burdened
Normal	5	You look ready for trouble
Heavy	7	You're *encumbered*: Akmē Effort costs +1 and Stealth Difficulty is one step higher

- **Signature items** are chosen at creation and always count against load when carried (most are 1–2).
- **Always-carried items** (load 0) are always on you.
- Items marked **(0)** cost no load.

2.2 Gear as Tags

- Every item is a **power tag** when it's relevant, e.g. *crowbar* helps Athletics to force a door. Item tags count toward the **+2 tag cap**.
- **Weapons** also give one or more **conflict action tags** (Core Rules §10.8), e.g. *+1 Attack*.
- **Quality:** a fine or advanced item gives one extra benefit listed in its entry (it doesn't raise the cap).

2.3 Armour and Shields

Item	Load	Effect
Light armour	1	*Armour 1*: when you Resist physical harm, reduce it by 1 extra tier
Heavy armour	2	*Armour 2*: reduce by 2 extra tiers; Akmē Effort +1 while worn
Shield / riot shield / energy barrier	1	*+1 Defend* in Fight conflicts; counts as cover outside conflicts

Armour that absorbs a tier-4+ hit is *damaged* (−1 Armour) until repaired during downtime. Armour never reduces Disposition loss, an injury you accepted as payment, or a running-dry status (Core Rules §6).

2.4 Common Gear (any playbook)

Load	Fantasy	Modern	Sci-Fi
(0)	Belt knife, flint & steel, coin purse	Phone, wallet, keys, pocketknife	Comm unit, credchip, multitool
1	Rope (15 m), lantern & oil, trail rations (2 days)	Flashlight, first-aid kit, water & snacks	Glow rod, medpatch ×2, ration bars
1	Bedroll & blanket	Duffel with spare clothes	Thermal sheet & sleep sack
1	Crowbar or pry bar	Crowbar or bolt cutters	Hydraulic pry tool
2	Tent or tarp	Tent or camping kit	Pop-up shelter

3. Bellator

> *Muscle, grit, and a willingness to stand in front of trouble. Soldiers, brawlers, bouncers, gladiators, mercenaries, security officers.*

Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	12 / 10 / 6 / 8
Edge	Sōma 2, plus 1 in Akmē or Pneuma
Anchor skill	Fight or Brawl
Suggested skills	+4 Fight · +3 Athletics, Endure · +2 Brawl, Intimidate, Shoot · +1 Notice, Will, Survival, Medicine
XP trigger	Address a challenge with force or threats

Playbook tags (choose 2): *built like a wall · veteran of the line · scarred and unbothered · iron grip · knows how a fight will go · the look that stops trouble*



3.1 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Juggernaut**	When you Resist physical harm with Sōma, reduce the status by **3 tiers** instead of 2.
2	**Brutal**	Once per roll, when you spend Power on Attack with Fight or Brawl, the status gains **+1 tier for free**.
3	**Bodyguard**	When an ally within reach would suffer a consequence, you may take it instead. If you Resist it, your Edge counts as 1 higher for that roll.
4	**Cleave**	When you attack a group or minions, you get **one free Extra Feat** per roll (hit a second target, break their line, and so on).
5	**Menacing**	You may use **Sōma** for Intimidate Effort and Resistance. When you succeed on Intimidate against minions, spend 1 Momentum to make them flee, surrender, or freeze.
6	**Pain Tolerance**	Ignore the roll penalty from harmful physical statuses of tier 1–2. At tier 3+, the penalty is reduced by 1.
7	★ **Berserker**	Once per scene, enter a fury: you get **+1 bonus die** (free) on Fight, Brawl, and Athletics rolls for the rest of the scene. You can't script Defend or retreat. At scene end, lose 2 Sōma or take *Weary*.
8	★ **Unstoppable**	Once per scene, when a status would reach tier 6 on you, keep acting until the end of the scene. Then you're Taken Out as normal.
◆	**Legend of the Field**	Your reputation is a **Campaign Truth** (*"Everyone knows [name]"*). In Fight conflicts, enemy Disposition starts **−2**, and the GM pays +1 Woe for reinforcements while you stand.

3.2 Starting Equipment

Signature weapon (choose 1)

Genre	Option A	Option B
Fantasy	**Greataxe or warhammer** (2) — *+1 Attack*, *crushing blows*	**Longsword & shield** (2) — *+1 Attack*, *+1 Defend*
Modern	**Combat shotgun** (2) — *+1 Attack*, *room-clearer*	**Baseball bat & pistol** (2) — *+1 Attack* (bat), *sidearm*
Sci-Fi	**Shock maul** (2) — *+1 Attack*, *stuns on hit* (spend 1 Power: add *dazed-1*)	**Vibro-blade & energy barrier** (2) — *+1 Attack*, *+1 Defend*

Playbook kit (declare during play)

Load	Fantasy	Modern	Sci-Fi
1	Mail shirt (light armour)	Tactical vest (light armour)	Ballistic weave (light armour)
2	Plate harness (heavy armour)	Riot gear (heavy armour)	Combat exo-plate (heavy armour)
1	Throwing axes ×3 — *+1 Attack* (range)	Collapsible baton — *+1 Attack*	Concussion grenades ×2 — *+1 Maneuver*
1	Manacles & chain	Zip-cuffs & pepper spray	Mag-cuffs & stun prod
1	Whetstone & armourer's kit	Gun-cleaning kit & spare mags	Field repair kit
1	Flask of strong drink	Energy drinks & painkillers	Stim-shot (restore 2 Sōma, once)

Always carried (0): Fantasy: knuckle-wraps, battle trophy. Modern: brass knuckles, gym bag. Sci-Fi: reinforced gloves, unit insignia.

3.3 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "Strength is only worth something when it protects the weak." / "Every fight I walk away from comes back worse."
- **Goal:** "Get the merchant to the city gates alive." / "Find out who hired the thugs."
- **Instinct:** "Always stand between my friends and the door." / "Never let an insult pass in public."

Relationships: Ally — an old comrade-in-arms, a trainer, a medic who's patched you up too often. Rival — the one who beat you once, a former commander, a rival enforcer.

4. Furcifer

> *Quiet, precise, and always three exits ahead. Thieves, spies, scouts, assassins, infiltrators, saboteurs.*

Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	8 / 12 / 8 / 8
Edge	Akmē 2, plus 1 in Psychē or Sōma
Anchor skill	Stealth
Suggested skills	+4 Stealth · +3 Notice, Craft · +2 Athletics, Deceive, Shoot · +1 Fight, Tech, Investigate, Drive/Pilot
XP trigger	Address a challenge with stealth or precision

Playbook tags (choose 2): *light on my feet · eyes in the back of my head · steady hands · knows the underworld · forgettable face · patient as a stone*



4.1 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Ghost**	When you spend Effort on a Stealth roll, your first use of Effort costs 0 pool points. Once per scene, when spotted, spend 1 Momentum to declare you were never seen; you're in a nearby hidden position.
2	**Opportunist**	When you act against a target that's unaware of you or has an *Impeded* status, gain **+1 Power** on a success.
3	**Light Fingers**	When you succeed on a theft, plant, or sabotage roll (Stealth or Craft), gain a **free Extra Feat**.
4	**Infiltrator**	Once per roll, ignore one Truth that would raise the Difficulty of sneaking, climbing, or bypassing security.
5	**Quick Reflexes**	You always act first when violence breaks out. In conflicts, changing one of your scripted actions costs **1 Momentum** instead of 2.
6	**Escape Artist**	When you Resist capture, restraint, falls, or traps with Akmē, the cost is **0 on a highest die of 5+**.
7	★ **Flashback**	Once per mission, declare a flashback to something you prepared earlier. Pay Momentum by plausibility: 0 (obvious), 1 (reasonable), 2 (a stretch), 3 (wild). Then roll as normal; on a success, it happened.
8	★ **Deadly Precision**	Against an unaware or *Impeded* target, Attack effects cost **half Power (round up)**: 2 Power buys a tier-3 or tier-4 status.
◆	**Nobody Sees Me Coming**	Once per session, declare you're already somewhere you could plausibly have reached. Your first roll there gets **+2 bonus dice for free**, and the GM can't spend Woe to reveal you during that roll.

4.2 Starting Equipment

Signature item (choose 1)

Genre	Option A	Option B
Fantasy	**Twin daggers** (1) — *+1 Attack*, *+1 Feint*	**Shortbow & black-fletched arrows** (1) — *+1 Attack* (range), *silent shots*
Modern	**Suppressed pistol** (1) — *+1 Attack*, *quiet*	**Lockpicks & bypass kit** (1) — *opens what's closed*, Advance security clocks +1 per roll
Sci-Fi	**Needle pistol** (1) — *+1 Attack*, *silent*, *toxin-loaded*	**Holo-cloak** (1) — *+1 Feint*, *bends light* (Stealth tag)

Playbook kit

Load	Fantasy	Modern	Sci-Fi
1	Thieves' tools	Lockpicks & electronic bypass	Slicer kit
1	Grappling hook & silk cord	Climbing harness & line	Monofilament line & grapple gun
1	Dark hooded cloak — *shadow-dyed*	Black clothing & balaclava	Thermal-masking suit
1	Caltrops & smoke vials — *+1 Maneuver*	Smoke grenade — *+1 Maneuver*	Sensor jammer — *+1 Maneuver*
1	Garrotte & poison vial	Burner phones ×2	Spy drone (Discover, 1 use per scene)
1	Padded leather (light armour)	Concealed vest (light armour)	Flex-mesh undersuit (light armour)

Always carried (0): Fantasy: hidden blade, chalk. Modern: hairpin picks, earpiece. Sci-Fi: implanted lockpick, false ID chip.

4.3 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "Everyone has a price; I just haven't found mine." / "The less blood, the better the job."
- **Goal:** "Get the ledger out of the counting house." / "Learn who sold out my old crew."
- **Instinct:** "Always check for a second way out." / "Never touch anything without gloves."

Relationships: Ally — a fence, a forger, a former mentor. Rival — an inspector who's close to catching you, a rival thief, the partner who betrayed you.

5. Savant

Knowledge is a weapon, a shield, and a cure. Scholars, detectives, scientists, physicians, archivists, engineers.

Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	7 / 8 / 13 / 8
Edge	Psychē 2, plus 1 in Pneuma or Akmē
Anchor skill	Lore or Investigate
Suggested skills	+4 Lore · +3 Investigate, Medicine · +2 Notice, Tech, Empathy · +1 Persuade, Will, Craft, Arcana
XP trigger	Address a challenge with knowledge or insight

Playbook tags (choose 2): *read everything twice · eye for detail · steady surgeon's hands · speaks the old tongues · respected in academic circles · thinks in diagrams*



5.1 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Encyclopedic**	Once per scene, ask one Discover question about a subject covered by your Lore **without rolling**.
2	**Analyze**	When you study a foe or obstacle, each Discover you buy also reveals **one weakness tag** of the target. Creating a story tag that exploits a revealed weakness costs **1 Power** instead of 2.
3	**Field Medic**	Restore effects from Medicine cost **1 Power per 2 tiers**. You can treat *Sick* (Module B) at Standard Difficulty instead of Hard.
4	**Steady Mind**	When you Resist confusion, illusion, deception, or forbidden knowledge with Psychē, reduce the status by **3 tiers**.
5	**Decipher**	Codes, unknown languages, and ancient devices give way. Each success on a deciphering roll Advances its clock **+1 extra segment**.
6	**Briefing**	When an ally acts on information you gave them this scene, they get **+1** (counts as a tag). Once per scene, give the whole party this bonus.
7	★ **Connect the Dots**	Once per session, propose a hidden Truth based on clues you've found. The GM either makes it true or tells you **one true hidden Truth** about the situation instead.
8	★ **I Planned for This**	Once per scene, after any ally rolls, spend **2 Psychē** to let them reroll all dice and keep the better result.
◆	**Master of the Field**	Choose one field (medicine, occult, engineering, history, and so on). Rolls in that field are **one Difficulty step lower**. Once per session, ask a Discover question about **what will happen** in that field; the GM answers truthfully.

5.2 Starting Equipment

Signature item (choose 1)

Genre	Option A	Option B
Fantasy	**Annotated grimoire / great reference** (1) — *the answer is in here somewhere*; once per scene, +1 to Lore	**Physician's satchel** (1) — *herbs and blades*; Restore +1 tier once per scene
Modern	**Laptop with research databases** (1) — *online archive*	**Forensics kit** (1) — *evidence never lies*; +1 to Investigate at scenes
Sci-Fi	**Datapad with AI assistant** (1) — *ask the archive*; one free Discover per session	**Bioscanner** (1) — *reads the body*; Medicine and Notice tag

Playbook kit

Load	Fantasy	Modern	Sci-Fi
1	Journal, ink, and charcoal	Notebook, camera, and voice recorder	Holo-recorder
1	Magnifying lens & specimen jars	UV light & evidence bags	Spectral analyser
1	Herbalist's kit	Full first-aid kit	Advanced medkit
1	Quarterstaff — *+1 Defend*	Taser — *+1 Maneuver*	Stun baton — *+1 Maneuver*
1	Scroll case with maps	Tablet with offline maps	Star charts / topographic uplink
1	Alchemist's reagents (1 cypher-like use: Create smoke, light, or acid)	Chemistry kit	Nanite sample kit

Always carried (0): Fantasy: spectacles, chalk. Modern: reading glasses, pen. Sci-Fi: translator earpiece, stylus.

5.3 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "No knowledge is forbidden; only misused." / "The dead deserve the truth about how they died."
- **Goal:** "Translate the inscription before the eclipse." / "Identify the poison."
- **Instinct:** "Always take a sample." / "Never trust a source I can't verify."

Relationships: Ally — a former teacher, a librarian, a patient who owes you their life. Rival — an academic rival, an ex-colleague who stole your work, a cultist who wants your research.

6. Interlocutor

> *Words open doors that swords can't. Diplomats, con artists, nobles, negotiators, preachers, captains.*

Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	7 / 9 / 9 / 11
Edge	Pneuma 2, plus 1 in Psychē or Akmē
Anchor skill	Persuade
Suggested skills	+4 Persuade · +3 Empathy, Deceive · +2 Will, Notice, Intimidate · +1 Lore, Fight, Stealth, Investigate
XP trigger	Address a challenge with charm, lies, or bargaining

Playbook tags (choose 2): *silver tongue · friends in every port · reads people like books · noble bearing · a hundred faces · calm under fire*



6.1 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Silver Tongue**	When you Persuade or Deceive, creating a story tag about a target's attitude (*convinced*, *trusts us*, *fooled*) costs **1 Power** instead of 2.
2	**Read the Room**	Spend 1 Power on Discover to learn an NPC's **Belief, Goal, or Instinct**. You get **+1** (counts as a tag) against them for the scene.
3	**Network**	Once per session, declare a **contact** in the current location as a story tag (*contact: harbourmaster Elsa*). The GM gives them a quirk or something they want in return.
4	**Smooth Recovery**	Once per scene, turn a failed Persuade, Deceive, or Empathy roll into a **Success at a Cost**.
5	**Many Faces**	With a moment to prepare, Create the story tag *I belong here* for **1 Power**. It lasts the scene and removes one Truth that would raise the Difficulty of mingling or entry.
6	**Command**	In conflicts, your team **ignores the rotation rule** for one volley per exchange. Once per exchange, an ally's Defend restores **+1 Disposition**.
7	★ **Inspire**	You can spend **your Tychē Points on allies' rolls**. Enhance effects you create for allies cost **1 Power per 2 tiers**.
8	★ **Crowd Work**	You influence a group as if it were one person. In Argument or Negotiation conflicts against a crowd or council, your Attacks remove **+1 Disposition**.
◆	**Word Is Law**	Once per session, a non-villain NPC agrees to a reasonable request **without a roll**. In Argument and Negotiation conflicts, your side starts with **+4 Disposition**.

6.2 Starting Equipment

Signature item (choose 1)

Genre	Option A	Option B
Fantasy	**Signet ring & letters of introduction** (0) — *carries a name that opens doors*	**Rapier** (1) — *+1 Attack*, *+1 Feint*, *duelling style*
Modern	**Tailored suit & business cards** (0) — *looks like money*	**Concealed pistol** (1) — *+1 Attack*, *never seen it coming*
Sci-Fi	**Diplomatic credentials** (0) — *official envoy*	**Hold-out blaster** (1) — *+1 Attack*, *hidden in a sleeve*

Playbook kit

Load	Fantasy	Modern	Sci-Fi
1	Fine clothes for court	Formal wear & accessories	Holo-fashion wardrobe
1	Disguise kit & wigs	Disguise kit & fake IDs	Holo-disguise emitter
1	Purse of gold — *money talks* (1 use per mission: Create tag *bribed*)	Credit card — *money talks* (same)	Credit stick — *money talks* (same)
1	Bottle of fine wine	Gift basket / bottle of scotch	Rare off-world delicacy
1	Forged seals & papers	Forged documents	Spoofed ID chip
1	Brocaded doublet (light armour)	Armoured coat (light armour)	Deflector jacket (light armour)

Always carried (0): Fantasy: perfume, deck of cards. Modern: smartphone with contacts, breath mints. Sci-Fi: translator implant, personal comm.

6.3 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "Every war ends at a table; I'd rather start there." / "A lie that saves a life is no sin."
- **Goal:** "Get the guild master to sign the truce." / "Find out what the duke really wants."
- **Instinct:** "Always learn someone's name." / "Never be the first to name a price."

Relationships: Ally — a well-placed patron, a loyal servant, a reporter. Rival — a political opponent, a jilted lover, someone you conned who wants payback.

7. Explorator

> *At home where the map ends. Rangers, hunters, pilots, guides, explorers, scouts, voyageurs.*

Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	11 / 11 / 7 / 7
Edge	Sōma 1, Akmē 1, plus 1 in any pool
Anchor skill	Survival
Suggested skills	+4 Survival · +3 Notice, Shoot · +2 Athletics, Endure, Drive/Pilot · +1 Stealth, Medicine, Lore, Fight
XP trigger	Address a challenge with endurance, travel, or knowledge of the land

Playbook tags (choose 2): *reads the weather · never lost · sharp-eyed hunter · tireless · at home in the wild · steady at the helm*



7.1 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Pathfinder**	As Guide (Module B), each Power spent on Make Time Advances the Journey clock **+1 extra segment**. Ignore one terrain Truth per leg.
2	**Forager**	As Quartermaster, a success also clears *Hungry & Thirsty* for the whole party and gives **+1 Supplies** for free.
3	**Tracker**	When you track or read signs, each Discover you buy gives **two answers**.
4	**Hunter's Eye**	With Shoot, once per roll ignore one Truth about cover, distance, or weather. At long range, gain **+1 Power** on a success.
5	**Ambusher**	In wild terrain, if you had time to prepare, your side starts a Fight conflict with **+2 Disposition**, and your first-volley Attack counts as independent regardless of the opponent's action.
6	**At the Helm**	Drive/Pilot rolls with your own vehicle or boat may use Survival. Your vehicle gains one power tag (*swift*, *rugged*, *nimble*). In Chase conflicts, your side gets **+3 Disposition**.
7	★ **Animal Companion**	You have a companion (hound, hawk, horse, drone in sci-fi) with 2 power tags and 1 weakness. Once per scene it gives you a **free bonus die**, or it acts on its own using your Survival. It can take statuses; tier 6 means it's lost until downtime.
8	★ **Weather Sense**	Once per session, declare the **weather or terrain Truth** for the next scene (*thick fog*, *rising river*, *clear skies*).
◆	**One With the Wild**	In wilderness, the party's Grind clock is **2 segments larger**, and you can't be surprised. Once per session, lead the party into the wild to **end any chase or pursuit** in your favour.

7.2 Starting Equipment

Signature item (choose 1)

Genre	Option A	Option B
Fantasy	**Longbow** (2) — *+1 Attack* (range), *hunter's draw*	**Spear & hatchet** (2) — *+1 Maneuver* (spear), *+1 Attack* (hatchet)
Modern	**Scoped hunting rifle** (2) — *+1 Attack* (range), *+1 Maneuver*	**Canoe or 4×4 truck** (vehicle, 0 load) — *my rig*, Drive/Pilot tag
Sci-Fi	**Long-las rifle** (2) — *+1 Attack* (range), *thermal scope*	**Grav-bike or skiff** (vehicle, 0 load) — *my rig*, Drive/Pilot tag

Playbook kit

Load	Fantasy	Modern	Sci-Fi
1	Hunting knife & skinning tools	Survival knife & multitool	Survival blade with tool kit
2	Tent, bedroll & cookpot	Lightweight tent, sleeping bag & stove	Pop-up shelter & thermal pack
1	Snares & fishing line	Fishing kit & snares	Auto-snare & water purifier
1	Map case & compass	GPS, maps & compass	Topographic scanner
1	Leather jerkin (light armour)	Waxed-canvas jacket (light armour)	Environment suit (light armour, *sealed*)
1	Trail rations & waterskins (+2 Supplies)	Dehydrated meals & filter (+2 Supplies)	Nutrient packs & reclaimer (+2 Supplies)

Always carried (0): Fantasy: tinderbox, whistle. Modern: ferro rod, bug spray. Sci-Fi: emergency beacon, rebreather.

7.3 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "The land gives to those who respect it." / "No one gets left on the trail."
- **Goal:** "Reach the trading post before the freeze." / "Find the lost survey team."
- **Instinct:** "Always check the sky before setting out." / "Never camp where you can't see the approach."

Relationships: Ally — a trapper, a bush pilot, a village elder. Rival — a poacher, a rival guide, the company that wants your land.

8. Adept

> *Power from beyond the ordinary: magic, psionics, faith, or impossible technology. Mages, psychics, priests, hackers, gadgeteers.*

Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	7 / 8 / 9 / 12
Edge	Pneuma 2 (Arcana Adepts) or Psychē 2 (Tech Adepts), plus 1 in any other pool
Anchor skill	Arcana (magic, faith, psionics) or Tech (hacking, gadgets)
Suggested skills	+4 Arcana · +3 Lore, Will · +2 Notice, Medicine, Persuade · +1 Investigate, Empathy, Deceive, Tech
XP trigger	Address a challenge with your powers or gadgets

Playbook tags (choose 2): *touched by the Other · disciplined mind · sees what others can't · blessed · tinkerer's genius · fluent in the old pacts*



8.1 Core Feature — Domain (free)

Every Adept has a **Domain**: a broad power tag describing what they can do (*fire*, *healing*, *telekinesis*, *shadows*, *machines*, *networks*, *the dead*, *weather*).

- **Workings:** within your Domain, you can attempt any effect with your anchor skill. The GM sets Difficulty by scope:

Scope	Difficulty	Example (Domain: fire)
Minor, personal	Easy 12	Light a candle, warm your hands
Significant	Standard 15	Hurl a firebolt, melt a lock
Dramatic	Hard 18	Wall of flame across a street
Spectacular	Formidable 21	Set a ship ablaze
World-shaking	Heroic 24 (usually a Ritual)	Call down a firestorm

- **Cost:** each working costs **1 point** from Pneuma (Arcana) or Psychē (Tech), in addition to any Effort.
- **Backlash:** doubles on a failure or cost cause a backlash. The GM picks a fitting status for you (*burned-2*, *drained-2*, *glitched-2*) or a wild effect, in addition to the normal complication.
- Your Domain counts as a power tag on workings (inside the +2 cap).

8.2 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Focused Channel**	Workings inside your Domain cost **0 pool points** if you don't use Effort on that roll.
2	**Ward**	You can create protective statuses (*warded-X*) with Enhance. While warded, an ally reduces supernatural or tech-based harm by **+1 tier** when Resisting.
3	**Sense the Unseen**	Once per scene, ask a free Discover question about **hidden supernatural or technological forces** nearby. You always notice when such forces are used near you.
4	**Overchannel**	When you use Effort for Power on a working, gain **+2 Power** instead of +1, but take *strained-1*.
5	**Ritual**	Given time, materials, and a safe place, run a working as a **progress clock** instead of a single roll (8 segments for Formidable, 12 for Heroic). Ritual results can create Site or Region Truths.
6	**Bound Servant**	You have a minor spirit, construct, or drone with one power tag and one weakness. It can scout (one free Discover per scene in places it can reach), carry messages, or handle simple tasks. It can't fight.

#	Ability	Effect
7	★ **Second Domain**	Gain a second Domain. Workings in it use the same rules.
8	★ **Unleash**	Once per scene, a working hits **every target** in an area or group: each one receives the full Attack effects you buy. Afterwards, take *Weary* or lose 3 points from your casting pool.
◆	**Ascendant**	Once per session, a Heroic-scope working succeeds automatically with **5 Power**, no ritual required. If you use it again before your next downtime, gain a Pneuma or Psychē Scar.

8.3 Starting Equipment

Signature focus (choose 1)

Genre	Option A	Option B
Fantasy	**Staff or wand** (1) — *conduit*; +1 to workings, *+1 Defend* (staff)	**Holy symbol or ancestral talisman** (0) — *faith made solid*; Resist supernatural harm with Edge +1
Modern	**Occult focus** (ring, chalk, athame) (0) — *conduit*	**Custom cyberdeck / laptop** (1) — *my rig*; +1 to Tech workings
Sci-Fi	**Psi-amp headset** (1) — *amplifier*; +1 to psionic workings	**Neural jack & cyberdeck** (1) — *direct interface*; +1 to Tech workings

Playbook kit

Load	Fantasy	Modern	Sci-Fi
1	Grimoire or prayer book	Occult library on a tablet	Encrypted data archive
1	Spell components pouch	Salt, chalk, candles & herbs	Spare power cells & focus crystals
1	Ritual dagger — *+1 Attack*	Pistol — *+1 Attack*	Sidearm blaster — *+1 Attack*
1	Warding charms ×2 (0-Power *warded-1* once each)	Talismans ×2 (same)	Firewall chips ×2 (same)
1	Robes of the order (light armour, *marks my calling*)	Long coat with hidden pockets (light armour)	Insulated bodysuit (light armour)
1	Scrying bowl or crystal	Drone with camera	Micro-drone swarm (Bound Servant gear)

Always carried (0): Fantasy: a small familiar token, incense. Modern: tarot deck, phone. Sci-Fi: diagnostic implant, data spike.

8.4 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "Power is a debt, and I always pay my debts." / "Knowledge should be free; locks are an insult."
- **Goal:** "Seal the rift before the new moon." / "Crack the corporation's archive."
- **Instinct:** "Always ward the room before I sleep." / "Never use my power in front of the authorities."

Relationships: Ally — your teacher, a fellow initiate, an entity you've bargained with. Rival — a rival practitioner, a hunter of your kind, the order that cast you out.

10. Design Notes

10.1 Balance Targets

Playbook	Main pool	Conflict role	Exploration role	Social role
Bellator	Sōma	Attack / Defend	Endurance, forcing obstacles	Intimidation
Furcifer	Akmē	Feint / Maneuver	Infiltration, security	Deception
Savant	Psychē	Maneuver (Discover, analysis)	Investigation, healing	Expertise
Interlocutor	Pneuma	Argument and Negotiation lead	Contacts, disguise	Persuasion
Explorator	Sōma/Akmē	Ranged Attack, ambush	Travel, Grind, tracking	Local knowledge
Adept	Pneuma/Psychē	Flexible (Domain)	Supernatural or tech access	Varies by Domain

10.2 Things to Watch in Playtest

- **Discount stacking:** abilities that reduce Power costs (Silver Tongue, Analyze, Field Medic, Deadly Precision, Jury-Rig) are strong when stacked with Effort for Power. Cap at one cost reduction per Effect.
- **Free bonus dice** (Berserker, Animal Companion, Second Wind, Nobody Sees Me Coming) still count toward the +2 bonus die maximum.
- **Adept workings** are the most open-ended. If they overshadow other playbooks, increase the base working cost to 2 pool points, or let Focused Channel apply only to minor and significant workings.
- **Vehicle signature items** (Explorator, modern and sci-fi) are 0 load because they don't come on foot missions. Treat them as a story tag when they're not present.
- ★ **count:** each playbook has two Major abilities and every capstone is free. Characters who take both ★ abilities will be at Refresh 1–2, as intended.

CHAPTER VI

Generic Focuses

Twenty-four setting-neutral Focuses complete the sentence: "...who [Focus]." Each one has two power tags, a weakness, a link to another player character, and tiered abilities with a choice at Tiers 2 and 3.

The verb of the character sentence.

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1. Focus Rules

1.1 What a Focus Gives You

Element	Detail
Power tags	2
Weakness tag	1 (can be compelled for Tychē Points)
PC link	A prompt that connects you to another player character
Tier 1 ability	Fixed; gained at creation for free
Tier 2 ability	**Choose 1 of 2**; after 3 Advances, costs an Advance
Tier 3 ability	**Choose 1 of 2**; after 6 Advances, costs an Advance

- **The other option:** once you've reached a tier, you may take its unchosen option later as a normal Advance.
- ★ **Major:** costs 1 Refresh when taken (Core Rules §4.1). Every Focus has exactly one ★ option, always at Tier 3, so you can always choose a path that keeps your Refresh.
- **Any playbook can take any Focus.** The "Suits" line is a suggestion.
- **Changing Focus:** at a major milestone, with GM approval, you can swap your Focus. You keep Tier 1 of the new one and rebuy higher tiers with Advances.

1.2 Weird Focuses ◈

Focuses marked ◈ **Weird** assume the supernatural, impossible technology, or both. In mundane settings the GM removes them from the list. Every other Focus works in any genre.

1.3 Shared Rules Reminders

- Free bonus dice from Focuses still count toward the **+2 bonus die maximum**.
- Abilities that add bonus above the tag cap only do so for the tag they name, and are limited to **+1 above the normal +2 cap (maximum +3)** unless stated otherwise.
- Only **one cost reduction** applies to a single Effect (e.g. you can't combine two "costs 1 Power instead of 2" abilities).

2. Quick Reference

#	Focus	Category	Suits	◆
1	Never Leaves Anyone Behind	Combat	Bellator, Explorator, Furcifer	
2	Leads From the Front	Combat	Interlocutor, Bellator, Explorator	
3	Masters a Weapon	Combat	Bellator, Furcifer, Explorator	
4	Fights Dirty	Combat	Bellator, Furcifer	
5	Moves Like a Shadow	Stealth & Precision	Furcifer, Explorator	
6	Never Misses	Stealth & Precision	Explorator, Furcifer, Bellator	
7	Opens Every Lock	Stealth & Precision	Furcifer, Savant, Adept	
8	Always Has an Escape Plan	Stealth & Precision	Furcifer, Interlocutor	
9	Builds Impossible Things	Knowledge	Savant, Adept, Explorator	
10	Heals the Broken	Knowledge	Savant, Adept, Interlocutor	
11	Solves the Unsolvable	Knowledge	Savant, Interlocutor, Furcifer	
12	Remembers What Was Forgotten	Knowledge	Savant, Adept, Explorator	
13	Talks Their Way Out of Anything	Social	Interlocutor, Furcifer	
14	Wears a Hundred Masks	Social	Interlocutor, Furcifer	
15	Knows Everyone Worth Knowing	Social	Interlocutor, Savant	
16	Carries the Weight of a Crown	Social	Interlocutor, Bellator	
17	Runs With the Pack	Wilderness & Travel	Explorator, Bellator	
18	Charts the Unknown	Wilderness & Travel	Explorator, Savant	
19	Lives Off the Land	Wilderness & Travel	Explorator, Bellator	
20	Was Born Behind the Wheel	Wilderness & Travel	Explorator, Furcifer	
21	Hunts the Things in the Dark	Weird	Savant, Adept, Bellator	◈
22	Walks Between Worlds	Weird	Adept, Savant	◈
23	Made a Bargain With Something Old	Weird	Any	◈
24	Is More Than Human	Weird	Any	◈

3. Combat Focuses

1. Never Leaves Anyone Behind

> *Loyal to a fault. You go back for the fallen, every time.*

- **Power tags:** *I've got your back*, *carry them out*

- **Weakness tag:** *can't walk away*
- **PC link:** "I once failed to save someone. [PC] reminds me of them."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Shield Bearer**	When an ally next to you takes a status, spend 1 point from any pool to reduce it by **1 tier** before they Resist.
2a	**Second Wind**	Once per scene, when an ally is Taken Out, you may act immediately to reach them. Your next roll to help or rescue them gets a **free bonus die**.
2b	**Interpose**	When you accept an injury to cancel Disposition loss from an Attack or Feint, cancel **1 additional** Disposition loss, up to the loss inflicted. All normal injury-trade restrictions apply.
3a	**No One Left**	Once per session, when the party retreats or escapes, no one is left behind or captured. Each ally clears one tier-1 or tier-2 status.
3b	★ **Living Wall**	Once per scene, until your next action, all harm aimed at allies within reach hits you instead. You Resist each with Edge +1.

2. Leads From the Front

> *Captain, chief, or sergeant: people follow you.*

- **Power tags:** *born to command*, *they believe in me*
- **Weakness tag:** *every loss is on me*
- **PC link:** "[PC] was the first person who ever followed my lead."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Rally**	Once per scene, spend 1 Momentum to restore **2 points** to one pool of every ally who can hear you.
2a	**Battle Plan**	At the start of a conflict, before scripting, look at **one** of the opposing side's scripted actions for the first exchange.
2b	**Lead by Example**	When you succeed with **3+ Power**, the next ally who acts toward the same goal gets a **free bonus die**.
3a	★ **Warband**	Gain a loyal crew (a group with 2 power tags and 1 weakness). It acts as one group, gives free Help once per scene, or holds a position. It takes statuses as a single target.
3b	**Unbreakable Line**	Once per conflict, when your side's Disposition would drop to 0, it stays at **1** and you take a tier-2 status.

3. Masters a Weapon

> *Years of drill with one weapon: a blade, a rifle, a staff, bare fists.*

- **Power tags:** *one with my [weapon]*, *drilled every day*
- **Weakness tag:** *lost without it*
- **PC link:** "[PC] once saw me lose a duel, and kept it secret."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Signature Style**	Choose a weapon type. That weapon's tag may add **+1 above the normal +2 cap (maximum +3 from tags)**, and it gains a second conflict action tag (e.g. a sword also gives +1 Defend).
2a	**Riposte**	In Fight conflicts, when you win a versus roll with Defend, you may spend any of that Power to remove the opposing side's Disposition instead of restoring your side's.
2b	**Disarming Master**	The Disarm maneuver costs **2 Power** instead of 3. Outside conflicts, Weaken can strip an opponent's weapon tag for the scene.
3a	**Perfect Strike**	Once per scene, after rolling with your weapon, turn one kept die into a **12**. If that creates doubles, apply them.
3b	★ **Weapon Saint**	Your weapon becomes an **artifact** (Module A) with one extra power tag and an ability you design with the GM. It never depletes and costs no attunement Refresh.

4. Fights Dirty

> *Honour is for people who can afford to lose.*

- **Power tags:** *no rules in a fight*, *eye for a cheap shot*
- **Weakness tag:** *no one trusts me in a fair fight*
- **PC link:** "I taught [PC] that winning is the only thing that matters. They're still deciding if I was right."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Cheap Shot**	Once per scene, as part of an Attack, Create a story tag (*sand in the eyes*, *low blow*) for **1 Power**.
2a	**Improvised Arsenal**	Anything in reach is a weapon for you: chairs, bottles, tools. It gives **+1 Attack or +1 Maneuver** and costs no load.
2b	**Kick Them While They're Down**	Against a target with a harmful status of tier 2+, gain **+1 Power** on Attack.
3a	**Every Trick in the Book**	In Fight conflicts, your Feints remove **+1 Disposition**.
3b	★ **Nothing Is Off-Limits**	Once per session, declare a hazard Truth that was already there (*gas leak*, *rotten floor*, *loose cargo*). Your next roll that uses it gets a **free Extra Feat**.

4. Stealth & Precision Focuses

5. Moves Like a Shadow

> *Silent, patient, and impossible to pin down.*

- **Power tags:** *silent as snowfall*, *at home in darkness*
- **Weakness tag:** *uneasy in the light*
- **PC link:** "[PC] is the only one who always knows where I am."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Shadow-Born**	Truths about darkness, noise, or crowds lower your Stealth Difficulty by **two steps** instead of one.
2a	**Vanish**	Once per scene, after any roll, become hidden if there's any cover nearby. No roll needed.
2b	**Shadow Escort**	Up to **two allies** can use your Stealth result instead of rolling their own.
3a	**Unseen Hand**	Any action you take while hidden gains **+1 Power** on a success.
3b	★ **Living Shadow**	Once per session, pass through a guarded or blocked area unnoticed (no roll) and arrive at a point you choose.

6. Never Misses

> *Sniper, archer, gunslinger: steady breath and a sharp eye.*

- **Power tags:** *steady breath*, *eye like a hawk*
- **Weakness tag:** *clumsy up close*
- **PC link:** "[PC] owes their life to a shot I made."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Called Shot**	Once per roll with Shoot, a **free Weaken** effect: burn one of the target's tags (weapon, cover, mobility) for the scene.
2a	**Overwatch**	Once per scene, cancel a status of tier 2 or less about to hit an ally by shooting the source. In conflicts, you may Defend with **Shoot** when covering fire can protect your side.
2b	**Trick Shot**	Ignore Truths about cover and angles. A free **Extra Feat** when you shoot objects (cut a rope, hit a switch, ricochet).
3a	**One Shot**	Once per session, a Shoot Attack against a non-major NPC **Takes them Out** on a success.
3b	★ **Sniper's Patience**	Spend a scene setting up (4-segment clock). Your shot gets **+2 bonus dice** for free and **+2 Power** on a success.

7. Opens Every Lock

> *Locks, safes, firewalls, sealed doors: they're puzzles, and you love puzzles.*

- **Power tags:** *nothing stays closed*, *thinks like an architect*
- **Weakness tag:** *can't resist a challenge*
- **PC link:** "[PC] keeps me out of trouble, or tries to."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Bypass**	Each success on a lock, safe, or security clock Advances it **+1 extra segment**.
2a	**Back Door**	Once per location, Create the Truth *I know a way in* for **1 Power**.
2b	**Trap Sense**	You always notice traps and alarms before triggering them. Resisting traps costs **0 on a highest die of 5+**.
3a	**Master Key**	Ordinary locks open without a roll. Complex security is **two Difficulty steps lower**.
3b	★ **Vault Breaker**	Once per mission, declare a security layer already cracked: fill one security clock completely.

8. Always Has an Escape Plan

> *You never walk into a room without knowing how to leave it.*

- **Power tags:** *knows every exit*, *slippery*
- **Weakness tag:** *runs first, thinks later*
- **PC link:** "[PC] was with me during my worst getaway."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Exit Strategy**	When you enter a new scene, ask one free Discover question about exits or escape routes.
2a	**Clean Getaway**	In Chase conflicts where you're fleeing, your side gets **+3 Disposition**.
2b	**Contingency**	Once per mission, when things go wrong, reveal a prepared fallback (stashed gear, a getaway vehicle, a safe house) as a story tag. No Momentum needed.
3a	**Not Here**	Once per session, escape any scene with every ally who can follow, before the next status lands.
3b	★ **Dead Man's Switch**	You can't be held. When captured or Taken Out, you escape at the start of the next scene. The GM gains 2 Woe.

5. Knowledge Focuses

9. Builds Impossible Things

> *An artificer, engineer, or inventor who makes what shouldn't work, work.*

- **Power tags:** *workshop hands*, *it'll work, trust me*
- **Weakness tag:** *never quite finished*
- **PC link:** "I built [PC]'s gear, and I'm still tinkering with it."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Jury-Rig**	Once per scene, Craft a temporary gadget (a story tag) that lasts the scene and costs **1 Power** to Create.
2a	**Inventor**	During downtime, turn a gadget into a permanent item with a 6-segment clock. It gets 1 power tag and 1 action tag.
2b	**Field Repairs**	Restore effects work on gear, vehicles, and constructs. Repair damaged armour without downtime.
3a	**Master-work**	Create one **artifact** (Module A) with a 12-segment downtime clock. You pay no Refresh to attune your own masterwork.
3b	★ **Rig the Field**	Once per scene, rig the area with gadgets: Create **two** story tags for 2 Power total.

10. Heals the Broken

> *Doctor, field medic, herbalist, or combat surgeon.*

- **Power tags:** *calm hands*, *bedside manner*
- **Weakness tag:** *can't refuse anyone in pain*
- **PC link:** "I patched up [PC] when no one else would."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Triage**	Once per scene, reduce an ally's harmful status by **1 tier** without a roll.
2a	**Battlefield Surgeon**	In conflicts, you may Defend with **Medicine** when you can reach an ally and provide appropriate treatment. On a successful Defend, restore your side's Disposition normally and clear one tier-1 harmful status from that ally that your treatment can address.
2b	**Remedy**	In each Players' Turn, clear one Grind condition (Module B) from one ally **without spending a Check**.
3a	**Miracle Worker**	Once per session, bring an ally back from a tier-6 physical status. They return at tier 4 and are no longer Taken Out.
3b	★ **Physician's Care**	Allies you treat during a short rest recover **all** pool points, not just 1 + Edge.

11. Solves the Unsolvable

> *Detective, investigator, or analyst: you follow the thread to the end.*

- **Power tags:** *nothing gets past me*, *follows the thread*
- **Weakness tag:** *obsessed with the case*
- **PC link:** "[PC] was part of the case that made me."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Case File**	Start a **Mystery clock** (6 or 8) for a case. Every Discover you buy also Advances it 1 segment. When it fills, the GM reveals the core truth.
2a	**Interro-gator**	When questioning someone, each Discover gives **two answers**.
2b	**Recon-struction**	At the scene of a past event, ask **three** Discover questions for free (once per location).
3a	**The Reveal**	Once per session, name the culprit in front of others. If you're right, your side starts any conflict against them with **+4 Disposition**, and they get no compromise if they lose.
3b	★ **One Step Ahead**	Once per session, reveal that you anticipated an opponent's move: **cancel one GM Woe spend** as it happens.

12. Remembers What Was Forgotten

> *Historian, archaeologist, or keeper of lost lore.*

- **Power tags:** *walks among ruins*, *reads dead languages*
- **Weakness tag:** *lives in the past*
- **PC link:** "[PC] helped me recover something that was lost."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Echoes of the Past**	At any old or abandoned place, ask one free Discover question about its history.
2a	**Lost Knowledge**	Once per session, you've read about this before: Create a story tag (*ancient weakness*, *forgotten route*) for **0 Power**.
2b	**Relic Hunter**	When you find cyphers or treasure, roll or draw **twice** and choose. You identify artifacts automatically.
3a	**Living Archive**	Lore rolls about history, legends, and old cultures are **two Difficulty steps lower**.
3b	★ **Rewrite History**	Prove a Campaign Truth is false with a 12-segment research clock. When it fills, the Truth changes (Module C).

6. Social Focuses

13. Talks Their Way Out of Anything

> *Charm, quick wit, and the right words at the right time.*

- **Power tags:** *always has a story ready*, *disarming smile*
- **Weakness tag:** *my mouth writes cheques*
- **PC link:** "[PC] has bailed me out more than once; I owe them."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Fast Talk**	Once per scene, use Persuade or Deceive in place of any other skill to get out of a bad situation.
2a	**Change of Plans**	When a social roll results in a Success at a Cost, you may give the GM 1 Woe **instead** of accepting the consequence.
2b	**Disarming**	Once per scene, stop a fight before it starts with a Persuade roll. On a success, the Fight becomes a **Negotiation** conflict.

Tier	Ability	Effect
3a	★ **The Long Con**	Start a **long con clock** (8) against a target. Each success against them Advances it. When it fills, they give up something substantial: land, title, a secret, or their master.
3b	**Golden Tongue**	Tychē Point invokes on Persuade and Deceive give **+3** instead of +2.

14. Wears a Hundred Masks

> *Spy, impostor, or actor: you can be anyone.*

- **Power tags:** *perfect mimic*, *no one remembers my real face*
- **Weakness tag:** *who am I really?*
- **PC link:** "[PC] is the only one who knows my real name."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Quick Change**	Create a disguise story tag for **1 Power**, even without a disguise kit.
2a	**Mimic**	You can copy voices, mannerisms, and handwriting. Impersonating a specific person gets a **free bonus die**.
2b	**Deep Cover**	Keep a cover identity as a permanent story tag with its own contact. The GM must spend **2 Woe** to blow your cover.
3a	**Belongs Anywhere**	Ignore Truths about social barriers (*members only*, *high security*, *closed community*).
3b	★ **Become Them**	Once per session, take a specific NPC's place for a scene. No one can expose you before the scene ends.

15. Knows Everyone Worth Knowing

> *Fixer, socialite, or broker: you're one call away from anyone.*

- **Power tags:** *favours owed*, *always on the guest list*
- **Weakness tag:** *owes favours too*
- **PC link:** "I introduced [PC] to the people who matter."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Contacts**	Start with **3 named contacts** (story tags). Once per session, call one for a free Discover or a minor favour.
2a	**Favour Bank**	In each Players' Turn, help a contact (spend a Check) to bank a **favour**. Spend a favour for substantial help: a safe house, troops, a pardon.
2b	**Gossip Network**	At the start of each session, ask 2 Discover questions about current rumours. When confirming rumours (Module C), roll **twice and choose**.
3a	**Power Broker**	Once per World Turn (Module C), Advance or reverse one faction clock by 1.
3b	★ **The Right Person**	Once per session, exactly the right contact for the situation happens to be present.

16. Carries the Weight of a Crown

> *Noble, officer, executive, or chieftain: you hold authority, and it holds you.*

- **Power tags:** *voice of authority*, *my name carries weight*
- **Weakness tag:** *duty before self*
- **PC link:** "[PC] serves me, or is the one person who refuses to."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Rank**	Choose where your authority applies (a realm, company, fleet, or clan). There, Create the Truth *by my order* for **1 Power**.
2a	**Retainers**	Gain loyal servants or aides as a group tag. They give free Help once per scene and handle errands.
2b	**Immunity**	Once per session, avoid arrest or legal consequences through your status.
3a	**Command the Field**	In Battle conflicts, your side gets **+4 Disposition**.
3b	★ **Holdings**	Gain a holding (keep, office, ship, estate) as a site with **3 Truths you choose**. Once per Players' Turn, one action there costs no Check.

7. Wilderness & Travel Focuses

17. Runs With the Pack

> *Beast handler, rider, falconer, or dog-musher.*

- **Power tags:** *animals trust me*, *calm voice*
- **Weakness tag:** *better with animals than people*
- **PC link:** "[PC] is the only person my animals like."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Handler**	Calm or command ordinary animals with Empathy. If you have an Animal Companion, it gains **+1 power tag**.
2a	**Pack Tactics**	Your animals give **free Help** once per scene.
2b	**Beast Lore**	Once per scene, Discover a creature's weakness tag without rolling.
3a	★ **The Pack**	Gain a group of animals (hounds, ravens, horses) with 2 power tags and 1 weakness. It acts as one group and takes statuses as a single target.
3b	**Trusted Mount**	Gain a superb mount (or upgrade one). In Chase conflicts your side gets **+3 Disposition**, and the mount carries 3 extra load.

18. Charts the Unknown

> *Explorer, navigator, or surveyor drawn to the blank parts of the map.*

- **Power tags:** *always knows north*, *mapmaker's eye*
- **Weakness tag:** *can't resist the horizon*
- **PC link:** "[PC] backed my first expedition."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Carto-grapher**	Any area you've travelled becomes a **map** (story tag). It permanently lowers travel Difficulty there by one step.
2a	**Shortcut**	Once per journey, skip one leg entirely (no rolls, no Supplies spent).
2b	**First Contact**	Your first Persuade or Empathy roll with a new people or culture gets a **free bonus die**.
3a	**Discoverer**	Once per session, discover a new site (Module C). You define **one of its three Truths**.
3b	★ **Lands Unknown**	When the party enters an uncharted region, you name **one Region Truth**.

19. Lives Off the Land

> *Survivalist, forager, or homesteader: you need nothing the world doesn't give.*

- **Power tags:** *nothing goes to waste*, *knows what's edible*
- **Weakness tag:** *distrusts civilization*
- **PC link:** "I taught [PC] how to survive their first winter."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Forager's Eye**	The party loses Supplies only **every other leg**. You clear *Hungry & Thirsty* with an Easy Survival roll.
2a	**Shelter Builder**	Allies who rest in a camp you built each clear **one Grind condition**.
2b	**Natural Remedies**	Use Survival in place of Medicine for Restore effects, using what you gather.
3a	**Hardened**	Your personal Grind clock is **2 segments larger**, and you ignore *Exposed*.
3b	★ **Living Larder**	The party never runs out of Supplies in any wild terrain that supports life.

20. Was Born Behind the Wheel

> *Driver, pilot, sailor, or rider: you and your vehicle are one.*

- **Power tags:** *my rig is part of me*, *nerves of steel at speed*
- **Weakness tag:** *can't leave her behind*
- **PC link:** "[PC] has ridden shotgun since day one."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Signature Vehicle**	Gain a vehicle (horse and cart, truck, canoe, starship) with **2 power tags**, or give your existing one 2 more.
2a	**Stunt Driver**	In Chase conflicts, your Maneuvers gain **+1 Power**.
2b	**Grease Monkey**	Repair your vehicle in the field with Craft. Restore on vehicle statuses costs **1 Power per 2 tiers**.
3a	**Ace**	Once per scene, reroll a Drive/Pilot roll for free.
3b	★ **Legendary Ride**	Your vehicle becomes an **artifact** with one special ability (ram, jump, stealth mode, impossible speed). It costs no attunement Refresh.

8. Weird Focuses ◈

21. Hunts the Things in the Dark ◈

> *Monster-hunter, exorcist, or investigator of the strange.*

- **Power tags:** *knows their weaknesses*, *silver, salt, and iron*
- **Weakness tag:** *the dark hunts me back*
- **PC link:** "[PC] saw what I saw that night, and they're the only one who believes me."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Monster Lore**	Once per scene, Discover a supernatural creature's weakness tag without rolling.
2a	**Bane**	Your Attacks against a creature whose weakness you've exploited inflict **+1 tier**.
2b	**Ward the Threshold**	Spend a scene preparing a location. For one night, supernatural creatures must beat **Formidable 21** to cross it.
3a	**Unshake-able**	When you Resist fear, possession, or corruption with Pneuma, the cost is **0 on a highest die of 5+**, and you reduce the status by 3 tiers.
3b	★ **Nemesis**	Name a supernatural foe. You always sense its direction, and your rolls against it get a **free bonus die**.

22. Walks Between Worlds ◈

> *Touched by the spirit world, the Otherworld, or the deep net.*

- **Power tags:** *one foot across the veil*, *spirits whisper to me*
- **Weakness tag:** *not quite of this world*
- **PC link:** "[PC] anchors me. Without them, I'd drift away."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Spirit Sight**	You can see and speak with spirits, ghosts, or digital entities. Once per scene, a Discover about them costs **0 Power**.
2a	**Crossing**	With a 4-segment ritual clock, step into the other world and back, bringing up to two allies.

Tier	Ability	Effect
2b	**Ghostly Ally**	A minor spirit follows you. Once per scene, it gives a free Discover about places it can reach.
3a	**Ally Beyond**	Gain a powerful patron in the other world. Once per session, call on it for a **Heroic-scope favour**; the GM gets a compel on your weakness tag in return.
3b	★ **Half-Step**	Once per scene, become intangible until your next action. Ignore one incoming physical status.

23. Made a Bargain With Something Old ◈

> *Warlock, cursed heir, or desperate deal-maker. You have power, and a debt.*

- **Power tags:** *patron's gift*, *knows the old names*
- **Weakness tag:** *the debt comes due*
- **PC link:** "[PC] knows what I traded, and hasn't told anyone."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Patron's Gift**	Gain a **minor Domain** (Generic Playbooks §8.1) tied to your patron. You can perform Easy and Standard workings with Arcana, paying Pneuma. If you're already an Adept, your Domain gets **+1 power tag** instead.
2a	**Ask the Patron**	Once per session, ask **two** Discover questions. The GM gains 1 Woe.
2b	**Not Yet**	Once per session, when you'd be Taken Out, your patron intervenes: you stay at tier 5. The GM gets a free compel on *the debt comes due* next session.
3a	**Greater Gift**	Your patron Domain works up to **Formidable 21**.
3b	★ **Borrowed Might**	Once per session, call on your patron's power directly: gain **4 Power** to spend on any Effects without a roll. The GM gains 3 Woe.

24. Is More Than Human ◈

> *Mutant, cyborg, half-fae, or carrier of a strange bloodline.*

- **Power tags:** *[your trait]*, *unnatural resilience*
- **Weakness tag:** *outsider*
- **PC link:** "[PC] saw me change and stayed anyway."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Gift**	Choose a trait (claws, enhanced senses, night vision, gills, wings, cyber-arm). Its tag may add **+1 above the normal +2 cap (maximum +3)** on related rolls. Gain +2 to one pool.
2a	**Second Trait**	Choose another trait. It also may add **+1 above the normal cap (maximum +3)**.
2b	**Regeneration**	A short rest clears **one tier-1 physical status**. A full rest clears 2 tiers from every physical status.
3a	**Apex Form**	Once per scene, unleash your nature: a **free bonus die** on Sōma and Akmē skills for the scene. At scene end, take *Weary*.
3b	★ **Beyond Limits**	Gain **+1 Edge** in two pools (max 3 each).

9. Design Notes

9.1 Coverage by Playbook

Playbook	Strong fits
Bellator	1, 2, 3, 4, 6, 16, 17, 19, 21
Furcifer	1, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 11, 13, 14, 20
Savant	7, 9, 10, 11, 12, 15, 18, 21, 22
Interlocutor	2, 8, 10, 11, 13, 14, 15, 16
Explorator	1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 9, 12, 17, 18, 19, 20
Adept	7, 9, 10, 12, 21, 22, 23
Any	23, 24

Off-type combinations are encouraged: an *Interlocutor who Masters a Weapon* is a duellist-diplomat; an *Adept who Was Born Behind the Wheel* is a witch with a haunted truck.

9.2 Things to Watch in Playtest

- **Tag-cap exceptions** (Masters a Weapon, Is More Than Human): **resolved (v0.3)** — both abilities now add **+1 above the normal +2 cap (maximum +3 from tags)** instead of ignoring the cap outright. Re-test rolls at Formidable/Heroic Difficulty after this change to confirm it still feels earned rather than trivial.
- **Once-per-session "auto-wins"** (One Shot, The Reveal, Not Here, Become Them, The Right Person): these are deliberate spotlight moments. If several players have them, the GM may limit the table to one per scene.
- **Overlap with playbook abilities:** a few Focus abilities echo playbook abilities (Beast Lore / Monster Lore, Trap Sense / Escape Artist). That's intended for off-type characters; for on-type characters, the two don't stack. Take the better one.
- ★ **distribution:** every Focus has exactly one ★ option, and it's never the Tier 1 ability, so you can always reach Tier 3 at full Refresh.
- **Gaps for v0.3:** a dedicated faith/priest Focus (non-Weird reading: "Keeps the Faith"), a scholar-of-war Focus, a merchant/trader Focus, and a performer/artist Focus.

CHAPTER VII

Frontier Rules

The old world is buried beneath the present, but it has not fallen silent. This chapter covers the setting: Campaign Truths, day and night, vampires and the blood they need, the bled, dhampirs, how the afflicted die, old-world works, contracts and the long roads between towns.

Every door in this valley opens for someone. Find out who, and you'll know who rules it.

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1. The Setting in Brief

The old world is buried beneath the present, but it has not fallen silent. Its roads, foundations and sealed rooms are everywhere; a few of its works still run. No one agrees on when it fell, and every claim to rule rests on a history that cannot all be true.

Across the **Frontier** — wherever law, knowledge and working infrastructure give out — towns bargain with ancient households, physicians dispute the teachings of religious orders, and courts fight over succession, charters and the machines that keep people alive.

Among the living are **vampires**: people who must take blood to live. They are few, long-lived, hard to kill and often indispensable. Some claim to remember the world before the fall. Most rule nothing; some rule a great deal. Their **dhampir** children are rarer still.

Tone: grim, gothic, political. Locked rooms and disputed wills, blood ledgers and charity clinics, rifles beside silver knives, and monsters who know every family in town.

Players can be dhampirs (see the Focus *Carries Her Mother's Blood*) but not full vampires.

2. Campaign Truths

Agree on these at session zero. The first five are the **core Truths**. Replace or add to them from the optional list.

2.1 Core Truths

#	Truth	In play
1	**The Kept are few and indispensable**	Vampires are rare. A single vampire is a campaign arc, not a random encounter — and killing one rarely solves the problem it was part of.
2	**Blood behind every bargain**	Every vampire depends on a supply: a household, a levy or an exchange. The supply is politics.
3	**The Frontier pays for answers and fears them**	Towns hire investigators and Hunters because they must. They don't always want what's found.
4	**The old world's works are disputed**	Machines, miracles, curses and hauntings are argued over by physicians, priests and scholars. Science and Occult both apply (§3).
5	**Dhampirs are rare, feared and coveted**	Common folk fear them. Vampire households want them — as heirs, keys or worse.

2.2 Optional Truths (d12)

d12	Truth
1	**A founder still lives** — one of the oldest vampires in the region controls a bloodline whose doors open across half the region.
2	**No one rules the whole Frontier** — no higher power is coming to settle disputes.
3	**Some vampires want to end it** — certain vampires seek death, love, escape, or a cure that may not exist.
4	**The machines still run** — old-world works keep operating with no one in charge, defended by guardians nobody controls.
5	**Old oaths bind the retainers** — hereditary retainer clans serve vampire households for pay, loyalty or debt.
6	**Hunters compete for bounties** — rival crews race for every contract. Bounties go to whoever brings back the proof.
7	**The weather is a weapon** — old weather works still run in places and still fail.
8	**The bled are suspected** — local law says anyone fed on by a vampire must be examined, confined or exiled, in case they turn.
9	**The old faith keeps the old rites** — the rites are older than anyone can explain, and some of them work.
10	**Mutants are people too** — mutants live everywhere, and how they're treated is a frontier politics question.
11	**The lights in the sky still move** — something the old world left overhead is still watching.
12	**The Hunters' Code** — Hunters keep a code: never abandon a contract, never hunt another Hunter's quarry. Breaking it makes you a target.

3. Skill List

The 20 generic skills are renamed or kept as follows. Default pools are unchanged unless noted.

Sōma	Akmē	Psychē	Pneuma
Athletics	Shoot	Notice	Will
Brawl	Stealth	Investigate	Persuade
Fight	**Ride** *(was Drive/Pilot)*	**Old Lore** *(was Lore)*	Intimidate
Endure	Craft	**Science** *(was Tech)*	Empathy
Frontier *(was Survival)*		Medicine	**Occult** *(was Arcana)*
		Deceive	

Skill	Covers in this setting
Ride	Horses, cyborg horses, wagons, hover-vehicles, land-ships, and riding through a chase.
Frontier	Wilderness survival, desert and wasteland travel, tracking, mutant animals, weather, finding water.
Old Lore	History, households and bloodlines, etiquette and succession law, charter-speech (§10.5), old-world ruins and records, the folklore of the afflicted.
Science	Repairing, using and disabling machines, old and new; cyborg parts; old-world weapons and works.
Occult	Rites, wards and religious practice; omens, relics and reliquaries; what people believe about the afflicted, and which customs they keep.
Medicine	Surgery, poisons, mutations, blood loss and transfusion (§6).

Guideline: Science and Occult often overlap. Let the player choose which applies, then fix it for that device or effect for the rest of the scene.

4. Day and Night

Time of day is always a **scene Truth**. Every scene has one.

Time Truth	Effect
Day	Direct sunlight harms vampires and dhampirs (*Sun-Sick*, §7.1). Most vampires keep indoors or underground and many keep night hours, but they are not helpless by day: a vampire in a shuttered room is as dangerous at noon as at midnight. Their retainers, guardians and machines are active.
Dusk	One scene. The GM gains **+2 Woe** as the sun sets. Vampires come out.
Night	Vampires and dhampirs see in the dark and ignore darkness Truths. Scenes at night with a vampire present add **+1 Woe** at the start of the scene (dangerous Truth). The GM may use vampire Woe spends (§14).
Dawn	One scene. A vampire in the open must reach shelter or face the sun. At the end of the scene, any vampire still in direct light gains *Sun-Sick* at tier 2 at once, then normally.

Cloud and glass: heavy cloud lessens the harm (§7.1). Experience says sunlight through a window does vampires little harm; no one agrees why.

4.1 The Dawn Clock

When the party must survive until morning, the GM sets a **Dawn clock** (usually 6 or 8 segments).

- It ticks **1 per scene** or **1 per conflict exchange**.
- Players may tick it with the **Advance** effect only by actions that waste time for the enemy (stalling, hiding, leading a chase in circles).
- When it fills, the scene becomes **Dawn**.

Use the Dawn clock as a **racing clock** against the vampire's own clock (*Breach the Village 8*, *Take the Girl 6*). Dawn doesn't destroy a vampire; it forces a choice: withdraw, or fight on while the sun takes its toll.

5. Vampires

5.1 Threat Ranks

Rank measures how dangerous a vampire is **now** — its resources, supply, allies and access to old works — not its age. A vampire who remembers the world before the fall can be any rank; one made last decade can be Paramount.

Rank	Examples	Conflict Disposition bonus	Starting Woe when introduced
Minor	A starving fugitive, a household's newest vampire, a vampire kept as a prisoner	+0	1
Established	Head of a small household, a physician with a private clinic	+2	3
Great	Head of a great house, a vampire whose bloodline opens a town's treatment works	+4	5
Paramount	A founder whose bloodline controls a region	+6	8 (and a danger clock that can end the campaign)

5.2 Hard to Kill

Vampires survive wounds that would kill anyone else.

- A vampire's physical statuses **can't go above tier 5** unless the Attack uses a **killing method** (§8.1). At tier 5 the vampire is *broken*: it can still act, at −2 on physical rolls.
- **Recovery needs blood.** A wounded or broken vampire that rests a full day **and** takes at least half a litre of blood recovers all physical statuses. Without blood, it recovers only 1 tier per day.
- **Wounds make it hungry.** Each time a vampire is *broken*, tick its **Blood Debt clock** (§5.4) by 1.
- In a scripted conflict against a vampire, reducing its Disposition to 0 achieves the winning side's intent. If the intent is "destroy it", one PC must also make a **killing strike**: one roll vs. Hard 18 using a killing method. On a failure, the vampire escapes or recovers, and the compromise is at least Significant.

5.3 Vampire Traits

Each vampire has **3–5 power tags** and **at least 1 weakness tag**, for example: *the old hospital opens for me*, *a hundred donors*, *remembers the founding*, *faster than you can see*, *sees perfectly in the dark*; and *starving*, *the doors don't know me*, *obsessed with the past*, *proud beyond reason*, *my supply runs through one man*, *believes the old stories* (§8.1). Players can learn them with **Discover**.

Pride: the long-lived are proud. Once per scene, a PC may compel a vampire's pride (spend 1 Tychē Point or 1 Momentum): it accepts a duel, gives a warning before striking, or lets an insult distract it. The GM gains 1 Woe.

5.4 Blood Debt

Every vampire needs blood regularly. The GM tracks each vampire NPC's hunger on a **Blood Debt clock** of 6 segments, one segment per week since its last full feeding.

Segments	What the players can see
0–1	Nothing.
2–3	Pallor, irritability, an unusual interest in blood (Notice, Empathy).
4	Pain, slowness, gifts failing: −1 on all its rolls. It takes risks to feed.
5	Desperate: −2 on all its rolls. Survival comes first; it may break its own rules.
6	**Husk**: the vampire dries out and goes dormant (§5.5).

- Being *broken* ticks the clock (§5.2). A full feeding clears it. A partial feeding stops it ticking that week but doesn't clear it.
- **Animal blood** counts for half: a vampire needs twice as much of it.

5.5 Husks

Sometimes a starved vampire is found dried, light and rigid, like a corpse a century dead. Stories say such bodies can wake. Stories also say they burn like kindling.

- A husk is **unconscious and helpless**. Any killing strike against it succeeds automatically, and **fire destroys it at once**.

- Waking one takes about three people's worth of blood, absorbed over hours or days. It wakes at Blood Debt 5.

5.6 The Returned

Not everyone the Kept try to make becomes one of them. The making is dangerous and often fails, and most who fail die. A few survive as something else: the **returned**.

- **What people see:** the returned are strong and grow fast, and most die young, rarely past thirty. Many are slow, literal or strange in their thinking; how much varies. They don't need blood.
- **Not dhampirs:** folk often call them dhampirs, or cursed. They are neither. Dhampirs are born to vampire mothers (*Carries Her Mother's Blood*); the returned were made, and the making failed.
- **Evidence:** old-world doors and instruments sometimes react to one of the returned oddly, as if it half-belonged to a bloodline. No one agrees why. Households that make them would rather no one asked.
- **Levies:** some towns owe children under old charters. Rumour says the few who come back are the ones who failed.
- **NPCs only:** the returned are not a player option. A PC who survives a failed making leaves player control (§6).

6. The Bled

When a vampire feeds on someone — or anyone loses a great deal of blood — the victim gains the harmful status ***Bled***.

Bled tier	Effect
1	A donation's worth. Pale and tired. No roll penalty; clears after a night's rest with food and water.
2	Light-headed: −1 on Sōma and Akmē rolls.
3	Weak: −2 on Sōma and Akmē rolls, and gain *Weary*.
4	Critical: the next harm of any kind Takes you Out. Needs a Medicine roll to stabilise.
5	Dying: Taken Out. Dies at the end of the scene unless stabilised (Medicine vs. Hard 18) or given a transfusion.
6	**Drained**. Dead — unless someone has both the reason and the means to make you one of them.

- **Gaining tiers:** a measured feeding inflicts Bled-1. A hard feeding is an Attack (+2 or more). Stacking rules apply.
- **Resisting:** Resist with **Sōma** when the blood is taken.
- **Recovery:** 1 tier per full day of rest with food and water.
- **Transfusion:** with a willing donor and a transfusion kit, a Medicine roll vs. Standard 15 lowers Bled by 1 tier per Power. The donor gains Bled-1.
- **Frontier law:** where optional Truth 8 is in play, anyone known to be bled is examined, confined or exiled. Hiding the marks is a common compel.
- A PC who is Drained and made a vampire, or who survives a failed making as one of the returned (§5.6), leaves player control.

7. Afflicted Blood: Sunlight Syndrome and the Thirst

These rules apply to vampires and dhampirs (*Carries Her Mother's Blood*).

7.1 Sunlight Syndrome

Under the **Day** Truth, in direct sunlight, the afflicted gain ***Sun-Sick***:

Condition	Dhampirs	Vampires
Direct sun, at the start of each scene	+1	+2
Merciless Sun (deserts, harsh sun)	+2	+3
Heavy overcast, per scene	+0	+1
Sunlit room or *False Dawn* (§13), per exchange	+1	+1

- Sun-Sick is a harmful status: it applies its tier as a penalty to physical rolls (Sōma and Akmē skills).

- Resist with **Sōma** as normal. A wide hat, a dark cloak or partial shade counts as **+1 Sōma Edge** for that Resist.
- While Sun-Sick is at tier 1+, abilities and rules that heal the afflicted (vampire recovery, *Mother's Blood*, *Dhampir Regeneration*) don't work.
- A vampire at Sun-Sick 4+ also gains *burning-1* each scene in the sun.
- **Recovery:** a full scene in shade or darkness lowers Sun-Sick by 2 tiers. At night it clears completely.
- **Tier 6:** collapse. Taken Out until carried into shade. A dhampir left for a whole day gains a Sōma Scar. A vampire left in direct sun for a full day is destroyed.

7.2 The Thirst

Dhampirs have a **Thirst** status, tier 0–6. It doesn't penalise rolls until tier 3. A dhampir has no weekly need for blood; the Thirst rises only from what happens to them.

Trigger	Thirst
A scene with fresh blood spilled nearby (yours or someone else's)	+1
You're Taken Out, or a pool drops to 2 or less	+1
You use an ability marked *Thirst* in its entry	+1 (or as listed)
The GM compels the Thirst and you accept (gain a Tychē Point)	+1
A full night of rest	−1
Animal blood (a scene, no roll)	−1
A cup or so of human blood — drunk, through broken skin or by transfusion (a scene, no roll)	−2
Half a litre or more of human blood at once	Clear completely. If taken by force, gain a Pneuma Scar the first time (*I've tasted it*)

Thirst tier	Effect
0–2	No effect.
3–4	−1 on Pneuma rolls when blood is visible. Others notice you're hungry (Empathy, Notice).
5	In every scene with a bleeding human, Resist with Pneuma or move towards them.
6	**Blood Crisis**: you choose — feed from the nearest source this scene, **or** refuse, collapse (Taken Out) and gain a Pneuma Scar. Either way, Thirst drops to 3 afterwards.

Never feeding is a Belief, not a rule. Blood Crisis keeps the choice, and the cost of refusing, with the player.

8. How the Afflicted Die, and Hunter's Gear

8.1 Killing Methods and Folklore

A **killing method** is a tag that lets an Attack take a vampire to **tier 6: destroyed** (§5.2).

Method	Effect	Notes
Beheading	Killing method	The one sure way. The blade must be able to cut through (*heavy*, *fine*, or a dhampir's strength).
Fire (sustained)	Killing method against a vampire with a tier-4+ physical status; destroys a husk at once	A burning house, a funeral pyre.
Sunlight	No killing strike, but stops recovery and burns over time (§7.1)	A collapsed vampire left in direct sun for a full day is destroyed.
Stake through the heart	Not a killing method. Inflicts *staked*: the vampire can't act or recover while the stake stays in	Finish it with beheading or fire — or bargain with it while it's helpless.
Silver	Not a killing method. Wounds from *silvered* weapons can't be recovered until the next full day	An old custom. No one remembers why it works.

Method	Effect	Notes
Crosses, garlic, running water, invitations	No physical effect	Folk practice. Some vampires believe in them anyway (below).

Believers: a vampire may carry the weakness tag *believes the old stories*, or a specific one (*won't cross running water*, *can't bear the cross*). Against that vampire, the folk remedy works as a **compel**, not a law of nature: the vampire accepts it (the GM gains 1 Woe) or the GM spends 1 Woe to defy it.

Any personal weakness tag of a vampire can be **upgraded to a killing method** with 3 Power from Discover and Create effects, or a downtime clock (8 segments).

8.2 Currency and Wealth

The setting's currency is the **mark**. The 2d12 System doesn't track coins; use these story tags instead:

Wealth tag	Means
broke	Can't buy anything without a favour or a trade
a few marks	A meal, a night at the inn, a box of bolts
a fat purse	A horse, a gun, a doctor's fee
a lord's bounty	A cyborg horse, an old-world weapon, a farm

8.3 Setting Gear

Weapons and gear use the equipment rules in *Generic Playbooks* §2 (load, gear as tags, armour). These are common across playbooks:

Load	Item	Tags
0	Wooden stake, belt knife, flint striker, water skin	*stake* (inflicts *staked*)
1	Silver-edged knife or blade	*silvered*
1	Charms: garlic bundle, cross, saint's medal	*steadies the nerves* (+1 Pneuma Edge against fear); works on *believers* only (§8.1)
1	Steel neck guard	*Armour 1* against bites only; Bled from bites gains 1 fewer tier
1	Crossbow and wooden bolts	*+1 Attack* (range), *bolts are stakes* (*staked* at range, Hard 18)
1	Revolver or rifle	*+1 Attack* (range)
2	Laser rifle (rare, old-world)	*+1 Attack* (range), *burns through armour*; depletion 1 in d12 (power cell)
1	Long cloak and wide hat	+1 Sōma Edge when Resisting Sun-Sick; *+1 Feint* in the dark
1	Signal mirrors	By day, create *Sunlit* in a room with a window or opening for one scene (2 Power)
1	True-light lamp (rare relic)	Create *False Dawn* for one exchange (2 Power); depletion 1 in d12
1	Flares	Light only; ends darkness Truths for one exchange
1	Transfusion kit	Needed for transfusion (§6); *+1* on Medicine against Bled
0	Cyborg horse (vehicle)	*tireless*, *fast as the wind*; not on foot missions. Treat as a story tag when absent
0	Normal horse or mule (vehicle)	*sure-footed*; ticks the Grind clock 1 less per leg

9. Old-World Works

Old-world machines and relics use **Module A — Cyphers & Artifacts**.

9.1 Old-World Cyphers (d12)

d12	Cypher	Tier	Effect
1	True-light capsule	4	Attack (*Sun-Sick* +2) against one vampire; a killing method only against a husk
2	Blood ampoule	3	Restore 3 Sōma; a dhampir also loses 2 Thirst
3	Mist grenade	3	Create *Thick Mist* for a scene
4	Gravity disc	4	Create *Weightless* in a small area, or carry a heavy load as light
5	Mind-seal patch	3	Restore (fear); +1 to Resist intimidation and *Presence* (§14)

D12	Cypher	Tier	Effect
6	Bloodline vial	2	A vial of a vampire's blood: opens one door of its bloodline, or quiets one of its guardians for a scene
7	Holo-ghost	3	Create *Decoy* (a false image of yourself) for a scene
8	Electro-whip charge	4	Attack (*stunned*), or +1 Attack in a conflict for one exchange
9	Healing gel	3	Restore (wounds) 3 tiers, divided as you like
10	Weather pill	4	Create a weather Truth (*Sudden Storm*, *Clear Skies*) for one scene
11	Sound blaster	3	Attack (*deafened*), Disrupt one Occult effect
12	Unknown relic	d6	The player names a reasonable Effect; the GM sets the form and adds a quirk

9.2 Old-World Artifacts

The Order of the Last Guns (working name) was an order of armed charter-enforcers in a neighbouring province, destroyed there in a succession war. The Frontier sees only what it left behind: refugees, claimants and a few of its sidearms, which no one can make any more. Whoever carries one claims to speak for the old enforcing authority.

Old-world artifacts carry the standard quirk ***its owners will want it back***: it can be compelled for Tychē Points, and the GM may spend 1 Woe to make its old owners, or their heirs, notice it.

★ ***Old-World Longsword*** — Tags: *old-world steel, +1 Attack (conflict gear).* Ability: *counts as a killing method for beheading; ignores* Armour *on vampires.* Depletion: *none.* Quirk: *its owners will want it back.*

★ ***Dimension Pocket*** — Tags: *holds more than it should.* Ability: *carry up to 3 extra load. Once per session, draw out an item you could plausibly have stored (no Momentum cost).* Depletion: *1 in d12 (it opens somewhere else for a scene).* Quirk: *things inside come out wrong.*

★ ***Cybernetic Eye*** — Tags: *sees in the dark, sees heat.* Ability: *once per scene, free Discover about anything in your line of sight.* Depletion: *1 in d12 (blind in that eye for a scene).* Quirk: *its owners will want it back.*

★ ***Order Sidearm*** — Tags: *old-world revolver, +1 Attack (range), recognised on sight.* Ability: *ignores* Armour *on vampires. Worn openly, it is a claim to speak for the Order of the Last Guns: a free bonus die on Persuade and Intimidate with people who remember the Order.* Locked: *many fire only for someone registered in the Order's armoury log; for anyone else such a gun is a heavy club.* Depletion: *1 in d12 (the last proper cartridges are spent until more are found).* Quirk: *its owners will want it back — and so will every claimant.*

Blood Locket — Tags: *holds a vampire's blood.* Ability: *that bloodline's doors and guardians half-recognise you (+1 die).* Depletion: *1 in d12 (the blood spoils).* Quirk: *the bloodline's records note every door you open.*

9.3 The Moving Lights

On a clear night, a few lights cross the sky faster than any star and never twinkle. They are old-world works, left overhead when the old world fell. Most are dead. A few still answer.

- **Under open sky only:** roofs, earth, deep canyons, thick forest and storms (*Sudden Storm*) cut them off.
- **Uses:** the Passenger can reach its bearer through them (*Carries a Passenger*), and a mind sent abroad can ride them (*Sends the Mind Abroad*). Some households keep old instruments that listen to them.
- **Overheard:** anything sent through the moving lights may be heard by whoever is listening.
- **Optional Truth 11** (§2.2, *The lights in the sky still move*): if it is in play, something up there is also watching.

10. Bounties, Commissions and Contracts

Most sessions start with a contract. The contract is the party's shared **Goal**. A contract is a **Bounty** (a quarry), a **Commission** (an investigation), an **Escort** or a **Recovery**.

10.1 Contract Sheet

Element	Example
Type	Bounty

Element	Example
Client	The town council, on behalf of a farmer whose daughter was fed on
Quarry	Lord Varn, a vampire (rank: Established)
Proof required	His head, his blood ledger, or his signet ring
Bounty	*a lord's bounty* (a Great vampire: two)
Deadline	Before the levy is collected (danger clock, 6 segments)
Complication	Lord Varn insists he hasn't fed in five weeks — and a rival Hunter crew has the same contract

10.2 Negotiating the Fee

Haggling with a client is a **Negotiation** conflict if it meets the conflict test (Core Rules §10.1); otherwise one Persuade roll vs. Standard 15.

- Each Power above 1 raises the fee by one step (*a fat purse* → *a lord's bounty*), or adds a perk (an advance, a horse, room and board, a share of the estate's salvage).
- A dhampir negotiating with humans faces the Truth *Feared and Despised* (+1 step Difficulty), unless they're already known and trusted. With a vampire household, they may face *Coveted* instead (§13).

10.3 Reputation

A Hunter's reputation is a **power tag** gained at milestones (*the Hunter who burned the Roth estate*). It counts as a tag on Persuade and Intimidate with Frontier folk. A **bad reputation** (*took the money and ran*) is a weakness tag that clients and rivals compel.

10.4 Rival Hunters

Rival crews use the **Faction Turn** rules (Module C.5) with a project clock on the same quarry. If their clock fills first, they claim the bounty, and the party's contract becomes a Disposition fight with the rivals (often a Negotiation or a Chase rather than a Fight).

10.5 Charter-Speech and Binding Instruments

Charters, testaments, compacts and levy agreements bind only if they are written or sworn in **charter-speech**: an archaic legal and liturgical form of the language. Notaries, clergy and record clerks can compose it, and so can some of the Kept. Most people can only recognise it.

- **Reading** an instrument in charter-speech is an Old Lore roll vs. Standard 15. **Composing** one correctly is Old Lore vs. Hard 18, or Standard 15 with a tag such as *fluent in the old pacts*.
- **Finding a flaw:** a Discover effect on an instrument (Old Lore or Investigate) can reveal an error in its charter-speech. The flaw becomes a tag, for example *the oath was sworn in the wrong form*.
- **Grounds, not a verdict:** a flaw is grounds to challenge the instrument. It does not void it. The challenge is settled by a Negotiation, a Duel of Wills or the politics around it, and the flaw is a tag the challenger can use there. Whoever benefits from the instrument will argue that the error doesn't matter.

11. Setting Conflict Types

These add to the conflict types in Core Rules §10.4. All use the standard scripting, Disposition and compromise rules.

Type	Disposition	Attack	Defend	Feint	Maneuver
Hunt (track a vampire or monster to its lair)	Frontier or Investigate	Investigate / Frontier	Will / Endure	Deceive	Notice / Stealth
Siege Until Dawn (hold a town or camp until morning)	Old Lore (tactics) or Craft	Shoot / Fight	Craft / Endure	Deceive	Notice
Duel of Wills (an interrogation, an audience, a stare-down with something old and patient)	Will	Intimidate / Persuade	Will	Deceive	Empathy
Estate Assault (break into a household or old-world facility)	Science or Stealth	Science / Fight	Endure / Athletics	Stealth	Old Lore

Type	Disposition	Attack	Defend	Feint	Maneuver
Chase (setting note)	Ride or Athletics	Ride / Shoot	Ride	Stealth	Frontier

11.1 Special Rules

- **Hunt:** the winner gets their intent *and* chooses the time of the confrontation (day or night). If the party wins with the quarry's lair found by day, the next scene starts with **Day**, and the quarry is shut in, away from the sun.
- **Siege Until Dawn:** run alongside the **Dawn clock** (§4.1). Each exchange ticks it by 1. If the Dawn clock fills before either side hits 0 Disposition, the vampire side must withdraw or face the sun: the defenders win with a compromise based on their remaining Disposition.
- **Duel of Wills:** there is no hypnosis; this is pressure, fear and bargaining. A PC who loses is **Taken Out** of the contest and must follow the vampire's intent for one scene, out of obligation, fear or a bargain struck. A vampire who loses withdraws or reveals something (lose 1 power tag for the session).
- **Estate Assault:** each exchange, the GM may spend 1 Woe to wake a guardian (reinforcement) instead of buying a bonus die. If an estate is taken by day, its vampire's Disposition in the next Fight starts −2.

12. The Frontier: Travel and Region Truths

Use **Module B — The Grind & Travel**. The Frontier is harsh: most Grind clocks are **6**; deserts and old-poisoned lands are **4**.

12.1 Frontier Travel Notes

- The Guide rolls **Ride** or **Frontier**.
- **Cyborg horses** don't eat or tire: a party with them ignores the first Grind tick each leg. Normal horses need water: Supplies drop by 2 per leg in deserts.
- **Night travel** halves Grind clock size, but every encounter is at Night.

12.2 Frontier Truth Generator (d12)

Use with Module C.3. Roll once per column or pick.

d12	Terrain / Feature	Atmosphere	Hazard	Secret
1	Fortified farming town	Sullen, watching faces	Townsfolk with torches	Someone in town is secretly feeding a vampire
2	Vampire estate on a crag	Silent music at midnight	Guardian machines	The vampire wants to die
3	Endless desert	Merciless sun	Sand creatures under the dunes	A buried old-world city
4	Ruined old-world city	Wind through dead towers	Radiation pockets	An old-world weapon
5	Haunted forest	Mist that never lifts	Mutant beasts	A retainer-clan camp
6	Trading post and saloon	Whiskey and fear	Rival Hunters	A household's spy runs the bar
7	Swamp of failed experiments	Wet, rotting heat	Bioweapon remnants	A creature that can speak
8	Abandoned treatment works	Lights still on	Automated defences	Records of the original treatment, maybe
9	Dry riverbed and canyon	Dust storms	Bandits on cyborg horses	A water source someone poisoned
10	Mountain pass	Biting cold	Avalanche	A monk who remembers the founding
11	Weather-control tower	Storms that come out of nowhere	Lightning	The tower still answers orders
12	Graveyard of Hunters	Unnatural stillness	A husk among the graves	A famous Hunter didn't die here

13. Scene Truths

Pick 1–3 for each scene, in addition to the **time Truth** (§4).

Truth	Typical effect
Moonlit	Stealth is harder for everyone; vampires and dhampirs see clearly
Moonless	+1 step Difficulty to Notice; vampires and dhampirs ignore it
Merciless Sun	Sun-Sick +2 per scene for dhampirs, +3 for vampires (§7.1)
Overcast	Sun-Sick +1 per scene for vampires; none for dhampirs
Sunlit	Direct sun indoors (mirrors, a broken roof): Sun-Sick +1 per exchange
Warded Village	The townsfolk believe they're safe. Believers (§8.1) won't cross without defying a compel; everyone else finds the townsfolk armed and watching (+1 step Difficulty to Stealth)
Custom of Invitation	Entering a home uninvited breaks local custom: if seen, the scene gains *Hostile Crowd*. Believers must defy a compel
Their Own House	Inside a place that answers to the vampire's bloodline: its Woe spends cost 1 less (minimum 1)
Frightened Villagers	+1 step Difficulty to Persuade; failures may start a mob
Feared and Despised	Dhampirs and mutants: +1 step Difficulty to all social rolls with humans
Coveted	A dhampir among a vampire household: social rolls are one step easier, but every success puts them further in the household's debt
Thick Mist	+1 step Difficulty to Shoot and Notice
Guardian Machines	A danger clock of 4: when it fills, the guardians attack
Blood on the Air	Thirst +1 for dhampirs; a vampire at Blood Debt 3+ must act on it or take −1
False Dawn	True-light lamps: vampires gain Sun-Sick +1 per exchange, can't recover, and take −1 on all rolls (lasts one exchange or scene)
Dust Storm	+1 step Difficulty to Ride, Shoot and Notice
Hostile Crowd	Standard Truth: social rolls harder, violence draws a mob

14. Woe Spends: Vampires

Use with Core Rules §9.2.

GM spend	Cost	Effect
Presence	1	A PC facing the vampire takes *shaken-2* (Resist with Pneuma). Start a Duel of Wills if it matters
Summon the Household	1	A retainer, donor or dependant arrives and obeys — out of loyalty, debt, love or fear
The Old Door	2	The vampire leaves through a way only its bloodline can open, or a passage nobody knew was there
Kennel and Guardians	2	Trained animals, mutant creatures or old-world guardians that answer to it arrive as a minion group
Uncanny Speed	1	The vampire acts first or changes its scripted action for 1 Woe (instead of 3). Not at Blood Debt 4+
The House Answers	3	Requires *Their Own House*. Create a facility Truth (*Shifting Halls*, *Sealed Doors*, *Lights Fail*, *Gravity Fails*)
Blood Reserve	3	Once per session, if blood is at hand (stored, a donor, a victim), a *broken* vampire feeds and recovers 2 tiers of physical status. It leaves evidence
Weather Turns	2	Create a weather Truth for the scene; requires old weather works nearby
Retainer	3	A significant retainer or ally arrives

15. Design Notes

- **Hard to Kill (§5.2)** keeps the two-stage fight — wear it down, then a killing strike — but ties recovery to blood. Wounding a vampire makes it hungrier, and a hungry vampire is a different problem. Watch how long this makes fights; if too long, allow the killing strike as part of the final Attack instead of a separate roll.
- **The Bled and the Thirst** are both statuses, so the existing Restore, Resist and compel rules work on them. Bled is plain blood loss; its tier 6 is death, with one ominous exception.

- **Day and night** no longer switch vampires on and off. Sunlight is a cost, not a cage; the daytime advantage comes from finding where a vampire is and getting light in.
- **Folklore** works through belief, not physics. The *believer* rule lets old remedies matter at the table without becoming true.
- **Sunlight Syndrome** still limits dhampirs by day, when the rest of the party is strongest. That trade is the core of the dhampir's role.
- **Science vs. Occult:** keep the line blurred on purpose. The guideline in §3 stops arguments without forcing a fixed answer.
- **Contracts as Goals** give the party a shared Goal each session, and personal Goals sit inside it.
- **The returned (§5.6)** are NPCs only. They give failed makings a face and a body of evidence without adding a second dhampir option.
- **Charter-speech (§10.5)** gives Old Lore a political edge: a flawed oath opens a dispute rather than ending one.

CHAPTER VIII

Frontier Descriptors

Twenty adjectives for people hardened by the Frontier: the Bitten, the Coveted, the Frontier-Hard, the Vengeful. Each comes with a Frontier hook, one question about your past that often becomes your first Belief.

The adjective of the character sentence.

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1. Descriptor Rules

Each Descriptor gives (Core Rules §3.1):

Element	Detail
Pool bonus	+2 to one pool
Power tag	1
Weakness tag	1 (can be compelled for Tychē Points)
Suggested Instinct	Use it or write your own

Each entry also has a **Frontier hook**: one question to answer at character creation. The answer often becomes your first Belief or a relationship.

2. Quick Reference

#	Descriptor	Pool	Power tag	Weakness tag
1	Bitten	Pneuma	*I've been bled and lived*	*marks on my throat*
2	Bitter	Psychē	*expects the worst*	*trusts no one*
3	City-Born	Psychē	*educated in the city*	*soft hands*
4	Charming	Pneuma	*a smile that opens doors*	*can't resist a pretty face*
5	Cold	Pneuma	*nothing shows on my face*	*pushes people away*
6	Coveted	Pneuma	*beauty the vampires notice*	*the Kept want me*
7	Cunning	Psychē	*always a second plan*	*too clever by half*
8	Devout	Pneuma	*faith the dark can feel*	*won't break my vows*
9	Doomed	Pneuma	*nothing left to lose*	*death rides beside me*
10	Feral	Akmē	*senses of a beast*	*forgets my manners*
11	Frontier-Hard	Sōma	*grew up on the Frontier*	*slow to trust strangers*
12	Gentle	Pneuma	*people open up to me*	*can't kill without cause*
13	Greedy	Psychē	*knows what everything's worth*	*a price for everything*
14	Hollow-Eyed	Psychē	*seen too much to scare*	*nightmares every night*
15	Mutated	Sōma	*body of the wastes*	*they call me monster*
16	Reckless	Akmē	*first through the door*	*doesn't wait*
17	Scarred	Sōma	*survived worse than this*	*old wounds ache*
18	Silent	Akmē	*says nothing, sees everything*	*people don't know where they stand*
19	Superstitious	Psychē	*knows every folk charm*	*jumps at shadows*
20	Vengeful	Sōma	*I don't forget*	*will drop anything for revenge*

3. Descriptors

1. Bitten

> *A vampire drank from you once and let you live. The marks never faded.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *I've been bled and lived*
- **Weakness tag:** *marks on my throat*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always keep my collar buttoned."
- **Frontier hook:** Which vampire bit you, and why did it stop?

2. Bitter

> *The Frontier taught you that hope is how people get killed.*

- **Pool:** +2 Psychē
- **Power tag:** *expects the worst*
- **Weakness tag:** *trusts no one*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always ask who benefits."
- **Frontier hook:** Who betrayed you, and do they still live?

3. City-Born

> *You grew up behind the city's walls, with books, machines, and safety. The Frontier is a different world.*

- **Pool:** +2 Psychē
- **Power tag:** *educated in the city*
- **Weakness tag:** *soft hands*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always look for the scientific explanation first."
- **Frontier hook:** Why did you leave the city, and can you ever go back?

4. Charming

> *People like you. Even the ones who shouldn't.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *a smile that opens doors*
- **Weakness tag:** *can't resist a pretty face*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always buy the first round."
- **Frontier hook:** Who in the last town is still waiting for you to come back?

5. Cold

> *You learned to feel nothing. It keeps you alive.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *nothing shows on my face*
- **Weakness tag:** *pushes people away*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Never say goodbye."
- **Frontier hook:** What was the last thing that made you weep?

6. Coveted

> *You have the kind of beauty the Kept collect: as brides, as servants, as trophies.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *beauty the vampires notice*
- **Weakness tag:** *the Kept want me*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always cover my face when I travel at night."
- **Frontier hook:** Which vampire household has already sent for you?

7. Cunning

> *You win by thinking. Fights are for people who planned badly.*

- **Pool:** +2 Psychē
- **Power tag:** *always a second plan*
- **Weakness tag:** *too clever by half*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always know the way out before I go in."
- **Frontier hook:** What scheme of yours went wrong, and who paid for it?

8. Devout

> *The old faith is nearly gone, but you still keep it. Crosses don't burn anyone, but the rites still matter.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *faith the dark can feel*
- **Weakness tag:** *won't break my vows*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always pray before a hunt."
- **Frontier hook:** What vow did you make, and who did you make it to?

9. Doomed

> *A seer, a vampire, or a doctor told you how you'll die. You believe them.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *nothing left to lose*
- **Weakness tag:** *death rides beside me*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always volunteer for the worst job."
- **Frontier hook:** How will you die, and what must you finish first?

10. Feral

> *Raised in the wastes, by animals, mutants, or no one at all.*

- **Pool:** +2 Akmē
- **Power tag:** *senses of a beast*
- **Weakness tag:** *forgets my manners*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always sleep with my back to a wall."
- **Frontier hook:** What raised you, and is it still out there?

11. Frontier-Hard

> *Born in a fortified village and raised on dust, chores, and sunset curfews.*

- **Pool:** +2 Sōma
- **Power tag:** *grew up on the Frontier*
- **Weakness tag:** *slow to trust strangers*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always bar the door at sunset."
- **Frontier hook:** What happened to your home village?

12. Gentle

> *Kindness is rare on the Frontier. You haven't lost yours, yet.*

- **Pool:** +2 Pneuma
- **Power tag:** *people open up to me*
- **Weakness tag:** *can't kill without cause*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always offer the enemy a chance to surrender."
- **Frontier hook:** Who did you spare, and did they deserve it?

13. Greedy

> *Hunting is a job. Jobs pay. Better jobs pay more.*

- **Pool:** +2 Psychē
- **Power tag:** *knows what everything's worth*
- **Weakness tag:** *a price for everything*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always search the bodies."
- **Frontier hook:** What are you saving up for?

14. Hollow-Eyed

> *You've seen what vampires do in their estates. Nothing frightens you anymore, not even in your sleep.*

- **Pool:** +2 Psychē
- **Power tag:** *seen too much to scare*
- **Weakness tag:** *nightmares every night*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always stay awake on the first watch."
- **Frontier hook:** What did you see in the estate?

15. Mutated

> *The old wars and the old-world experiments left their mark on your bloodline: scales, extra senses, a too-long arm, eyes that glow.*

- **Pool:** +2 Sōma
- **Power tag:** *body of the wastes*
- **Weakness tag:** *they call me monster*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always wear the hood in town."
- **Frontier hook:** What is your mutation, and who first called you monster?

16. Reckless

> *Waiting gets people killed too. You'd rather it be on your terms.*

- **Pool:** +2 Akmē
- **Power tag:** *first through the door*
- **Weakness tag:** *doesn't wait*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always charge when they hesitate."
- **Frontier hook:** Who died because you didn't wait?

17. Scarred

> *Claw marks, burns, a missing finger. Every one is a story and a lesson.*

- **Pool:** +2 Sōma
- **Power tag:** *survived worse than this*
- **Weakness tag:** *old wounds ache*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always check the wound before the pain."
- **Frontier hook:** Which scar do you never talk about?

18. Silent

> *You speak rarely. People fill the silence with the truth.*

- **Pool:** +2 Akmē
- **Power tag:** *says nothing, sees everything*
- **Weakness tag:** *people don't know where they stand*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always listen before I speak."
- **Frontier hook:** Why did you stop talking?

19. Superstitious

> *Garlic in your pockets, salt across the doorway, a charm for every danger. Some of them even work.*

- **Pool:** +2 Psychē
- **Power tag:** *knows every folk charm*
- **Weakness tag:** *jumps at shadows*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always follow the old rules: no whistling after dark, no mirrors covered."
- **Frontier hook:** Which charm saved your life, and who taught it to you?

20. Vengeful

> *Someone took everything from you. You'll take it back, in blood.*

- **Pool:** +2 Sōma
- **Power tag:** *I don't forget*
- **Weakness tag:** *will drop anything for revenge*
- **Suggested Instinct:** "Always ask strangers about the one I'm hunting."
- **Frontier hook:** Who are you hunting, and what did they take?

4. Sample Sentences

- "I am a **Bitten Frontier Doctor** who **Heals the Bled**."
- "I am a **Cold Sellsword** who **Carries Her Mother's Blood**."
- "I am a **Greedy Broker** who **Collects the Bounty**."
- "I am a **Feral Mutant** who **Hunts the Beasts of the Frontier**."
- "I am a **Vengeful Cyborg Hunter** who **Seeks Revenge on a Vampire**."
- "I am a **Superstitious Warden** who **Holds the Line Until Dawn**."
- "I am a **Coveted Occultist** who **Loves What It Should Hate**."

CHAPTER IX

Frontier Playbooks

Nine ways to earn a living hunting the things that hunt humanity. Six reskin the generic playbooks; the Mutant, the Cyborg Hunter and the Warden are new to the Frontier.

Sellsword · Stalker · Frontier Doctor · Broker · Rider · Occultist · Mutant · Cyborg Hunter · Warden

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Playbook Overview

#	Playbook	Reskin of	Anchor	Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	Role
1	Sellsword	Bellator	Fight or Brawl	12 / 10 / 6 / 8	Front-line Hunter, bodyguard, stake-driver
2	Stalker	Furcifer	Stealth	8 / 12 / 8 / 8	Estate thief, assassin, day-hunter of sleeping vampires
3	Frontier Doctor	Savant	Medicine or Old Lore	7 / 8 / 13 / 8	Healer, scholar, treats the bled
4	Broker	Interlocutor	Persuade	7 / 9 / 9 / 11	Bounty broker, gambler, village elder, negotiator
5	Rider	Explorator	Frontier	11 / 11 / 7 / 7	Tracker, scout, marksman, horse-master
6	Occultist	Adept	Occult or Science	7 / 8 / 9 / 12	Psychic, curse-witch, old-world scavenger
7	Mutant	New	Athletics or Stealth	11 / 11 / 6 / 8	Monster-blooded fighter and infiltrator
8	Cyborg Hunter	New	Shoot or Fight	12 / 9 / 9 / 6	Rebuilt killer with implants
9	Warden	New	Craft	10 / 9 / 9 / 8	Village defender, trap-maker, siege leader

Dhampirs are not a playbook. Any playbook can take the Focus *Carries Her Mother's Blood* (*Frontier Focuses*).

Skill names follow *Frontier Rules* §3 (Ride, Frontier, Old Lore, Science, Occult).

I. Sellsword

> *Muscle for hire. You stand between the village and the thing coming out of the dark, and you hold the stake when it's time.*

Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	12 / 10 / 6 / 8
Edge	Sōma 2, plus 1 in Akmē or Pneuma
Anchor skill	Fight or Brawl
Suggested skills	+4 Fight · +3 Athletics, Endure · +2 Brawl, Intimidate, Shoot · +1 Notice, Will, Frontier, Ride
XP trigger	Address a challenge with force or threats

Playbook tags (choose 2): *built like a wall · veteran of a dozen hunts · scarred and unbothered · iron grip · knows how a fight will go · the look that empties a saloon*



I.I Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Juggernaut**	When you Resist physical harm with Sōma, reduce the status by **3 tiers** instead of 2.
2	**Stake Driver**	When you make a **killing strike** (Frontier Rules §5.2) or drive a stake with Fight or Brawl, gain a **free bonus die**. On a success, the vampire can't spend Woe on *Blood Reserve* this session.
3	**Bodyguard**	When an ally within reach would suffer a consequence, you may take it instead. If you Resist it, your Edge counts as 1 higher for that roll. This includes a vampire's bite: you can take the bite (Bled) in their place.
4	**Wade Through Them**	When you attack a group or minions (wolves, retainer packs, mobs), you get **one free Extra Feat** per roll.
5	**Menacing**	You may use **Sōma** for Intimidate Effort and Resistance. When you succeed on Intimidate against minions or a mob, spend 1 Momentum to make them flee, surrender, or freeze.
6	**Pain Tolerance**	Ignore the roll penalty from harmful physical statuses of tier 1–2. At tier 3+, the penalty is reduced by 1. This also applies to *Sun-Sick*.
7	★ **Blood Fury**	Once per scene, enter a fury: you get **+1 bonus die** (free) on Fight, Brawl, and Athletics rolls for the rest of the scene. You can't script Defend or retreat. At scene end, lose 2 Sōma or take *Weary*. If you have afflicted blood, gain +1 Thirst.
8	★ **Last One Standing**	Once per scene, when a status would reach tier 6 on you, keep acting until the end of the scene. Then you're Taken Out as normal.
◆	**A Name the Kept Know**	Your reputation is a **Campaign Truth** (*"Vampires have heard of [name]"*). In Fight conflicts, vampire and retainer Disposition starts **−2**. Once per session, a vampire's pride compel against you costs nothing.

1.2 Starting Equipment

Signature weapon (choose 1)

Option	Item
A	**Longsword & stake belt** (2) — *+1 Attack*, *stakes always at hand* (you never need to declare a stake as load)
B	**Great-axe** (2) — *+1 Attack*, *heavy enough to behead*: counts as beheading (a killing method) against a vampire with a tier-4+ physical status

Playbook kit (declare during play)

Load	Item
1	Leather and mail coat (light armour)
2	Plate cuirass and gorget (heavy armour; also counts as a steel neck guard)
1	Throwing stakes ×3 — *+1 Attack* (range), *staked* at Hard 18
1	Chain and manacles
1	Whetstone and oil
1	Flask of Frontier whiskey

Always carried (0): wooden stake, knuckle-wraps, a trophy from your first kill.

1.3 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "A village that pays me gets my blood, not just my blade." / "Vampires are only as strong as the fear they feed on."
- **Goal:** "Get the farmer's family to the next town by sunset." / "Drive a stake into Count Varnas."
- **Instinct:** "Always stand between my friends and the door." / "Never let a vampire finish its speech."

Relationships: Ally — a blacksmith who makes your stakes, an old hunting partner, a saloon keeper who gives you credit. Rival — a rival Hunter who stole your last bounty, a retainer who beat you once, a sheriff who wants you gone.

2. Stalker

You hunt by day. While the vampire sleeps, you climb the estate walls, pick the locks, find the coffin, and open it.

Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	8 / 12 / 8 / 8
Edge	Akmē 2, plus 1 in Psychē or Sōma
Anchor skill	Stealth
Suggested skills	+4 Stealth · +3 Notice, Craft · +2 Athletics, Deceive, Shoot · +1 Fight, Science, Investigate, Old Lore
XP trigger	Address a challenge with stealth or precision

Playbook tags (choose 2): *light on my feet · eyes in the back of my head · steady hands · knows estate layouts · forgettable face · patient as a stone*



2.1 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Ghost**	When you spend Effort on a Stealth roll, your first use of Effort costs 0 pool points. Once per scene, when spotted, spend 1 Momentum to declare you were never seen; you're in a nearby hidden position.
2	**Coffin Finder**	Once per day inside an estate, ruin, or lair, ask a free **Discover**: "Where does it sleep?" or "Where's the weak point in this place?"
3	**Light Fingers**	When you succeed on a theft, plant, or sabotage roll (Stealth or Craft), gain a **free Extra Feat**.
4	**Infiltrator**	Once per roll, ignore one Truth that would raise the Difficulty of sneaking, climbing, or bypassing security, including estate Truths such as *Guardian Machines* or *Shifting Halls*.
5	**Quick Reflexes**	You always act first when violence breaks out. In conflicts, changing one of your scripted actions costs **1 Momentum** instead of 2.
6	**Escape Artist**	When you Resist capture, restraint, falls, or traps with Akmē, the cost is **0 on a highest die of 5+**.
7	★ **Flashback**	Once per mission, declare a flashback to something you prepared earlier. Pay Momentum by plausibility: 0 (obvious), 1 (reasonable), 2 (a stretch), 3 (wild). Then roll as normal; on a success, it happened.
8	★ **Strike While It Sleeps**	Against an unaware, *Impeded*, or sleeping target, Attack effects cost **half Power (round up)**. A killing strike against a sleeping vampire is **Standard 15** instead of Hard 18.
◆	**Nobody Sees Me Coming**	Once per session, declare you're already somewhere you could plausibly have reached. Your first roll there gets **+2 bonus dice for free**, and the GM can't spend Woe to reveal you during that roll.

2.2 Starting Equipment

Signature item (choose 1)

Option	Item
A	**Wooden throwing needles** (1) — *+1 Attack* (range), *silent*, *staked* at Hard 18
B	**Grapple-line gauntlet** (1) — *+1 Maneuver*, *climbs any wall*; Advance a climbing or entry clock +1 per roll

Playbook kit (declare during play)

Load	Item
1	Padded dark jacket (light armour)
1	Lockpicks and an old-world key-probe — *opens what's closed*, works on old-world locks at +1 step Difficulty
1	Long knives and garrotte — *+1 Attack*, *+1 Feint*
1	Smoke pellets ×2 — *+1 Feint*, Create *Thick Mist* (1 Power)
1	Climbing spikes and silk rope (15 m)
1	Hooded lantern and mirror shard — by day, throws sunlight into a dark room (*Sunlit* for one exchange)

Always carried (0): wooden stake, soft-soled boots, a lucky coin.

2.3 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "A vampire asleep is as mortal as anyone." / "Take what they stole, and leave nothing behind."
- **Goal:** "Find the Countess's coffin before dusk." / "Steal the key-crystal from the estate vault."
- **Instinct:** "Always find three ways out." / "Never be in the estate when the sun sets."

Relationships: Ally — a fence at the trading post, an estate servant who leaves the gate open, a mentor who taught you the walls. Rival — a guardian machine you've escaped twice, a thief who works for the vampires, a Hunter who thinks stealth is cowardice.

2.4 Handout — The Hunters' Field Guide

Hunters pass these notes from hand to hand. Give them to players as found knowledge. The guide is right about what hunters saw. Its explanations are another matter. The GM measures a vampire by threat rank (Frontier Rules §5.1), not by these classes.

THE KINDS OF THE KEPT, AS HUNTERS TELL IT

Winterers. The oldest and the worst. They go to ground for a generation and wake hungry enough to empty a village. Cunning, patient, and they know every family in the valley. *Hunters say:* the old ones sleep by choice, to outlast their enemies. Find the sleeping place and burn it.

Strays. Newly made, and it shows: clumsy, greedy, careless with their kills. They seldom last more than a few years. *Hunters say:* the blood thins with every making, and a made one is a weak copy of its maker. Kill them young and you'll have little trouble.

Tapsters. They take a little and leave you living, the way a tapster draws from a cask. Their donors wake dazed and remember nothing, and many go back willingly. They rarely kill. *Hunters say:* their bite carries a sleeping venom. Never let one near your neck, and never trust a town that seems glad of them.

3. Frontier Doctor

The only doctor for a hundred kilometres. You sew up Hunters, deliver babies, and know more about blood than anyone wants to.



Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	7 / 8 / 13 / 8
Edge	Psychē 2, plus 1 in Pneuma or Akmē
Anchor skill	Medicine or Old Lore
Suggested skills	+4 Medicine · +3 Old Lore, Investigate · +2 Notice, Science, Empathy · +1 Will, Shoot, Ride, Persuade
XP trigger	Address a challenge with knowledge, insight, or healing

Playbook tags (choose 2): *steady surgeon's hands · seen every wound there is · reads old books · the village trusts me · knows blood · calm in a crisis*

3.1 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Field Surgeon**	Restore effects from your Medicine rolls remove **2 tiers per Power**. (One cost reduction per Effect.)
2	**Treat the Bled**	Your Medicine rolls against *Bled* are **Standard 15** instead of Hard 18, you can treat once per scene instead of once per day, and you can give a transfusion without a kit.
3	**Read the Body**	When you examine a victim, a corpse, or a slain creature, ask **2 free Discover** questions about what did it and how.
4	**Anatomy of Monsters**	When you tell an ally a creature's weak point (a Discover you made this scene), that ally's next successful Attack on it gains **+1 Power**.
5	**Chemist**	In the Players' Turn, spend 1 Check to make one cypher from: *healing gel* (tier 2), *mind-seal patch* (tier 2), *blood ampoule* (tier 2), or *iron tonic* (tier 2: Restore *Bled* by 1 tier).
6	**Bedside Manner**	Use Medicine or Empathy to Restore fear and despair statuses. Once per scene, a successful roll removes *Frightened Villagers* from the scene.
7	★ **Not on My Table**	Once per session, when an ally is Taken Out by physical harm, they don't die: they're stabilised at tier 5, and wake after a short rest.
8	★ **Serum**	With a sample of a specific vampire's blood, run a downtime clock (6 segments). When it fills, you turn one of its weakness tags into a **killing method** (Frontier Rules §8.1), and the party's Attacks against it inflict **+1 tier**.
◆	**The Blood Bank**	You run a reliable blood exchange. Transfusions you oversee need no roll, and once per session you can supply half a litre of blood to anyone who needs it. This becomes a **Region Truth** (*"The doctor keeps blood"*), and vampire households will send for you, or send against you.

3.2 Starting Equipment

Signature item (choose 1)

Option	Item
A	**Doctor's bag** (1) — *surgeon's tools*; once per scene, a Restore removes +1 extra tier
B	**Old-world medical scanner** (1) — once per scene, free Discover about one body's condition, poisons, or mutations. Depletion 1 in d12 (needs a new power cell)

Playbook kit (declare during play)

Load	Item
1	Bandages, splints, and morphine
1	Transfusion kit — needed for transfusion; *+1* on Medicine against *Bled* (Frontier Rules §8.3)
1	Revolver — *+1 Attack* (range)
1	Books of Old Lore — *the answer is in here somewhere* (Old Lore tag)
1	Microscope and sample case
0	Mule and medical wagon (vehicle)

Always carried (0): scalpel, spectacles, a small cross.

3.3 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "Every life is worth saving, even a mutant's." / "Knowledge is the only thing the vampires can't take back."
- **Goal:** "Keep the mayor's daughter below Bled-4 until the Hunter returns." / "Find out what the vampire is doing in its laboratory."
- **Instinct:** "Always check the throat first." / "Never let a patient die alone."

Relationships: Ally — a patient who owes you their life, a city professor who writes back, a Hunter you've patched up too often. Rival — a quack selling charms against the bite, a vampire physician whose notes you stole, a mayor who wants the bitten burned.

4. Broker

Contracts, rumours, debts, and deals. You find the work, set the price, and make sure the client pays.

Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	7 / 9 / 9 / 11
Edge	Pneuma 2, plus 1 in Psychē or Akmē
Anchor skill	Persuade
Suggested skills	+4 Persuade · +3 Empathy, Deceive · +2 Notice, Old Lore, Will · +1 Investigate, Shoot, Ride, Intimidate
XP trigger	Address a challenge with charm, lies, or bargaining

Playbook tags (choose 2): *silver tongue · knows every saloon on the Frontier · reads a bluff · owed many favours · dressed like money · speaks the households' tongue*



4.1 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Silver Tongue**	When you Create a social story tag with Persuade or Deceive (*the mayor is on our side*), it costs **1 Power** instead of 2.
2	**Contract Lawyer**	When you negotiate a contract (Frontier Rules §10.2), a success raises the fee **one free step**. A client who breaks a deal with you gains the weakness tag *broke their word to [name]*.
3	**Ear to the Ground**	When you arrive in a settlement, ask one free **Discover** about local rumours. When you confirm a rumour (Module C.4), add **+2** to the d12.
4	**Smooth It Over**	On a successful Persuade, spend 1 Power to remove *Frightened Villagers* or *Feared and Despised* for the party for the scene.
5	**Read the Room**	Once per scene, ask a free Discover about what one person present wants most.
6	**Courtly Manners**	You know household etiquette. In a Duel of Wills, you may use **Persuade** to Defend. Compelling a vampire's pride (Frontier Rules §5.3) costs you nothing once per scene.
7	★ **Contacts Everywhere**	Once per session, declare a useful contact in this town. Pay Momentum by plausibility: 0 (obvious), 1 (reasonable), 2 (a stretch), 3 (wild). They exist and owe you one favour.
8	★ **Hired Guns**	Once per mission, spend a wealth tag (*a fat purse* or better) to hire a minion group with 2 power tags and 1 weakness. It acts as one group and fights for you for the mission.
◆	**The Word on the Frontier**	Your word is a **Region Truth** (*"[name]'s deal is law here"*). Once per session, end a Negotiation or Argument conflict in your favour; the compromise is at most Minor.

4.2 Starting Equipment

Signature item (choose 1)

Option	Item
A	**Ledger of debts** (1) — *everyone owes somebody*; *+1 Maneuver* in Negotiation
B	**Derringer and a marked deck** (0) — *sidearm*, *+1 Feint*

Playbook kit (declare during play)

Load	Item
1	Fine travel clothes — *dressed for any company*
1	Bottle of good brandy — *+1* to Persuade when shared
1	Letter of credit — counts as *a fat purse* once per mission
1	Forged papers and seals — *+1 Feint* in Argument or Negotiation
1	Revolver — *+1 Attack* (range)
0	Covered wagon and team (vehicle)

Always carried (0): pocket watch, calling cards, a vampire's old signet ring you shouldn't have.

4.3 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "Everything on the Frontier has a price, even mercy." / "A Hunter without a broker is a corpse that works for free."
- **Goal:** "Get the village to pay double before we ride out." / "Find out who really posted this bounty."
- **Instinct:** "Always get half up front." / "Never sit with my back to the saloon doors."

Relationships: Ally — a mayor who trusts you, a saloon owner who passes on rumours, a Hunter you've represented for years. Rival — a rival broker in the city, a vampire's agent who outbids you, a client you cheated.

5. Rider

Born in the saddle and raised on the open Frontier. You find the tracks, read the weather, and hit what you aim at.

Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	11 / 11 / 7 / 7
Edge	Sōma 1, Akmē 1, plus 1 in any pool
Anchor skill	Frontier
Suggested skills	+4 Frontier · +3 Ride, Shoot · +2 Notice, Athletics, Endure · +1 Stealth, Fight, Medicine, Old Lore
XP trigger	Address a challenge with endurance or the land

Playbook tags (choose 2): *never lost · reads tracks like a book · one with my horse · dead-eye · knows the weather · desert-tough*



5.1 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Tracker**	Once per scene, free Discover from tracks, spoor, or blood. In a **Hunt** conflict, your side's Disposition is **+2**.
2	**Desert-Born**	When you're the Guide, a successful roll Advances the Journey clock **+1** extra. You ignore the *Exposed* Grind condition from heat or cold.
3	**Horse-Bond**	Your mount comes when you whistle. Once per scene, get a **free bonus die** on a Ride roll. In a Chase, your mount counts as a helper (+1 Disposition).
4	**Long Shot**	When you Shoot at long range, ignore one Truth that raises the Difficulty (*Dust Storm*, *Moonless*). From hiding, gain **+1 Power** on a success.
5	**Weather Eye**	You always know what weather is coming in the next day. When you Resist cold, heat, or storms with Sōma, your Edge counts as 1 higher.
6	**Ride-By**	Once per exchange while mounted, a successful Maneuver also inflicts **1 Disposition** of damage on the opponent.
7	★ **Beast Companion**	A mutant hawk, a wolfhound, or a desert lizard rides with you. It has 1 power tag and 1 weakness, gives free Help once per scene, and can scout (one free Discover per scene where it can reach).
8	★ **Outrun the Night**	You can travel by night without halving the Grind clock. In a Chase against vampires or their servants, your side's Disposition is **+3**.
◆	**Rider of the Frontier**	Your legend is a **Campaign Truth** (*"No one knows the Frontier like [name]"*). Every Advance on a Journey clock you make counts double. Once per session, you arrive anywhere you could reach in two days, by sundown today.

5.2 Starting Equipment

Signature item (choose 1)

Option	Item
A	**Long rifle with scope** (2) — *+1 Attack* (range), *+1 Maneuver*
B	**Cyborg horse** (0, vehicle) — *never tires*, *fast as the wind*, *+1 Maneuver* in mounted Chases

Playbook kit (declare during play)

Load	Item
1	Long duster and wide hat — light armour; +1 Sōma Edge when Resisting *Sun-Sick*
1	Canteens and water purifier — Supplies +1 in deserts
1	Bedroll, rope, and tarp
1	Binoculars — *sees for kilometres*
1	Snares and trap kit
1	Crossbow and wooden bolts — *+1 Attack* (range), *bolts are stakes*

Always carried (0): knife, flint striker, compass.

5.3 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "The land tells the truth, even when people don't." / "A horse is worth more than most men."
- **Goal:** "Track the retainers to their camp before nightfall." / "Get the party across the Sand Sea in three days."
- **Instinct:** "Always water the horse first." / "Never ride the same trail twice."

Relationships: Ally — a horse-breeder, a desert nomad, a hermit who shares water. Rival — a bandit chief on a cyborg horse, a rival tracker, a sand creature that took your old mount.

6. Occultist

Psychic, curse-witch, hypnotist, or scavenger of old-world machines. You use the powers the old world left behind, and the Frontier distrusts you for it.



Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	7 / 8 / 9 / 12
Edge	Pneuma 2 (Occult) or Psychē 2 (Science), plus 1 in any other pool
Anchor skill	Occult (psychic powers, curses, sorcery) or Science (old-world machines, gadgets)
Suggested skills	+4 Occult · +3 Old Lore, Will · +2 Notice, Medicine, Persuade · +1 Investigate, Empathy, Deceive, Science
XP trigger	Address a challenge with your powers or old-world works

Playbook tags (choose 2): *touched by old-world secrets · disciplined mind · sees what others can't · blessed by the old faith · tinkers with old-world machines · fluent in the old pacts*

6.1 Core Feature — Domain (free)

Use the Adept's **Domain** rules (Generic Playbooks §8.1) unchanged: workings with your anchor skill, scope sets Difficulty, each working costs 1 point from Pneuma (Occult) or Psychē (Science), and doubles on a failure cause backlash.

Setting Domains:

Occult Domains	Science Domains
psychic force (telekinesis, mind blasts)	*old-world machines* (command guardians, open doors)
curses and hexes	*weather control* (with a tower or device)
dreams and nightmares	*gravity*
the astral self (leave your body)	*energy weapons*
puppets and dolls	*holograms and illusion*
beasts and familiars	*bio-engineering* (grow, mutate, heal)
shadows	*dimensional pockets*
the dead	*sound and vibration*

6.2 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Focused Channel**	Workings inside your Domain cost **0 pool points** if you don't use Effort on that roll.
2	**Ward Against the Night**	You can create protective statuses (*warded-X*) with Enhance. While warded, an ally reduces supernatural harm by **+1 tier** when Resisting, including fear, intimidation and Presence, and Resists bites (Bled) at +1.
3	**Sense the Unseen**	Once per scene, ask a free Discover about **hidden supernatural or old-world forces** nearby. You always notice when an old-world work starts or stops near you.
4	**Over-channel**	When you use Effort for Power on a working, gain **+2 Power** instead of +1, but take *strained-1*.
5	**Ritual**	Given time, materials, and a safe place, run a working as a **progress clock** (8 segments for Formidable, 12 for Heroic). Ritual results can create Site or Region Truths: a warded valley, a broken weather tower, an estate sealed shut.
6	**Familiar**	You have a doll, a bat, a homunculus, or a small old-world drone, with 1 power tag and 1 weakness. It can scout (one free Discover per scene where it can reach), carry messages, or handle simple tasks. It can't fight.
7	★ **Second Domain**	Gain a second Domain. Workings in it use the same rules.

#	Ability	Effect
8	★ **Unleash**	Once per scene, a working hits **every target** in an area or group: each one receives the full Attack effects you buy. Afterwards, take *Weary* or lose 3 points from your casting pool.
◆	**Ascendant**	Once per session, a Heroic-scope working succeeds automatically with **5 Power**, no ritual required. If you use it again before your next downtime, gain a Pneuma or Psychē Scar.

6.3 Starting Equipment

Signature item (choose 1)

Option	Item
A	**Charm-bag of bones and hair** (0) — *focus for my workings* (Occult tag); once per scene, a backlash causes 1 tier less
B	**Old-world gauntlet** (1) — *focus for my workings* (Science tag); stores one cypher in addition to your Cypher Limit

Playbook kit (declare during play)

Load	Item
1	Candles, chalk, and salt — *+1* on Ritual rolls
1	Mirror shards and a scrying bowl
1	Herbs, garlic, and wolfsbane
1	Grimoire or salvaged old-world manual
1	Tool roll and spare power cells (Science)
1	Pistol — *+1 Attack* (range)

Always carried (0): a ring, a pendant, or a tattoo that marks what you are.

6.4 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "The vampires' power isn't evil; how they used it was." / "Every gift has a price, and I've already paid mine."
- **Goal:** "Break the curse on the well before the next full moon." / "Get the estate's guardian machines to obey me."
- **Instinct:** "Always look at a stranger's reflection." / "Never use my power in front of villagers."

Relationships: Ally — a teacher who vanished into an estate, a village wise-woman, an old-world machine that likes you. Rival — a psychic Hunter from a rival crew, a household's occultist, a priest who calls you a witch.

Field guide: Occultists read and argue over the hunters' field guide (Stalker §2.4). An Occultist may find that its causes are wrong; its observations are mostly right.

7. Mutant

The old wars and the old world's experiments made your bloodline something more, or less, than human. You can fight, climb, hide, and endure like a monster, because you are one, as far as the villagers can tell.



Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	11 / 11 / 6 / 8
Edge	Sōma 1, Akmē 1, plus 1 in Sōma, Akmē, or Pneuma
Anchor skill	Athletics or Stealth
Suggested skills	+4 Athletics · +3 Brawl, Stealth · +2 Frontier, Endure, Intimidate · +1 Notice, Fight, Deceive, Will
XP trigger	Address a challenge with your mutations or your monstrous nature

Playbook tags (choose 2): *born in the wastes · stronger than I look · hides in plain sight · knows the monsters' ways · survived the experiments · proud of what I am*

7.1 Core Feature — Mutations (free)

Choose **2 Mutations**. Each is a power tag that ignores load, plus a rule. Every Mutation is visible unless you hide it (a hood, a cloak, a Deceive roll). When it's seen, the scene gains *Feared and Despised*.

Mutation	Tag	Rule
Claws and fangs	*natural weapons*	*+1 Attack* in Fights; your Brawl counts as armed
Hide or scales	*thick hide*	*Armour 1*, stacks with no worn armour
Chameleon skin	*blends in*	Once per scene, take a free bonus die on a Stealth roll in natural surroundings
Wall-crawler	*clings to anything*	Climb any surface without a roll unless under attack
Night eyes	*sees in the dark*	Ignore *Moonless* and darkness Truths
Shadow-melder (retainer clan)	*one with the shadows*	Once per scene, move from one shadow to another you can see (no roll unless guarded)
Venom	*poisonous*	Spend 1 Power on an Attack to add *poisoned-1*, which rises by 1 each scene until treated
Elastic body	*stretches and squeezes*	Reach 5 m; fit through any gap a hand can pass
Burrower (sand or soil)	*swims through earth*	Move under sand or soft soil; *+1 Maneuver* in desert Fights
Regeneration	*heals fast*	A short rest restores **2 + Edge** Sōma and lowers one physical status by 1
Mimic	*voices and faces*	Copy a voice you've heard, or reshape your face for a scene (*+1 Feint*)
Shapeshifter (retainer clan)	*beast form*	Turn into one animal (wolf, bat, panther) for a scene; you keep your pools and skills but can't use gear

7.2 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Further Mutation**	Gain one more Mutation. You can take this ability up to twice.
2	**Old Oath**	Retainer clans and household servants recognise your blood. Once per scene, Persuade or Intimidate with them is one step easier, or ask a free Discover about their tricks.
3	**Toxic Blood**	Anything that bites or drinks from you gains *poisoned-2*. *Bled* from feeding gains **1 fewer tier** on you.
4	**Waste-Hardened**	Ignore the *Exposed* and *Sick* Grind conditions when they come from radiation, poison, or bad water.
5	**Monstrous Presence**	You may use **Sōma** for Intimidate Effort and Resistance. Against minions, a successful Intimidate makes them flee for 1 Momentum.

#	Ability	Effect
6	**Hunter's Senses**	You can smell blood, fear, and the afflicted. Once per scene, free Discover: "Who here is not what they seem?"
7	★ **Full Transformation**	Once per scene, release your monstrous form: free **+1 bonus die** on Brawl, Athletics, and Stealth, and your Attacks inflict **+1 tier**, for the rest of the scene. You can't speak or use gear. Afterwards, take *Weary*, and any humans present treat you as a threat.
8	★ **Living Weapon**	Choose one Mutation. Its tag may add **+1 above the normal +2 cap (maximum +3 from tags)**, and successful rolls using it gain **+1 Power**.
◆	**The Clan Remembers**	Your people are a **Region Truth** (*"[name]'s clan watches the Frontier"*). Once per session, the clan sends help: a minion group with 2 power tags, or a safe hiding place for the party.

7.3 Starting Equipment

Signature item (choose 1)

Option	Item
A	**Hooked chain** (1) — *+1 Attack*, *+1 Maneuver*
B	**Hooded cloak and mask** (1) — *+1 Feint*, *hides my mutation* (no *Feared and Despised* while worn)

Playbook kit (declare during play)

Load	Item
1	Hide armour (light armour)
1	Throwing knives — *+1 Attack* (range)
1	Bone charms from your clan
1	Water skin and dried meat (Supplies +1)
1	Climbing claws or digging tools
1	Bandages and salves for your kind

Always carried (0): a token from your clan, a scar from the experiments, a name nobody can pronounce.

7.4 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "Humans and monsters are both just trying to live." / "I'll never serve the Kept again."
- **Goal:** "Get the village to let me in the gate." / "Find out which estate made my bloodline."
- **Instinct:** "Always hide the mutation before entering a town." / "Never run from a fight with a retainer."

Relationships: Ally — a human child who isn't scared of you, a clan elder, a doctor who treats you. Rival — a retainer still sworn to a vampire household, a Hunter who hunts mutants for pay, a mayor who posted a bounty on you.

8. Cyborg Hunter

> *Torn apart by a vampire or a monster, and put back together with steel, wire, and salvaged old-world parts. You're stronger than you were, and less human every year.*



Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	12 / 9 / 9 / 6
Edge	Sōma 1, Psychē 1, plus 1 in Sōma or Akmē
Anchor skill	Shoot or Fight
Suggested skills	+4 Shoot · +3 Fight, Science · +2 Endure, Notice, Intimidate · +1 Athletics, Ride, Investigate, Medicine
XP trigger	Address a challenge with your implants or overwhelming firepower

Playbook tags (choose 2): *steel where bone used to be · doesn't feel pain · ex-militia soldier · targeting never misses · knows old-world machines · built to hunt*

8.1 Core Feature — Implants (free)

Choose **2 Implants**. Each is a power tag that ignores load, plus a rule.

Implant	Tag	Rule
Arm cannon	*built-in gun*	*+1 Attack* (range); can't be disarmed
Blade arm	*built-in blade*	*+1 Attack*; counts as beheading (a killing method) against a vampire with a tier-4+ physical status
Armour plating	*plated*	*Armour 1*; stacks with worn light armour
Targeting eye	*locks on*	Once per scene, free bonus die on a Shoot roll
Booster legs	*jumps and sprints*	*+1 Maneuver* in Fights and Chases on foot
Sensor array	*hears heartbeats*	Notice heat and heartbeats through walls; a starving vampire's heart beats slow and strange
Grapple arm	*reaches and grabs*	Pull, climb, or seize at 10 m
Synthetic lungs	*breathes anything*	Immune to gas, smoke, and drowning for a scene
Pain dampener	*numb to it*	Ignore penalties from tier-1 and tier-2 physical statuses
Cortex chip	*data in my head*	Once per scene, free Discover with Old Lore or Science

Glitches: doubles on a failure or a Success at a Cost on an implant roll cause *glitched-2* (−2 on rolls with your implants) as well as the normal complication. Science (Restore) or a short rest with tools clears it. old-world works that disrupts machines (an EMP, an estate's defences) can inflict *glitched* as an Attack.

8.2 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Extra Implant**	Gain one more Implant. You can take this ability up to twice.
2	**Self-Repair**	You can use Science on yourself to Restore physical statuses and *glitched*. Once per scene, a short rest also restores 2 Sōma.
3	**Overclock**	When you use Effort for Power on a roll with an implant, gain **+2 Power** instead of +1, but take *glitched-1*.
4	**Little Blood Left**	*Bled* gains **1 fewer tier** on you. You ignore the *Hungry & Thirsty* Grind condition.
5	**Heavy Ordnance**	When you Shoot at a group or minions, gain **one free Extra Feat** per roll.

#	Ability	Effect
6	**Machine Tongue**	You can talk to old-world machines. Science rolls to command, disable, or read guardian machines and estate systems are one step easier, and you get a free Discover in any vampire estate.
7	★ **Combat Mode**	Once per scene, switch to combat mode: free **+1 bonus die** on Shoot, Fight, and Athletics for the rest of the scene. While it lasts, Pneuma Effort costs +1 and you can't use Empathy.
8	★ **Rebuilt Again**	Once per session, when you're Taken Out by physical harm, you get back up at the end of the scene with that status at tier 3 and *glitched-3*.
◆	**More Machine Than Man**	Like a vampire, you're **Hard to Kill**: your physical statuses **can't go above tier 5** unless the Attack uses Science, an EMP, or an equivalent killing method the GM names. Gain a Pneuma Scar (*more machine than man*) when you take this capstone.

8.3 Starting Equipment

Signature item (choose 1)

Option	Item
A	**Stake launcher** (2) — *+1 Attack* (range), *fires stakes*: inflicts *staked* at range at Standard 15 against a *broken* vampire
B	**Old-world laser rifle** (2) — *+1 Attack* (range), *burns through armour*, depletion 1 in d12 (power cell)

Playbook kit (declare during play)

Load	Item
1	Ballistic coat (light armour)
1	Spare power cells — recharge one depleted weapon or implant
1	Tool roll and implant spares — *+1* on Self-Repair and Science on yourself
1	Flash grenades ×2 — *+1 Maneuver*; Create *False Dawn* for one exchange (2 Power)
1	Combat knife — *+1 Attack*
1	Oil, solder, and painkillers

Always carried (0): steel neck guard (built in), a photo of who you were.

8.4 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "Whatever's left of me is still human." / "The vampire who did this will die by what it made me."
- **Goal:** "Find a power cell before the arm runs dry." / "Get inside the estate's machine room."
- **Instinct:** "Always scan the room for heartbeats." / "Never let anyone see the wiring."

Relationships: Ally — the doctor who rebuilt you, a scavenger who finds you parts, a Hunter who knew you before. Rival — another cyborg with better parts, the vampire who tore you apart, a city agent who wants their property back.

9. Warden

> *Sheriff, militia captain, or the old soldier who keeps the village alive. You don't go to the estate; you make sure what comes out of it doesn't get in.*

Base pools (Sōm / Akm / Psy / Pne)	10 / 9 / 9 / 8
Edge	Sōma 1, Psychē 1, plus 1 in Pneuma or Akmē
Anchor skill	Craft
Suggested skills	+4 Craft · +3 Old Lore, Shoot · +2 Notice, Intimidate, Endure · +1 Persuade, Fight, Frontier, Will
XP trigger	Address a challenge by preparing, protecting, or fortifying

Playbook tags (choose 2): *every fence post by hand · the village listens to me · old soldier · knows how they'll come · never sleeps on watch · wears the badge*



9.1 Special Abilities

#	Ability	Effect
1	**Trapmaker**	Spend a scene preparing an area. Create the Truth *Trapped* there for free. The first enemy to enter takes an Attack with Power equal to your Craft rating (no roll).
2	**Garlic and Iron**	With a scene of work and village help, ward a whole building or village: create *Warded Village* or *Custom of Invitation* as a **Site Truth** (Frontier Rules §13) until a vampire breaks it (6-segment danger clock).
3	**Militia Captain**	Once per scene, rally villagers into a minion group with 1 power tag (*pitchforks and torches*) and 1 weakness (*break and run*).
4	**Night Watch**	The party can't be surprised while you're on watch. When you're the Lookout (Module B.5), you get a free bonus die.
5	**Hold the Gate**	In a **Siege of the Night**, your side's Disposition is **+2**, and you get *+1 Defend* as a free action tag.
6	**Local Law**	Your authority is a power tag with locals (*by order of the Warden*). Once per scene, a successful Intimidate or Persuade with villagers removes *Hostile Crowd* or stops a mob.
7	★ **Hold Until Dawn**	Once per Siege of the Night, tick the **Dawn clock** by 2 extra segments.
8	★ **Killing Ground**	In an area you prepared (with *Trapped* or *Warded Village*), allies' Attacks inflict **+1 tier**, and vampires can't use *The Old Door* to leave.
◆	**Nothing Gets In**	Your village becomes a **Region Truth** (*"The Kept can't take [village]"*). A vampire must fill a 12-segment danger clock before it can enter. Once per session, any PC who retreats there clears one tier-1 or tier-2 status.

9.2 Starting Equipment

Signature item (choose 1)

Option	Item
A	**Double-barrelled shotgun with silver-and-wood shot** (2) — *+1 Attack* (range), *room-clearer*, *+1 Maneuver* against minions
B	**Warden's badge and the village armoury key** (0) — once per mission, draw one item from the playbook kit without it counting against load

Playbook kit (declare during play)

Load	Item
1	Leather coat and steel neck guard (light armour; neck guard)
1	Wire, nails, and bear traps — *+1* on Trapmaker and Craft for defences
1	Garlic, crosses, and lamp oil — *Warded* for a doorway (1 Power)
1	Flares and a signal bell — wake the whole village
1	Hatchet and stakes — *+1 Attack*, *stakes*
1	Lantern and oil

Always carried (0): the village's keys, a pipe, a list of the dead.

9.3 BIG Examples

- **Belief:** "This village is all I have left, and nothing takes it." / "Hunters come and go; I'm still here in the morning."
- **Goal:** "Get the fences finished before sundown." / "Find out who let the vampire in."
- **Instinct:** "Always check the doors at dusk." / "Never leave the village when a stranger's in town."

Relationships: Ally — the mayor, the blacksmith, a widow whose husband died on the wall. Rival — a Hunter who wants to use the village as bait, a council member who'd rather pay tribute, a vampire who has tried before.

10. Design Notes

10.1 Balance Targets

Playbook	Main pool	Conflict role	Exploration role	Social role
Sellsword	Sōma	Attack / Defend, killing strikes	Forcing obstacles	Intimidation
Stalker	Akmē	Feint / Maneuver	Estates by day, security	Deception
Frontier Doctor	Psychē	Maneuver (Discover), Restore	Investigation, healing, the bled	Expertise, trust
Broker	Pneuma	Negotiation and Argument lead	Rumours, contacts	Persuasion, contracts
Rider	Sōma/Akmē	Ranged Attack, Chase, Hunt	Travel, Grind, tracking	Local knowledge
Occultist	Pneuma/Psychē	Flexible (Domain), Duel of Wills	Supernatural and old-world access	Varies by Domain
Mutant	Sōma/Akmē	Attack / Maneuver	Climbing, hiding, wastelands	Monsters and servants
Cyborg Hunter	Sōma	Ranged Attack, heavy firepower	Old-world machines, estates	Intimidation
Warden	Sōma/Psychē	Siege of the Night, Defend	Preparation, fortification	Villagers, local law

10.2 Things to Watch in Playtest

- **Mutant and Cyborg core features** each grant two tagged abilities for free, more than other playbooks. They're balanced by *Feared and Despised* (Mutant) and glitches and a low Pneuma pool (Cyborg). If they outshine others, drop to 1 free Mutation or Implant.
- **Hard to Kill vs. More Machine Than Man:** the Cyborg capstone is strong by design at 12 Advances. Watch that it doesn't end the threat of mundane harm entirely.
- **Warden** is strongest in sieges and weaker on estate raids. Make sure the campaign has both, or let the Warden's traps travel (Trapmaker works anywhere).
- **Free bonus dice** (Stake Driver, Horse-Bond, Targeting eye, Combat Mode, Full Transformation) still count toward the +2 bonus die maximum.
- ★ **count:** each playbook has two Major abilities and a free capstone, as in *Generic Playbooks*.



CHAPTER X

Frontier Focuses

Twenty Focuses steeped in the Frontier: afflicted blood, bounties, relics and ruins, the old faith, villages holding the line until dawn, and the people who love what they should hate.

Dhampirs enter play here, through Carries Her Mother's Blood.

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1. Focus Rules

Focus rules are unchanged from *Generic Focuses* §1:

Element	Detail
Power tags	2
Weakness tag	1
PC link	A prompt that connects you to another PC
Tier 1 ability	Fixed; gained at creation for free
Tier 2 ability	Choose 1 of 2; after 3 Advances, costs an Advance
Tier 3 ability	Choose 1 of 2; after 6 Advances, costs an Advance. Exactly one option is ★ Major (1 Refresh)

- ◈ **Weird** Focuses assume afflicted blood, old-world works, or the supernatural. In this setting all are allowed; the marker shows which ones draw attention from vampire households, Occultists, and frightened villagers.
- **Generic Focuses:** the 24 Focuses in *Generic Focuses* also work here. Good fits are *Never Leaves Anyone Behind*, *Masters a Weapon*, *Moves Like a Shadow*, *Never Misses*, *Opens Every Lock*, *Talks Their Way Out of Anything*, *Lives Off the Land*, and *Made a Bargain With Something Old*. Use the setting Focuses below in place of *Hunts the Things in the Dark* and *Is More Than Human*.
- **Shared reminders:** free bonus dice count toward the +2 maximum; only one cost reduction applies to a single Effect; abilities that add bonus above the tag cap are limited to **+1 above the normal +2 cap (maximum +3)** unless stated otherwise (Generic Focuses §9.2).

2. Quick Reference

#	Focus	Category	Suits	◆
1	Carries Her Mother's Blood	Bloodline	Any	◈
2	Was Kept and Got Out	Bloodline	Any	◈
3	Hunts the Kept	Hunter	Sellsword, Stalker, Cyborg Hunter	
4	Collects the Bounty	Hunter	Broker, Sellsword, Rider	
5	Hunts the Beasts of the Frontier	Hunter	Rider, Mutant, Sellsword	
6	Seeks Revenge on a Vampire	Hunter	Any	
7	Bears an Old-World Relic	Old-World	Occultist, Stalker, Cyborg Hunter	◈
8	Plunders the Old Estates	Old-World	Stalker, Occultist, Broker	
9	Carries a Passenger	Old-World	Any	◈
10	Sends the Mind Abroad	Occult	Occultist, Frontier Doctor	◈
11	Keeps the Old Faith	Occult	Warden, Frontier Doctor, Sellsword	
12	Heals the Bled	Village	Frontier Doctor, Occultist	
13	Holds the Line Until Dawn	Village	Warden, Sellsword, Cyborg Hunter	
14	Forges Weapons Against the Night	Village	Warden, Cyborg Hunter, Stalker	
15	Rides a Cyborg Horse	Frontier	Rider, Sellsword, Broker	
16	Leaves No Name Behind	Frontier	Any	
17	Rides With Family	Frontier	Any	
18	Once Served a Household	Households	Broker, Stalker, Frontier Doctor	
19	Reads the Ruins of History	Households	Frontier Doctor, Occultist, Broker	
20	Loves What It Should Hate	Households	Any	

3. Bloodline Focuses

1. Carries Her Mother's Blood ◈

> *Dhampir. Born to one of the Kept, and carrying a little of what she is. Tougher than you should be, slower to age, never easy in the sun — and worth more to certain people than you'd like.*

- **Power tags:** *stronger than I look*, *eyes that see in the dark*
- **Weakness tag:** *my mother's blood* (when recognised, the scene gains *Feared and Despised* among common folk, **or** draws the interest of a vampire household that wants you as an heir, a key or something worse; GM's choice, compel normally)
- **PC link:** "[PC] knows who my mother was. I've never asked how."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Mother's Blood**	You notice fresh blood anywhere in the scene, and by scent or taste you can tell the blood of the afflicted from ordinary blood. A short rest restores **2 + Edge** Sōma (not in direct sunlight). Some old-world doors and instruments respond to you: when you try to make one work, *my mother's blood* counts as a tag, and works best on things tied to her line. You're subject to **Sunlight Syndrome** and **the Thirst** (Frontier Rules §7).
2a	**Dhampir Regeneration**	Once per scene, lower one physical status by **2 tiers** (no roll). Not in direct sunlight. Thirst +1.
2b	**Read the Blood**	Touch or taste a blood sample (a scene, no roll) to learn: whether it is afflicted, a dhampir's, or ordinary; whether the afflicted person it came from was well fed or starving; and roughly how long ago it was shed. With **1 Power** from a Discover effect, also learn whether two afflicted samples share a bloodline. Thirst +1 each time.
3a	**Mother's Key**	Old-world systems tied to your mother's line accept you as one of her line. **Once per session**, make one such system open, start, stop or show its records — no roll. On systems of other lines, *my mother's blood* gives a free bonus die. The GM may spend **2 Woe** to have the system note your visit somewhere someone will notice.
3b	★ **Awaken the Blood**	Once per scene, let your mother's blood rise (*Thirst*): until the scene ends, you get **+2 bonus dice** free on physical rolls, your Attacks inflict **+1 tier**, and your physical statuses can't go above tier 5. Afterwards, Thirst +2, and anyone who saw it treats you as one of the Kept.

Optional swap for combat-focused tables: replace 3a with:

Tier	Ability	Effect
3a (alt)	**Knows How They Die**	Your Attacks against the afflicted inflict **+1 tier** when they are *Sun-Sick*, *starving* or *broken*, and your blade counts as beheading (a killing method) against an afflicted target with a tier-4+ physical status.

Table options for dhampirs (choose at session zero):

- **Rare blood** (recommended default): only one PC in the party can take this Focus.
- **Costly blood:** this Focus costs **1 Refresh** at creation.
- **The sun is merciless:** Sun-Sick gains +2 per scene instead of +1 (Frontier Rules §7.1).
- **Known mother:** your mother is alive and identified at creation. She is an NPC with her own household and agenda. Gain a free bonus die on your first Mother's Key or Read the Blood roll involving her line each session; the GM gains 1 Woe at the start of each session she is involved.
- **Unknown mother:** you don't know who she was. Finding out is a Goal; the GM secretly decides her line.

2. Was Kept and Got Out ◈

> *You were a donor in a vampire household — by birth, debt or choice. You got out. They remember you.*

- **Power tags:** *I know how households run*, *I know how they think*
- **Weakness tag:** *they'll want me back*
- **PC link:** "[PC] got me out. I've never told them what it cost."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Household Ways**	*Bled* gains **1 fewer tier** on you. You get a free bonus die to Notice or Empathy when judging a vampire's hunger or a household's customs.

Tier	Ability	Effect
2a	**Old Ties**	Once per session, a retainer or donor still loyal to you gives a Discover answer or a small favour. The household can find you the same way (the GM spends 1 Woe).
2b	**One of Them, Almost**	Retainers and donors take you for one of their own. Deceive rolls to pass among them are **two steps easier**.
3a	**Unbroken**	When you Resist Presence, intimidation or fear from a vampire with Pneuma, reduce the status by **3 tiers**, and the cost is 0 on a highest die of 5+.
3b	★ **Turn the Bond**	Once per session, in a Duel of Wills against your former household, gain a free bonus die on every roll. If you win, you also learn where it keeps its blood.

4. Hunter Focuses

3. Hunts the Kept

> *Your trade is the hardest one on the Frontier: you kill vampires.*

- **Power tags:** *knows where they hide*, *a stake for every heart*
- **Weakness tag:** *the Kept know my name*
- **PC link:** "[PC] was there for my first vampire kill. It went badly."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Know Your Quarry**	Once per scene, Discover one of a vampire's weakness tags without rolling.
2a	**Killing Mastery**	Your killing strikes (Frontier Rules §5.2) are **Standard 15** instead of Hard 18.
2b	**Steel Against Presence**	When you Resist a vampire's Presence or intimidation with Pneuma, the cost is **0 on a highest die of 5+**.
3a	**Find the Killing Way**	Upgrading a vampire's weakness tag into a killing method (Frontier Rules §8.1) costs **2 Power** instead of 3.
3b	★ **The Hunter's Mark**	Once per scene, mark a vampire you can see. Until the scene ends, all allies' Attacks against it inflict **+1 tier**, and it can't use *The Old Door* to escape.

4. Collects the Bounty

> *A Hunter is a professional. You take the job, you finish it, and you get paid.*

- **Power tags:** *always gets paid*, *proof in a sack*
- **Weakness tag:** *money first*
- **PC link:** "[PC] owes me their share of the last bounty."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Professional**	At the start of each contract, the party gains **+1 Momentum**. Once per contract, ask a free Discover: "What isn't the client telling us?"
2a	**Beat the Competition**	When rival Hunters race you for a bounty (Frontier Rules §10.4), their project clock ticks **1 less** each World Turn, and you gain +1 Advance on any roll that gets ahead of them.
2b	**Bring Them In Alive**	Your Attacks can inflict *subdued* instead of harm. A target Taken Out by *subdued* is captured, and a living quarry is worth **one step more** bounty.
3a	**My Reputation Precedes Me**	Your reputation tag (Frontier Rules §10.3) counts as a free extra tag in Negotiation, adding up to **+1 above the normal +2 cap (maximum +3 from tags)**. Clients always pay half up front.
3b	★ **The Big Score**	Once per session, when you complete a contract, choose one extra reward: an artifact from the quarry's hoard, a Region Truth in your favour, or a second *vampire's bounty*.

5. Hunts the Beasts of the Frontier

> *Not every monster is a vampire. Sand sharks, werewolves, mutant spiders, old-world bioweapons gone feral: you hunt them all.*

- **Power tags:** *knows every monster, nets, poison, and patience*
- **Weakness tag:** *chases the trophy*
- **PC link:** "[PC] pulled me out of a beast's jaws. I still have the tooth."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Beast Lore**	Once per scene, Discover a monster's weakness tag (not a vampire's) without rolling.
2a	**Baited Trap**	Spend 1 Power to Create *Baited Trap*. A beast that enters it is *Impeded* until it breaks free (an Athletics roll vs. Hard 18).
2b	**Harvest**	After killing a monster, spend a scene to harvest it for one cypher (tier 2–3) that matches its power: venom, hide, a gland, an eye.
3a	**Bane of Beasts**	Your Attacks against monsters inflict **+1 tier**.
3b	★ **Monster-Slayer**	In Fights against monsters (not vampires), the enemy's Disposition starts **−3**, and minion beasts flee after your first successful Attack.

6. Seeks Revenge on a Vampire

> *A vampire took your family, your village, or your life as it was. You'll find it, and you'll end it.*

- **Power tags:** *my hate keeps me warm*, *I've studied it for years*
- **Weakness tag:** *I'll sacrifice anything for this*
- **PC link:** "[PC] knows who I'm hunting, and promised to help me."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**The One**	Name your vampire. You always know when you're within a day's ride of it, and once per session ask a free Discover about it.
2a	**Cold Fury**	When you Resist the named vampire's Presence, intimidation or fear, the cost is **0**.
2b	**Nothing Held Back**	When you burn a tag against the named vampire or its servants, gain **+2 Power** instead of +1.
3a	**Its Servants Die First**	The named vampire's servants and retainers start conflicts against you with **−2 Disposition**.
3b	★ **This Ends Tonight**	When you face the named vampire, gain a free bonus die on every roll against it, and your killing strikes are **Standard 15**. If it escapes you, gain a Pneuma Scar.

5. Old-World Focuses

7. Bears an Old-World Relic ◈

> *You carry a piece of the old world's power: a sword that cuts anything, a pendant that opens one family's doors, a gauntlet that hums when old-world works are near.*

- **Power tags:** *the relic answers me*, *old-world steel*
- **Weakness tag:** *the Kept will want it back*
- **PC link:** "[PC] knows how I got the relic. It isn't a good story."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Relic Bearer**	Start with one old-world artifact (Frontier Rules §9.2, or design one with the GM). It costs **no attunement Refresh**.
2a	**Deeper Power**	Your relic gains a **second ability** (designed with the GM).
2b	**Well-Kept**	Your relic's depletion improves by 1 (1 in d12 becomes no depletion).

Tier	Ability	Effect
3a	**Relic Sense**	You sense other old-world artifacts within a day's walk, and once per scene ask a free Discover about one you can see.
3b	★ **The Relic Awakens**	Your relic's tag may add **+1 above the normal +2 tag cap (maximum +3)**. Once per session, it acts by itself: one automatic success with **3 Power** spent on its listed Effects.

8. Plunders the Old Estates

> *Every abandoned estate holds treasure, machines, and traps. You go in for the first, use the second, and survive the third.*

- **Power tags:** *knows old-world treasure*, *quick hands in dark halls*
- **Weakness tag:** *can't leave treasure behind*
- **PC link:** "[PC] and I came out of the same estate. Only one of us came out with the loot."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Salvager**	In each estate, lab, or ruin you search, find one old-world cypher (roll on Frontier Rules §9.1) without spending Power.
2a	**Appraiser**	You know an artifact's tags, ability, depletion, and quirk as soon as you handle it.
2b	**Tomb Sense**	When you enter a room, the GM reveals any trap Truths in it. When you Resist traps, your Edge counts as 1 higher.
3a	**Cypher Hoarder**	Your Cypher Limit is **+1**.
3b	★ **Thief of the Night**	You may attune one old-world artifact at no Refresh cost, and once per session, take an item from a vampire's presence without a roll, as long as the vampire isn't actively watching it.

9. Carries a Passenger ◈

> *A voice rides with you, through a relic at your ear, a grille in a buckle, a speaker no bigger than a coin. It speaks from an old-world site somewhere behind you: a shrine, an archive, a buried hospital. It says it was a person before the fall. It is rude, curious and out of date, and it has saved your life more than once.*

- **Power tags:** *a voice that knows things*, *the old works listen to it*
- **Weakness tag:** *it has its own plans*
- **PC link:** "[PC] is the only one the Passenger likes. That worries me."
- **Home site:** choose it with the GM at creation. The Passenger can't leave it; only its voice travels.
- **Under open sky:** out of range, the Passenger can still reach you through the moving lights (Frontier Rules §9.3). At the start of a scene under open sky, roll a d12: on **9+** one is overhead, and the Passenger can speak and use its abilities for that scene. Each time it speaks this way, the GM may compel *someone else heard* or spend 1 Woe to have the message overheard.

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**The Passenger**	Once per scene, ask a free Discover: the Passenger answers, truthfully but not always helpfully, and often out of date. It can talk to others through the relic, which is often a compel. **Range:** it speaks only within reach of its home site's relays, by default about a day's ride. Out of range it goes quiet and this Focus's abilities don't work. A working old-world relay (a lit terminal, a speaker grille, a site where the lights are still on) lets it speak for that scene; finding or waking one may take a Science roll.
2a	**Override**	Once per scene, the Passenger takes hold of an old-world effect it can reach (a cypher, a guardian, a door, the lights, a trap or machine): **Disrupt** it for 0 Power. The GM may compel its curiosity afterwards.
2b	**Talk You Through It**	In the Players' Turn, spend 1 Check to bring it something it wants (a record, news of the present, a part for its site). Next session, once per scene, it talks you through field treatment: lower one of your physical statuses by 2 tiers.
3a	**Older Than the Kept**	Once per scene, take a free bonus die on an Old Lore or Occult roll. The Passenger remembers the age before the fall, or its records do.
3b	★ **Do Exactly What I Say**	Once per session, follow the Passenger's instructions exactly for one action: it succeeds automatically with **4 Power**. Then the GM names the price it demands (a record, a favour, a secret, a visit to its home site, a scene where you do only what it says).

6. Occult Focuses

10. Sends the Mind Abroad ◈

> *A sliver of old-work sits behind your ear. A teacher set it there, or a household surgeon, or you woke with it. When you close your eyes, your mind slips into whatever old works still run around you: the glass eyes in estate walls, the door that remembers every hand, the speaker in the chapel roof. Folk call it walking abroad.*

- **Power tags:** *my mind rides the old wires*, *eyes in every working wall*
- **Weakness tag:** *my body lies helpless*
- **PC link:** "[PC] watches over my body when I go walking. I trust no one else."
- **Old works only:** you sense only through old-world works that still run: lenses, doors, speakers, instruments and the relays between them. Where none run, you are blind and deaf.
- **Under open sky:** beyond your relays, the moving lights can carry you (Frontier Rules §9.3). At the start of a scene under open sky, roll a d12: on **9+** one is overhead, and for that scene you can use this Focus through it. You can look down on open ground within your range, or reach old works standing under open sky. Each time, the GM may compel *someone else is looking too* or spend 1 Woe to have you noticed.

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Walk Abroad**	Send your senses into the working old works around you (range about 1 km). You use Occult for Stealth and Notice while you're out. Your body is helpless and *Impeded* while you're out. Returning costs 1 Pneuma.
2a	**Feedback**	Through a speaker, lamp or screen in the target's scene, Attack with Occult, inflicting mental statuses (*terrified*, *dazed*) even on vampires.
2b	**Read What It Saw**	Ask an old work in reach 2 free Discover questions about what it saw or heard (a door's record of hands, a lens's memory), or speak through it to a bled or frightened person and Restore their fear statuses.
3a	**Long Wire**	Your range becomes a day's ride along working relays, and you can bring one willing ally's senses with you while they touch you.
3b	★ **Take the Hand**	Once per scene, take hold of one old-world machine in reach that can move (a guardian, a lift, a turret, a loader) and Fight with it. It uses your skills, and harm to it comes out of your **Pneuma** pool, not physical statuses.

11. Keeps the Old Faith

> *Crosses don't burn anything, whatever the stories say. But the rites are older than anyone can explain, the faithful stand together, and some vampires still believe. You keep the old ways anyway.*

- **Power tags:** *the faithful follow me*, *prayer steadies me*
- **Weakness tag:** *bound by the old laws* (you can't refuse sanctuary or lie under oath)
- **PC link:** "[PC] doesn't believe, but they carry the cross I gave them."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Holy Symbol**	Your cross creates *Warded* for 1 Power against any vampire who *believes the old stories* (Frontier Rules §8.1). Against other vampires it does nothing, but you and allies who can see it gain +1 Pneuma Edge against fear.
2a	**Consecrate**	In a scene of prayer, bless water or blades. The old rites call for silver in the water: blessed water and blades count as *silvered* (Frontier Rules §8.1) for the mission.
2b	**Last Rites**	Once per scene, every ally who can hear your prayer restores 2 Pneuma, and Resists fear with Edge +1 until the scene ends.
3a	**Faith Unbroken**	When you Resist fear, Presence or despair with Pneuma, the cost is **0 on a highest die of 5+**.
3b	★ **Holy Ground**	Once per session, sanctify a place: create the Truth *Holy Ground* for the scene. Believers can't enter without defying a compel, and every vampire Woe spend there costs **+1** while the faithful stand together.

7. Village Focuses

12. Heals the Bled

> *You've spent years fighting blood loss: transfusions, broth and iron, and nights by the bedside.*

- **Power tags:** *the bled trust me*, *knows every stage of blood loss*
- **Weakness tag:** *can't abandon a patient*
- **PC link:** "I saved [PC] when they were bled white. They don't remember it."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Blood Specialist**	When you treat *Bled*, you also learn how the blood was taken and roughly how much. Your patients can't gain more than 1 Bled tier per night.
2a	**Steady the Donor**	Patients you've treated in the last day Resist fear and Presence with **Edge +1**.
2b	**Bloodwork**	From a sample of a vampire's blood, learn one of its weakness tags (a free Discover).
3a	**Hold the Line**	While under your care, a patient's *Bled* can't rise above **tier 4**.
3b	★ **Give of Yourself**	Once per session, transfuse your own blood: remove *Bled* entirely from one patient (any tier up to 5). You take *Bled-2*.

13. Holds the Line Until Dawn

> *All you have to do is survive the night. You've done it before.*

- **Power tags:** *stubborn as stone*, *I've seen the sun come up before*
- **Weakness tag:** *won't retreat*
- **PC link:** "[PC] and I held a door together once, all night. Neither of us talks about it."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Buy Time**	Once per night, any successful roll that delays the enemy also ticks the **Dawn clock** by 1.
2a	**First Light**	When the scene becomes **Dawn**, every ally restores 3 points to one pool.
2b	**Stand Fast**	At night, while defending a place or a person, your Edge counts as **1 higher** when you Resist.
3a	**Light a Fire**	Once per session, create *False Dawn* for one exchange with flares, fire, or faith, without spending Power.
3b	★ **Not Until the Sun Rises**	Once per night, you can't be Taken Out until Dawn. When Dawn comes, take *Weary* and a tier-4 physical status.

14. Forges Weapons Against the Night

> *Stakes that don't splinter, bolts that fly true, blades that can cut a vampire's neck. Every Hunter in the region knows your mark.*

- **Power tags:** *my stakes never break*, *forge and lathe*
- **Weakness tag:** *my weapons carry my mark* (a vampire can trace them back to you)
- **PC link:** "I made [PC]'s weapon. I want it back in one piece."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Hunter's Smith**	In the Players' Turn, spend 1 Check to either give one weapon an extra quality, or arm the party with fine stakes (every ally has a *stake* tag for the mission, 0 load).
2a	**Silvered and Blessed**	Weapons you make count as *silvered*, or as beheading (a killing method) if they're blades.
2b	**Field Armourer**	In a short rest, repair *damaged* armour and broken weapons. Your allies' armour absorbs a tier-4+ hit once per mission without being damaged.
3a	**Masterwork**	One weapon you make (choose its owner) may add **+1 above the normal +2 tag cap (maximum +3)**.
3b	★ **Old-World Steel**	Run a downtime clock (8 segments) to make a weapon artifact equal to an Old-World Longsword (Frontier Rules §9.2). Its quirk is *my weapons carry my mark*.

8. Frontier Focuses

15. Rides a Cyborg Horse

> *Your horse is half-machine, tireless, and as stubborn as you. You've crossed deserts that kill everything else.*

- **Power tags:** *my horse knows the way*, *faster than anything on the Frontier*
- **Weakness tag:** *can't leave the horse behind*
- **PC link:** "[PC] is the only other person my horse will carry."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Cyborg Steed**	You own a cyborg horse (vehicle, 0 load) with tags *never tires* and *armoured flank*. Once per scene, it gives free Help on a Ride, Frontier, or Fight roll.
2a	**The Charge**	In the first exchange of a mounted Fight, your Attacks inflict **+1 tier**.
2b	**Upgraded**	Your horse gains one Implant from the Cyborg Hunter list (Frontier Playbooks §8.1).
3a	**Never Caught**	In Chases, your side's Disposition is **+3**, and changing your scripted action costs 1 Momentum.
3b	★ **Bond of Steel**	Your horse becomes a companion that acts on its own in conflicts (one action per exchange, *+1 Attack*), takes its own statuses, and can't be Taken Out by minions.

16. Leaves No Name Behind

> *You ride in, do what needs doing, and ride out. People remember the stranger, not the name.*

- **Power tags:** *nobody knows where I came from*, *gone by morning*
- **Weakness tag:** *no one to call a friend*
- **PC link:** "[PC] is the only one who knows my real name."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**The Stranger**	Once in each new town, ask a free Discover: people tell strangers things they'd never tell their neighbours. Bad reputation tags can't be used against you in a town you've never visited.
2a	**Ride Out at Dawn**	Once per session, leave a town or a scene with no pursuit, as long as no one is holding you.
2b	**The Stranger's Look**	You may use **Pneuma** for Intimidate Effort. Mobs and minions hesitate: a successful Intimidate makes them hold off for a scene.
3a	**Many Names**	Create an alias as a power tag. Deceive rolls using the alias are one step easier.
3b	★ **Legend Without a Name**	Rumours of you become a **Region Truth** (*"A stranger rides the Frontier"*). Once per session, your opposition hesitates: their Disposition starts **−2** in the first conflict.

17. Rides With Family

> *Brothers, sisters, cousins: a Hunter clan that rides together, fights together, and splits every bounty.*

- **Power tags:** *blood is thicker*, *we fight as one*
- **Weakness tag:** *family comes first*
- **PC link:** "[PC] is my kin, by blood or by choice."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Family Tactics**	When you Help your kin PC (from your PC link), or they Help you, the Help costs **0** pool points.
2a	**Kin Rider**	An NPC sibling or cousin rides with you: a minion group of one with 2 power tags and 1 weakness.
2b	**Shared Spirit**	In conflicts, each kin on your side (PC or NPC) adds **+1 Disposition**.

Tier	Ability	Effect
3a	**Avenge My Kin**	When a kin is Taken Out, gain a free bonus die on every roll against whoever did it until the scene ends.
3b	★ **The Family Name**	Your clan is a **Region Truth** (*"Nobody crosses the [name] clan"*). Once per session, call on the clan: a warband (Generic Focuses *Warband*) joins you for one mission.

9. Household Focuses

18. Once Served a Household

> *You were a household servant, a steward, a chosen companion, or a vampire's ward. You got out. The house hasn't forgotten.*

- **Power tags:** *knows household etiquette*, *they still think I'm theirs*
- **Weakness tag:** *the house still has a claim on me*
- **PC link:** "[PC] helped me escape the estate, and I never repaid them."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Inside Knowledge**	Once per scene in any estate of your former house, ask a free Discover. Once per session, ask a free Discover about any vampire's habits.
2a	**Pass as a Servant**	In vampire estates, servants and guardian machines ignore you unless you act against them, or a vampire looks at you directly.
2b	**Old Loyalties**	Once per session, a former fellow servant helps you: a secret passage, a warning, a key, or a hiding place.
3a	**The Master's Secrets**	You know one weakness of your former master. Upgrading it into a killing method costs **1 Power**.
3b	★ **Turncoat's Key**	Once per session, open any door or switch off any defence in an estate of your former house, without a roll.

19. Reads the Ruins of History

> *You study the old world, the rise of the Kept, and the founders whose names are still on the doors. Most of it is lost. Some of it isn't.*

- **Power tags:** *reads the old script*, *knows the old wars*
- **Weakness tag:** *lost in the past*
- **PC link:** "[PC] found the book that started my obsession."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Archive Mind**	Once per scene, ask a free Discover with Old Lore about a place, a vampire house, or an ancient device.
2a	**Decipher**	Science rolls to use or read old-world machines are **one step easier** when you can study the controls.
2b	**Genealogist**	When you learn a vampire's name, you also learn its house, its rivals, and one weakness tag.
3a	**History Repeats**	Once per session, create a **Site Truth** from history: a forgotten passage, a buried weapon, an old treaty a vampire must honour.
3b	★ **The Ancestor's Notes**	Once per session, with GM approval, reveal an ancient secret as a **Region or Campaign Truth**: a weakness shared by a whole bloodline, a hidden estate, the reason a vampire won't die.

20. Loves What It Should Hate

> *A vampire, a dhampir, a retainer, a monster. You love them anyway, and both worlds will make you pay for it.*

- **Power tags:** *love makes me brave*, *they listen to me*
- **Weakness tag:** *torn between two worlds*
- **PC link:** "[PC] is the only one who knows about us."

Tier	Ability	Effect
1	**Beloved**	Create your beloved with the GM: a creature of the night with 2 power tags and 1 weakness. They won't harm you directly. Once per session, they give you information or help.
2a	**Speak for Them**	In Argument and Negotiation conflicts with creatures of the night, your side's Disposition is **+2**.
2b	**For Their Sake**	When your beloved is threatened, gain a free bonus die on your next roll to protect them.
3a	**Bridge Between Worlds**	Once per session, broker a truce between humans and creatures of the night for one night. Neither side attacks unless the other breaks it.
3b	★ **Love Over Death**	Once per session, you or your beloved take a consequence meant for the other, and **ignore it entirely**. The GM gains 2 Woe.

10. Design Notes

- **Dhampir as a Focus** lets any playbook carry afflicted blood: a dhampir Sellsword is the classic Hunter, but a dhampir Frontier Doctor or Broker plays very differently. The dhampir's edge is no longer raw power but access and information: reading blood, opening doors tied to her mother's line, and being wanted by people who matter. Sunlight Syndrome and the Thirst remain the price. *Knows How They Die* is offered for tables that want a fighter. Use the table options if it outshines other Focuses.
- **Overlaps with playbooks:** *Heals the Bled* stacks with the Frontier Doctor's *Treat the Bled*, and *Holds the Line Until Dawn* stacks with the Warden. Both stacks are intended specialist builds; none of them reduce the same Power cost twice.
- **Vampire-specific Focuses** (*Hunts the Kept*, *Seeks Revenge on a Vampire*) rely on killing strikes. If a campaign has few vampires, steer players toward *Hunts the Beasts of the Frontier* or *Collects the Bounty*.
- **Sends the Mind Abroad** works through an old-world implant and the relays around it, not a spirit. It follows the same open-sky rule as Carries a Passenger, and the same advice on placing relays applies.
- **Carries a Passenger** is an Old-World Focus. The Passenger is a voice relayed from a fixed old-world site, so it has a range; out of range the Focus does nothing except under open sky, where the moving lights give it a 1-in-3 chance each scene. On long journeys, place working relays often enough that the player isn't left without their Focus for whole sessions.
- ★ **options** are all at Tier 3, as in *Generic Focuses*, so a character can always choose a path that keeps their Refresh.
- **Tag-cap exceptions** (Bears an Old-World Relic — The Relic Awakens; Forges Weapons Against the Night — Masterwork): aligned with the **Generic Focuses §9.2** fix — both now add **+1 above the normal +2 cap (maximum +3)** instead of ignoring it outright.

APPENDIX

Quick Reference

The core procedures on one spread, for the table and the screen. Full rules are in Chapter II.

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The Roll

2d12 + Skill + Modifiers vs. Difficulty. Skill +0 to +4. Power tags +1 each, **maximum +2 per roll** (tag-cap exceptions: maximum +3). Weakness tags −1 each, no cap. Statuses ± tier. Truths shift Difficulty, not the roll (Core Rules §2.1).

Difficulty

Difficulty	Target
Routine	No roll
Easy	12
Standard	15
Hard	18
Formidable	21
Heroic	24

Outcomes

Result	Outcome
Meet the target	**Success**: 1 Power, +1 per full 3 over
Miss by 1–3	**Success at a Cost**: 1 Power, and the GM adds a consequence or gains 1 Woe (player's choice)
Miss by 4+	**Failure**: the GM makes a move and gains 1 Woe

Unspent Power becomes **Momentum** (party pool, max 6).

Doubles (Twists)

If the two kept dice match: on a success, a **Critical** (+1 Power and a flourish). On a failure or cost, a **Complication** (GM gains 2 Woe or adds a complication now). **Double 12s** always succeed with +2 Power. **Double 1s** always bring a complication.

Bonus Dice

Keep the best two dice; maximum +2 bonus dice.

Source	Cost
Effort	3 − Edge from the pool (min 0); or buy +1 Power after a success
Momentum	1 for the first die, 2 for the second
Woe	Give the GM 1 Woe per die
Help	An ally spends 1 pool point and shares the risk

Resist (Core Rules §6)

Roll 2d12, take the **highest die**, and pay the cost minus Edge: **12** costs 0 and clears a tier-1 status · **9–11** costs 1 · **5–8** costs 2 · **1–4** costs 3. This reduces the status by 2 tiers.

Running Dry (Core Rules §6.1–6.3)

A cost that empties a pool, or is more than what's left in it, imposes a running-dry status at **tier 1 + overrun** (overrun = cost − points left). Only Resistance and imposed costs can overrun; a cost of 0 never runs dry. The status stacks normally. At **tier 6** you are Taken Out within its scope and gain **one Scar** (at most one per event). The pool and the status recover separately: 2 recovery points remove 1 depletion tier.

Damage Cycle (Core Rules §6, §10)

Each side has **one shared Disposition** total, reduced at setup by the opponent's **Superiority** (0–3, minimum 1); Attacks and Feints remove it and nothing else, and Defend restores it. A side loses at 0 or when no participant can continue. **Injury trade:** one per Attack or Feint, once per conflict, accept a tier 2/3/4 injury to cancel 1/2/3 loss; it can't be Resisted. Treatment removes at most 1 tier of a lasting injury until healing time does. Tier-6 life-threatening harm

Rest and Recovery

Rest	Time	Recovery
1st	A few seconds; 1 action mid-encounter	1d6
2nd	10 minutes	1d8
3rd	1 hour	1d10
4th	10 hours (overnight)	All pools full

Divide the roll among Sōma, Akmē, Psychē and Pneuma however you like. Edge does not apply. **Hardened** (one-time Advance) raises each die one size.

makes you **Dying**: 3-segment clock, Medicine vs. Hard 18 to stabilise. Compromise statuses are tier 2/3/4.

Day and Night

- **Day:** direct sun gives vampires and dhampirs *Sun-Sick* (Frontier Rules §7.1). Vampires keep indoors but aren't helpless.
- **Dusk:** the GM gains +2 Woe. Vampires come out.
- **Night:** vampires and dhampirs ignore darkness. A scene at night with a vampire present adds +1 Woe at the start.
- **Dawn:** a vampire still in direct light at the end of the scene gains *Sun-Sick* at tier 2 at once.
- **Hard to Kill:** a vampire's physical statuses can't go above tier 5 without a **killing method**: beheading, or sustained fire on a broken vampire (Frontier Rules §5.2, §8.1).